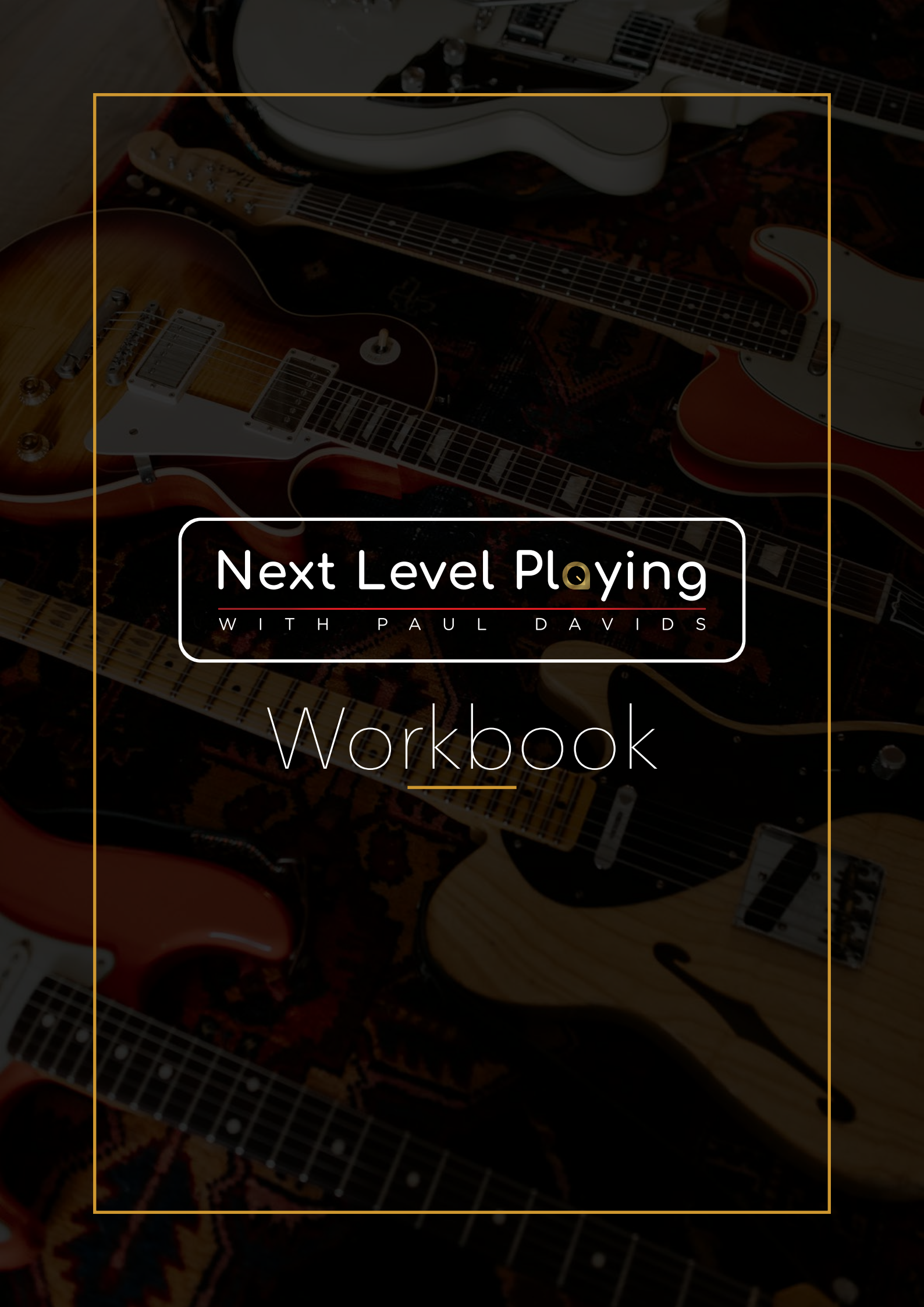


Next Level Playing

WITH PAUL DAVIDS

Workbook

Level 1

1. Speed and versatility: The fretboard
2. Chords: Major and minor barre chords
3. Lead: Major scales in 3 positions
4. Practical theory: Chord degrees
5. Improvisation: Key of C
6. Solo: “Optimistic Jam”
Advancing to Level 2
Lead: Major scales in 3 positions

Level 2

1. Chords: Triads
2. Lead: Pentatonic scales
3. Improvisation: Chords and pentatonic scales
4. Technique: Bending
5. Solo: “Feeling Blue in B Minor”
Advancing to Level 3

Level 3

1. Chords: 7th chords
2. Speed and versatility: Pentatonic scales
3. Practical theory: Chord progressions
4. Lead: Minor scales
5. Solo: “Aeolian Dream”
Advancing to Level 4

Level 4

1. Chords: Triads on the top 3 strings
2. Speed and versatility: Scales
3. Improvisation: How to embellish chords
4. Lead: Harmonic minor scales
5. Solo: “Harmonic Patterns in E Minor”
Advancing to Level 5

Level 5

1. Technique: Picking
2. Technique: Fretting chords
3. Lead: Major and minor arpeggios
4. Chords: Dm7, G7
5. Practical theory: Dorian mode
6. Solo: “Dazzling Dorian Funk!”
Advancing to Level 6

Level 6

1. Speed and versatility: Diagonal pentatonic scales
2. Chords: Embellishments
3. Practical theory: The CAGED system
4. Lead: Target notes
5. Solo: “Target Blues in Am”
Advancing to Level 7

Level 7

1. Chords: Twelve-bar blues
2. Lead: Mixolydian scales
3. Improvisation: Twelve-bar blues
4. Chords: Extended chords
5. Solo: “Everything Is Connected”

1. Speed and versatility: The fretboard

Ways to find notes quickly anywhere on the fretboard

Guitar terms

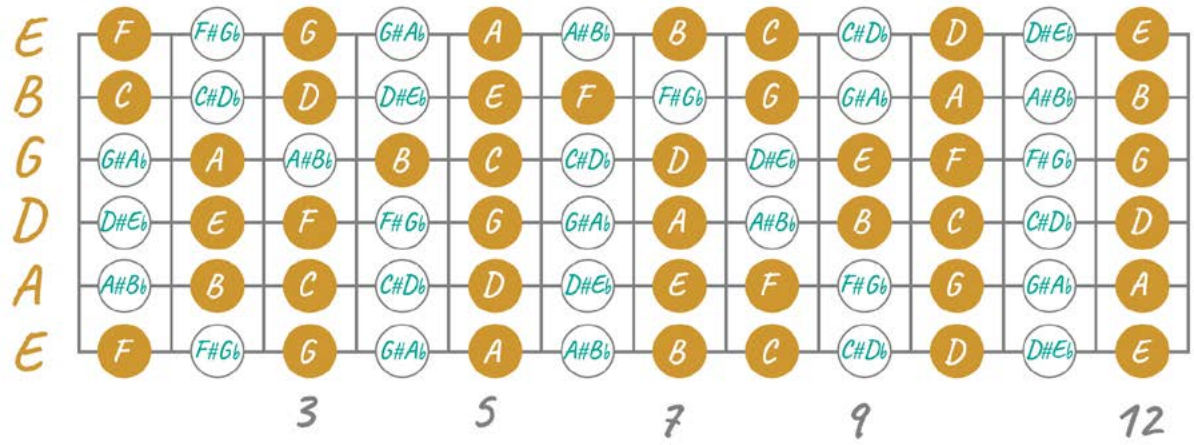
 # Sharp: One fret up, it raises a note by a semitone (a half step)

♭ Flat: One fret down, it lowers the note by a semitone (a half step)

Octave: An interval of 8 notes of a musical scale that shares notes of the same name – e.g., from a low C to a high C in the C major scale

The musical alphabet - a recap

There are 12 notes in Western music, but only 7 letters are used to name them: A, B, C, D, E, F, G. To complete the 12, we use sharps (#) or flats (♭).



Tips for navigating the fretboard

1. Go 5 frets, 1 string down to find the same note. The exception is between the B and G string, when you count 4 frets.
2. There are 12 frets between the lowest and highest notes of an octave.
3. Go 7 frets, 1 string up to find the lowest and highest notes of an octave. The exception is between the G and B strings, when you count 8 frets.

Goal

To be able to name a note at any random location on the fretboard within 5 seconds

Advanced goal

To be able to name a note at any random location on the fretboard within 2 seconds

Exercises

1.1.1 Learn strategic frets

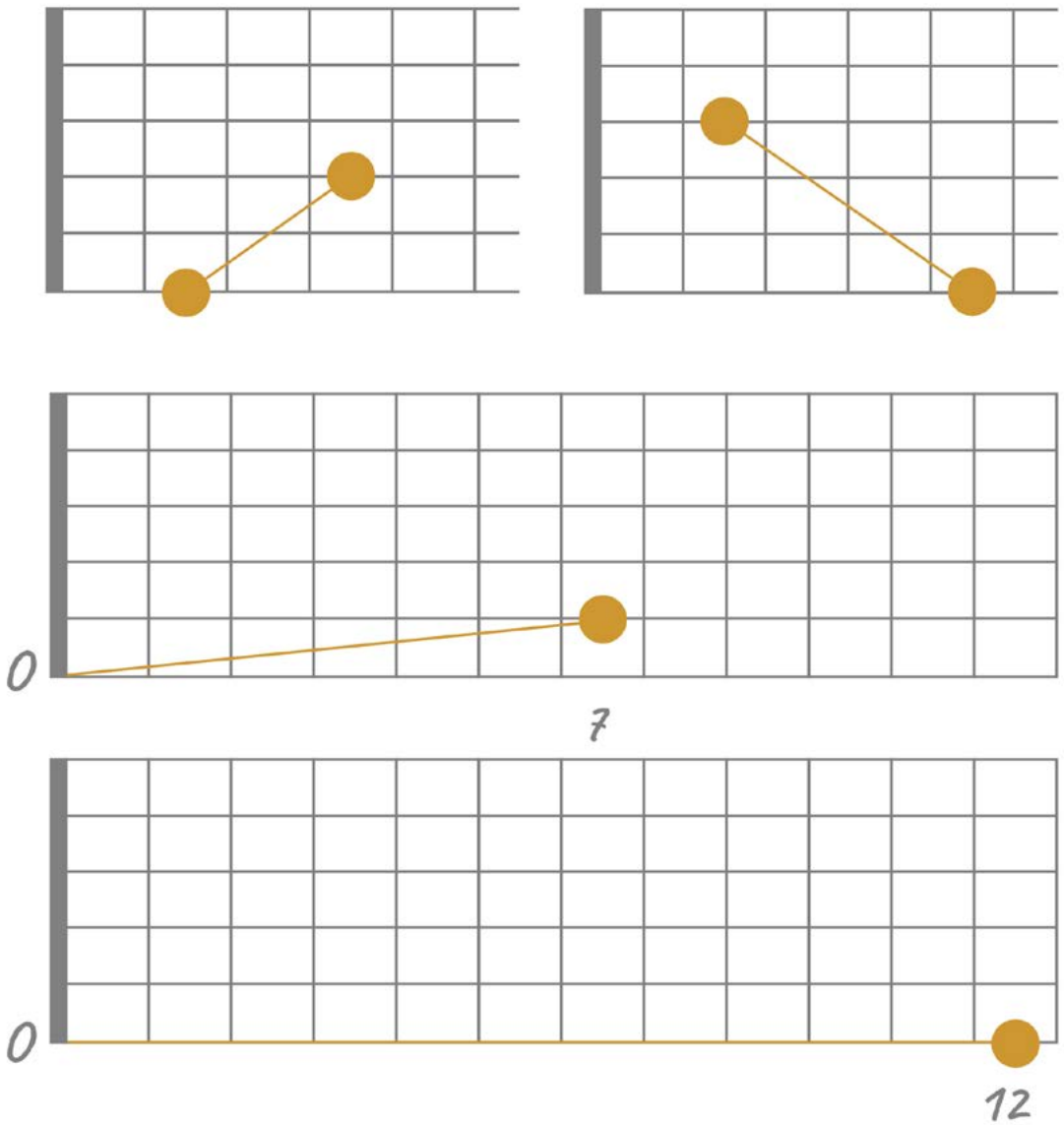
The aim of this exercise is to know all the notes on 4 frets, which you can use as reference points for counting up or down to quickly find other notes. Once you can name the notes on a fret from memory, move on to the next fret. My suggestion is to learn these frets in this order:

Fret 5
Fret 7
Fret 3
Fret 10

1.1.2 Learn octave shapes

Take time to practice these octave shapes and memorize them. Then you can use your knowledge to find your way quickly around the fretboard.

Octave Shapes



2. Chords: Major and minor barre chords

Tips for playing barre chords

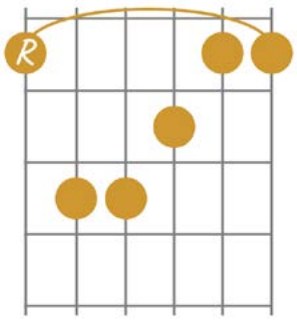
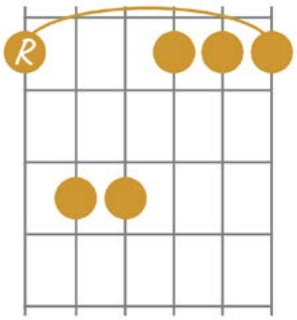
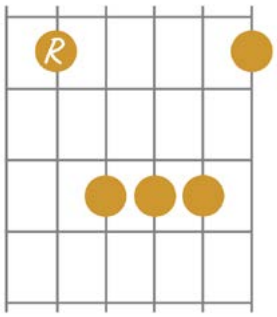
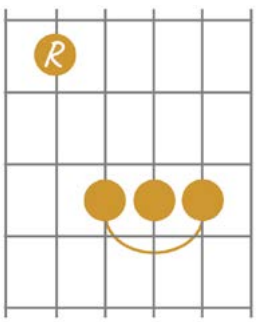
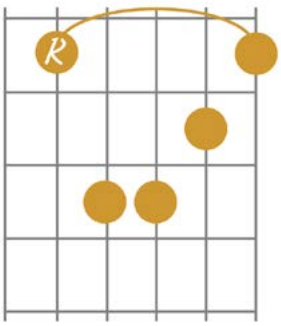
Guitar terms

Root note: The first note of a chord – e.g., the root note of E major is E

Technique

- Place your thumb on the back of the neck.
- Keep your index finger straight.
- Maintain a gentle curve in your wrist.
- Apply moderate pressure.

Movable chord shapes

Root Note	Major Chord	Minor Chord
On string 6 (low E)		
On string 5 (A)	 OR 	

Goal

Within 1 second locate major or minor chords with the root on the 6th or 5th string, as shown in the video

Note: If you're absolutely new to this, it can take some time before these shapes become second nature.

Exercises

1.2.1 Know the major barre chords

Make some time in your regular practice sessions to play the following chords with the root on the 6th and 5th string. Use the diagrams at first if you need to. When you begin to feel more confident, start playing them from memory.

C
G
D
A
E
B
F#
C#

1.2.2 Know the minor barre chords

Make some time in your regular practice sessions to play the following chords with the root on the 6th and 5th string. Use the diagrams at first if you need to. When you begin to feel more confident, start playing them from memory.

C minor
G minor
D minor
A minor
E minor
B minor
F# minor
C# minor

3. Lead: Major scales in 3 positions

Increase your versatility as a player by knowing major scales

Guitar terms

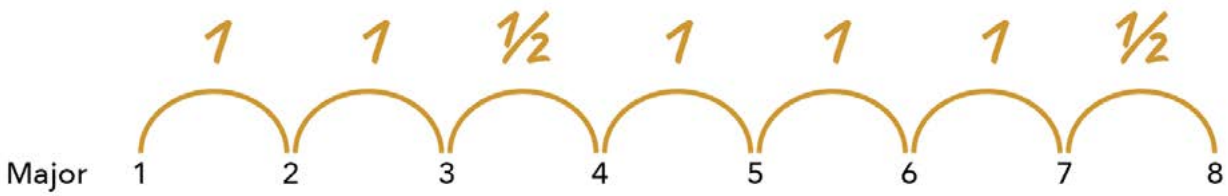
Function: The relation of a note, scale degree, or a chord to the tonal center (or key) of a song. Functions are expressed with numbers and can be flattened or sharpened.

Interval: The distance between the pitch of one note and another note

The major scale - a recap

Starting from the root note, this is the sequence of intervals between the notes in a major scale:

Whole tone (2 frets)
Whole tone (2 frets)
Semitone (1 fret)
Whole tone (2 frets)
Whole tone (2 frets)
Whole tone (2 frets)
Semitone (1 fret)



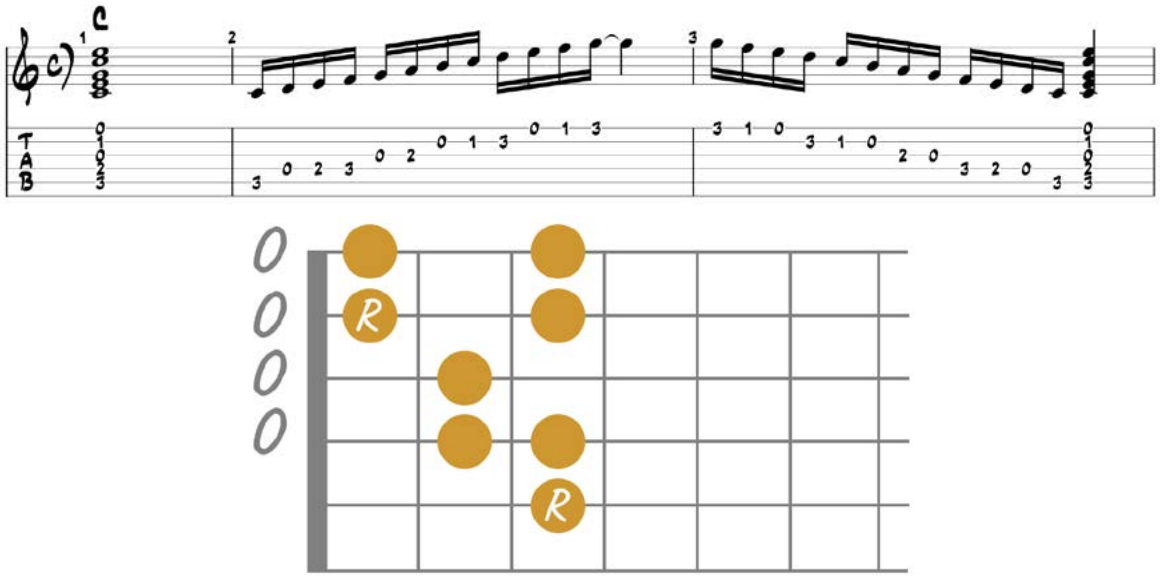
Goal

To play from memory the C major scale in 3 locations on the fretboard

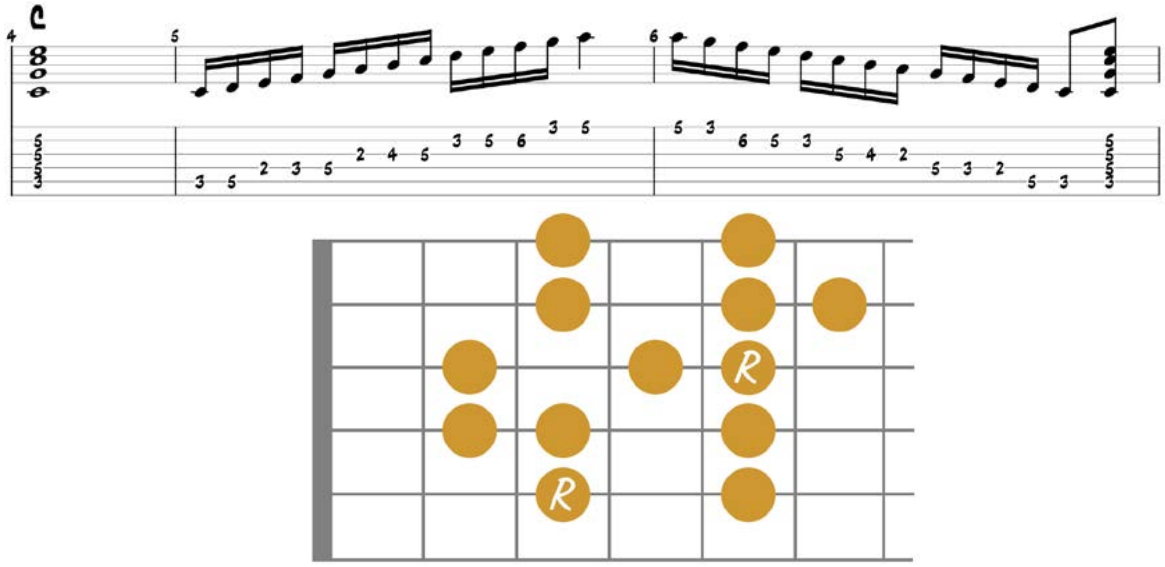
Exercises

These exercises are great to play every time you pick up the guitar, as a warmup.

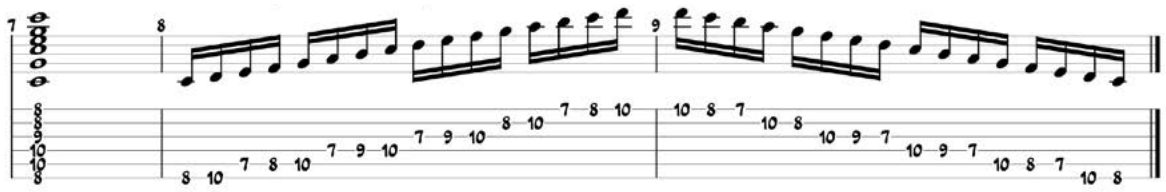
1.3.1 Open chord and C major scale

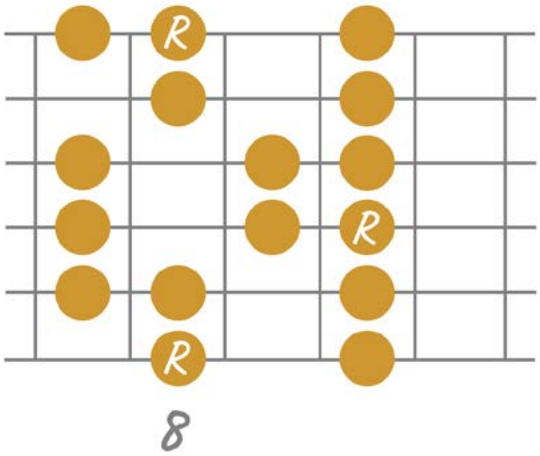


1.3.2 Barre chord and C major scale, root on 5th string



1.3.3 Barre chord and C major scale, root on 6th string





4. Practical theory: Chord degrees

How chords and scales relate to the key – and what that means for your playing

Guitar terms

Chord progression: The sequence of chord degrees played in a song

Key: The group of pitches (the scale) that is used in a song

Chord choices

Chord degrees are named using these Roman numerals: I, ii, iii, IV, V, vi, vii.

The I, IV, and V are major chords. The ii, iii, and vi are minor chords.

Understanding how the scale and the chords in a key relate to each other can help you choose chords and scales to play in a particular key.

Functions	Notes (C major scale)	Degrees	Chords
1	C	I	C major
2	D	ii	D minor
3	E	iii	E minor
4	F	IV	F major
5	G	V	G major
6	A	vi	A minor
7	B	vii	B diminished*

*We won't be covering the vii degree in this course.

Goal

Start to recognize the chord degrees.
Feel comfortable playing in different keys. (The most seen major keys are: C – G – D – A – E.)

Exercises

1.4.1 Common chord progressions

Practice playing the following chord progressions:

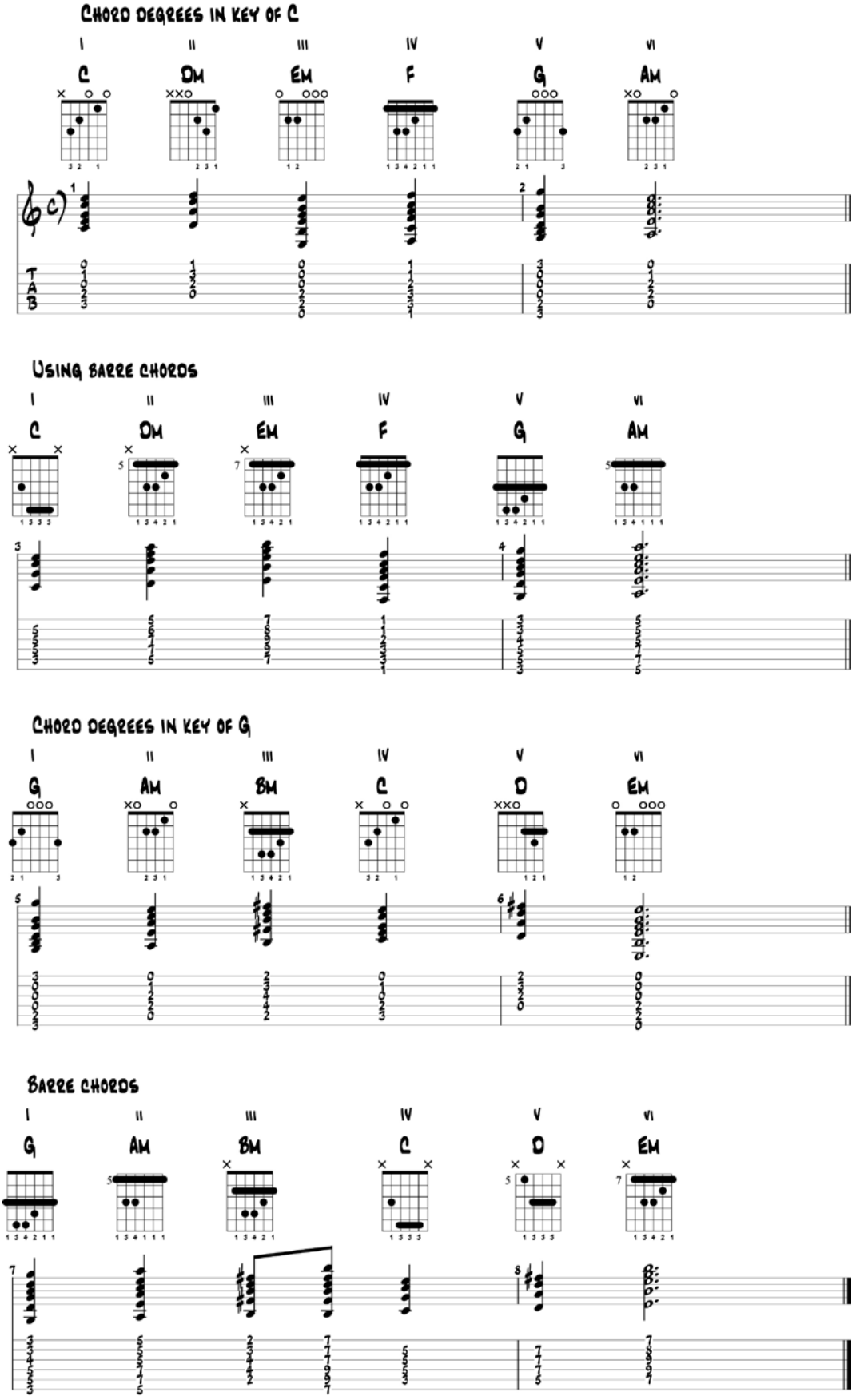
Key of G: I – vi – IV – V
Key of C: vi – IV – I – V
Key of G: V – IV – I – I
Key of D: I – IV – V – I

Additionally, you can try to make a few chord progressions yourself.

1.4.2 Analyze songs

Take some songs you already know and analyze them to find the chord degrees.

Exercise 1.4.1 Common chord progressions



5. Improvisation: Key of C

Essentials for getting better at improvising

Tips

- Play the guitar as if you're speaking. Use short sentences. Stop once in a while to breathe.
- Use repetition.
- Play licks you've memorized from solos by your favorite guitarists.
- Study theory.
- Practice improvising.

Advanced tips

- Record yourself and listen back to hear the bigger story in your guitar solos.
- Finish your licks on a target note from the chord you're playing over.

Goal

To gain confidence improvising with notes from the C major scale

Exercise

1.5.1 Improvisation in the key of C

Improvise over the backing track. It uses the C chord and the F chord. In the key of C, the C chord is the I chord, and the F chord is the IV chord. So we call it a "I–IV (one-four) progression in the key of C." If you use notes from the C major scale in your improvisation, they will sound great with these chords.

6. Solo: "Optimistic Jam"

Play over a backing track using the skills you've learned

Guitar terms

Bend: Push a string across the fretboard to make it tighter and raise the pitch of the note

BPM: Beats per minute; a measure of the speed a song is played at

Double stop: Two notes played at the same time

Hammer-on: To play a string open and then place your finger on the string to play a higher note without needing to pick again

Pull-off: To lift your finger off the fretboard so you can play a lower note on the same string without picking again

Staccato: A style of playing where notes are short and clearly defined

Vibrato: Repeatedly and quickly bending a note to give character to the sound

Goal

To nail this solo over the slower backing track

Advanced goal

To nail this solo over the faster backing track by the end of the course

Exercise

1.6.1 Solo: "Optimistic Jam"

Practice the solo with the backing track. It becomes more difficult as the song progresses, so play what you can. Then practice until you can play the whole solo over the backing track.

If you can play the solo well over the slower BPM backing track, move on to the regular speed.

You don't need to be able to play the solo perfectly before moving on to the next level of the course. Keep practicing it if you need to, even after you've finished the rest of the course. I made it pretty challenging so you have something to work toward.

Exercise 1.6.1 Solo: "Optimistic Jam"

Advancing to Level 2

This course becomes progressively more challenging as you build your skills. I designed it so you can advance at your own pace, to suit your learning style and your priorities as a guitarist.

To help you decide if you're ready to move on, answer the questions below.

You don't need to get everything right before you move forward. There are no guitar police looking over your shoulder! But I really hope you'll spend 10 minutes on this self-assessment so you know the areas where you need to practice more.

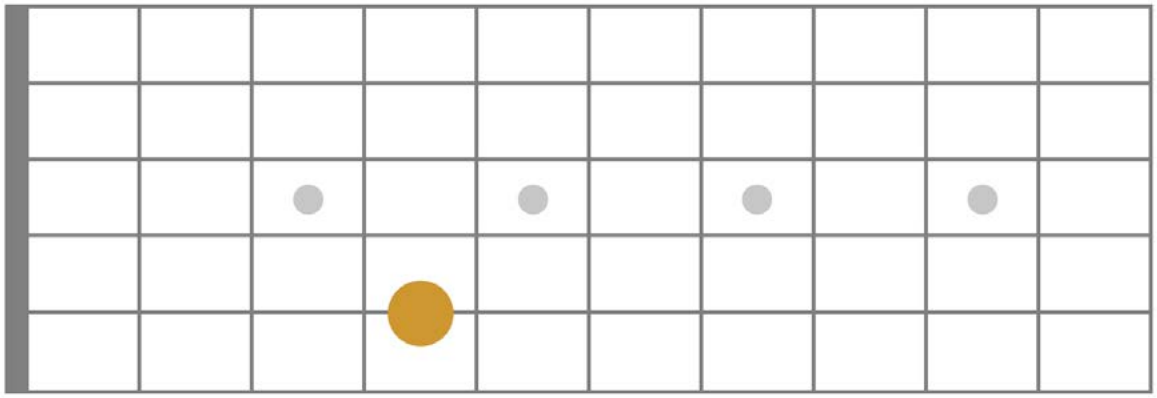
Level 1 Self test

Grab your guitar and a pen so you can assess the skills you've learned. For the answers, go to Advancing to Level 2 in the members area.

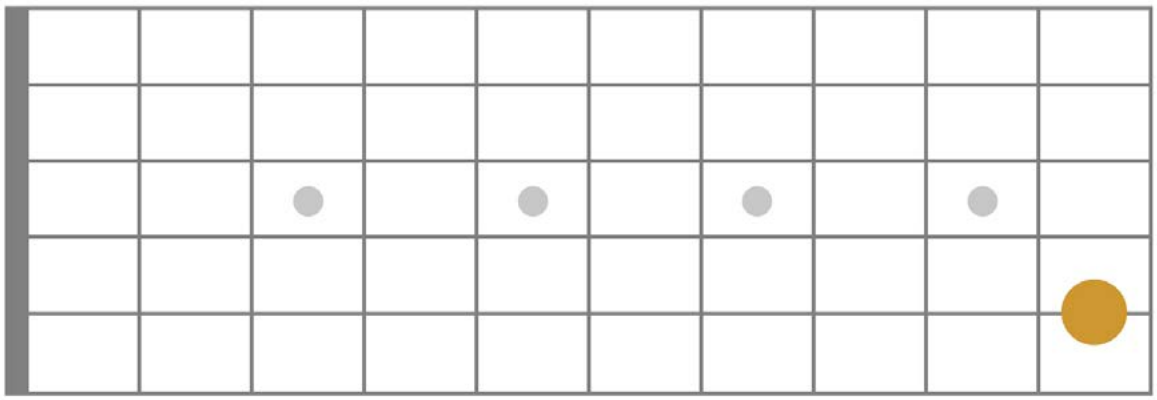
1. Name the notes

Can you name these notes without looking at a diagram?

1(a)



1(b)



2. Find the chords
Can you play these chords without looking at diagrams?

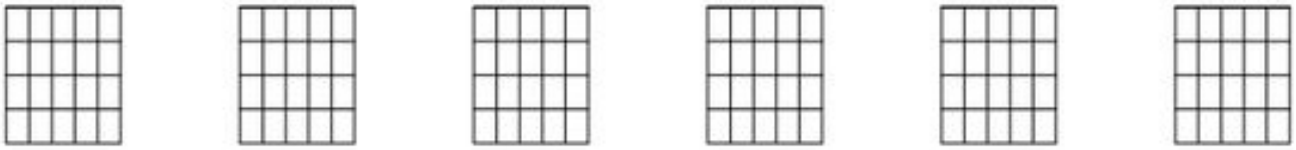
a) B
b) F# minor

3. Play a scale
Without looking at the tabs, can you play the C major scale in at least one of the positions in lesson 3, with a C chord before and after?

4. Play in key

a) What is the iii chord in the key of G?
b) Name two chords that will always sound good in the key of D.
c) Can you play a I – IV – vi – V progression in the key of A? (Hint: one of these will be a barre chord!)

5. Improvise and play solos
After playing with the backing tracks in lessons 5 and 6, do you feel more confident about improvising and playing solos?



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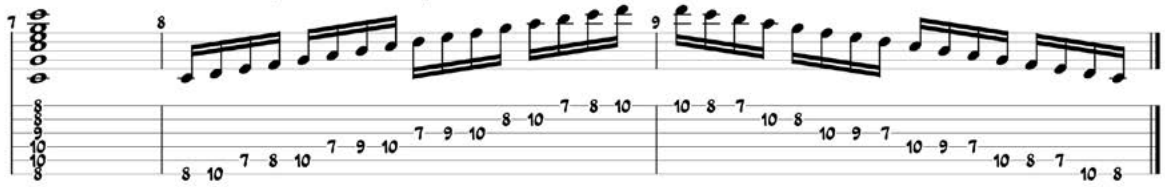
Lead: Major scales in 3 positions

1.3.1 Open chord and C major scale

1.3.2 Barre chord and C major scale, root on 5th string

1.3.3 Barre chord and C major scale, root on 6th string



1. Chords: Triads

Play major and minor chords wherever and however you want

Triads - a recap

- Any major triad consists of these notes in the scale: 1 – 3 – 5.
- Any minor triad consists of these notes in the scale: 1 – ♭3 – 5.
- You have the freedom to play the notes of a triad in any order you like.

Guitar terms

Triad: A chord made up of 3 unique notes

First inversion: When the lowest note of the triad is the major third (for a major chord) or a minor third (for a minor chord)

Second inversion: When the lowest note of the triad is the perfect fifth (the fifth note of the major scale)

Goal

To know the 3 positions of the triads on the top 3 strings, and preferably on the D, G, and B strings

Advanced goal

To know the triad positions on the A, D, and G strings
To know the triad positions on the E, A, and D strings

Exercise

2.1.1 More chord shapes

Practice the various chord shapes in the tabs by playing along with the backing track. Try out different shapes of the same chord throughout the track

Exercise 2.1.1 More chord shapes

2. Lead: Pentatonic scales

Unlock soloing skills with these essential scales

Guitar terms

Pentatonic scale: A scale made up of 5 unique notes

Relative keys: Keys that share the same notes but start on different notes

Notes in a pentatonic scale

Major pentatonic scales are made up of these notes (with 1 being the root note):

1 – 2 – 3 – 5 – 6

Minor pentatonic scales are made up of these notes (with 1 being the root note):

1 – ♭3 – 4 – 5 – ♭7

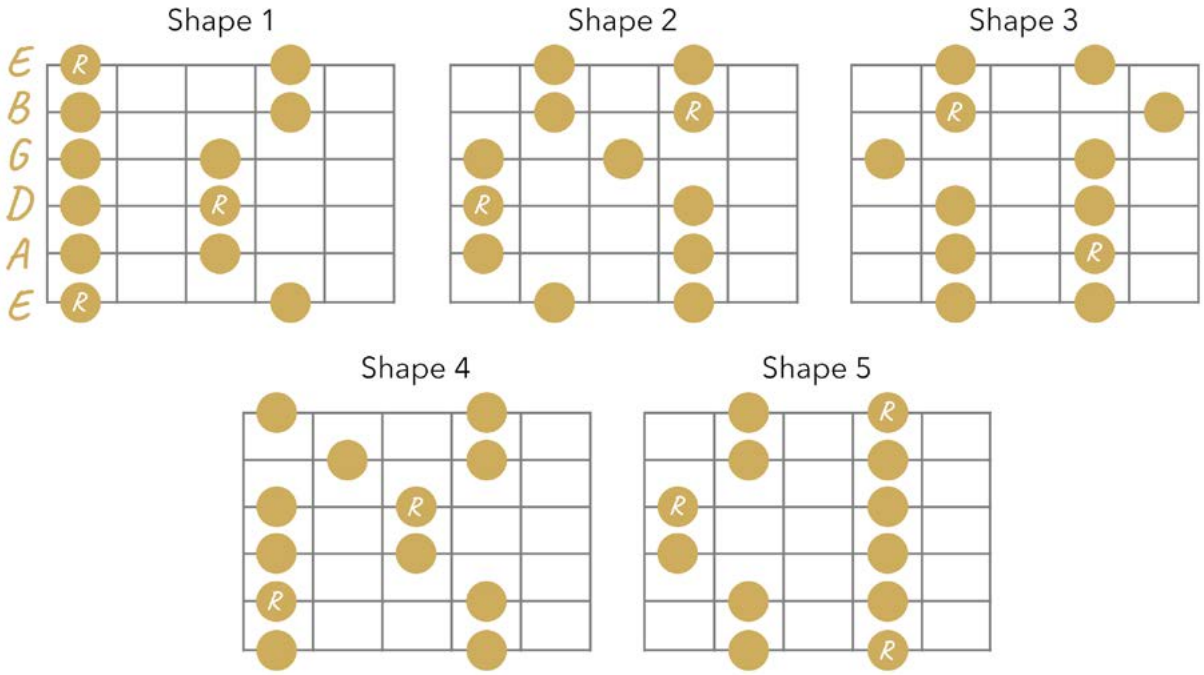
Goal

To know the major and minor pentatonic scales in at least two positions in any key

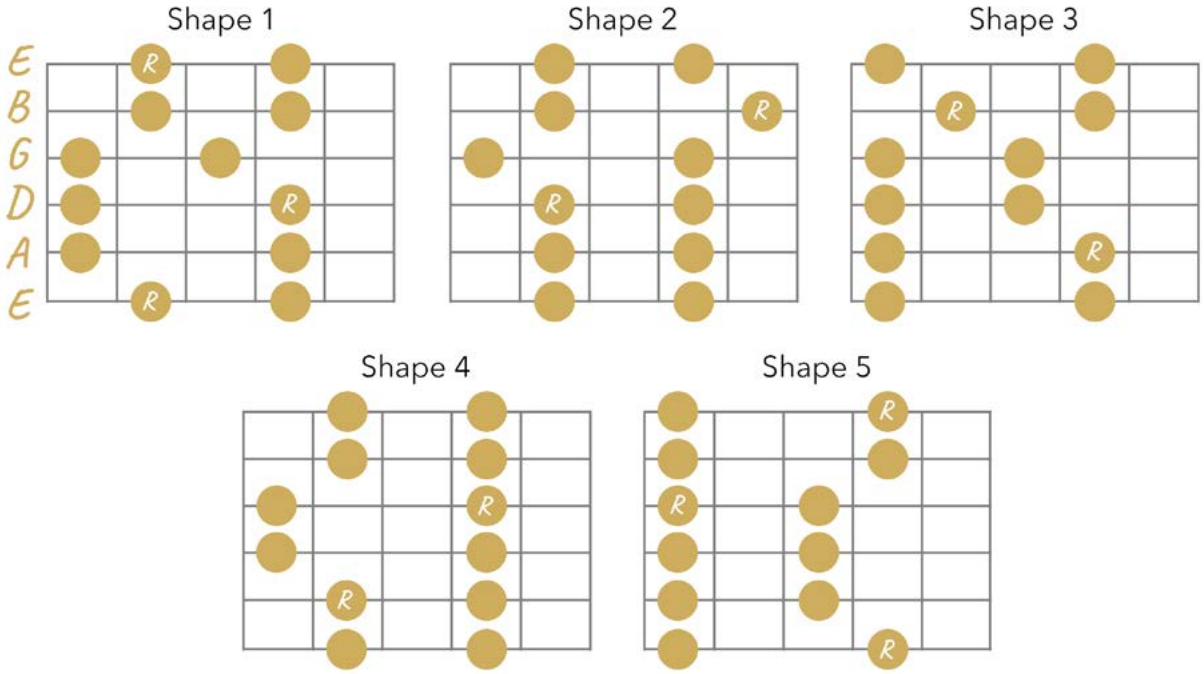
Exercises

Down below we see five minor shapes and five major shapes. These are movable, so the position always depends on the root of the scale (R). Do you notice that each minor shape has a major shape that is exactly the same? So if you're smart (and I know you are!), you just have to learn five shapes and you'll know them for both minor and major! Just remember that the root note changes.

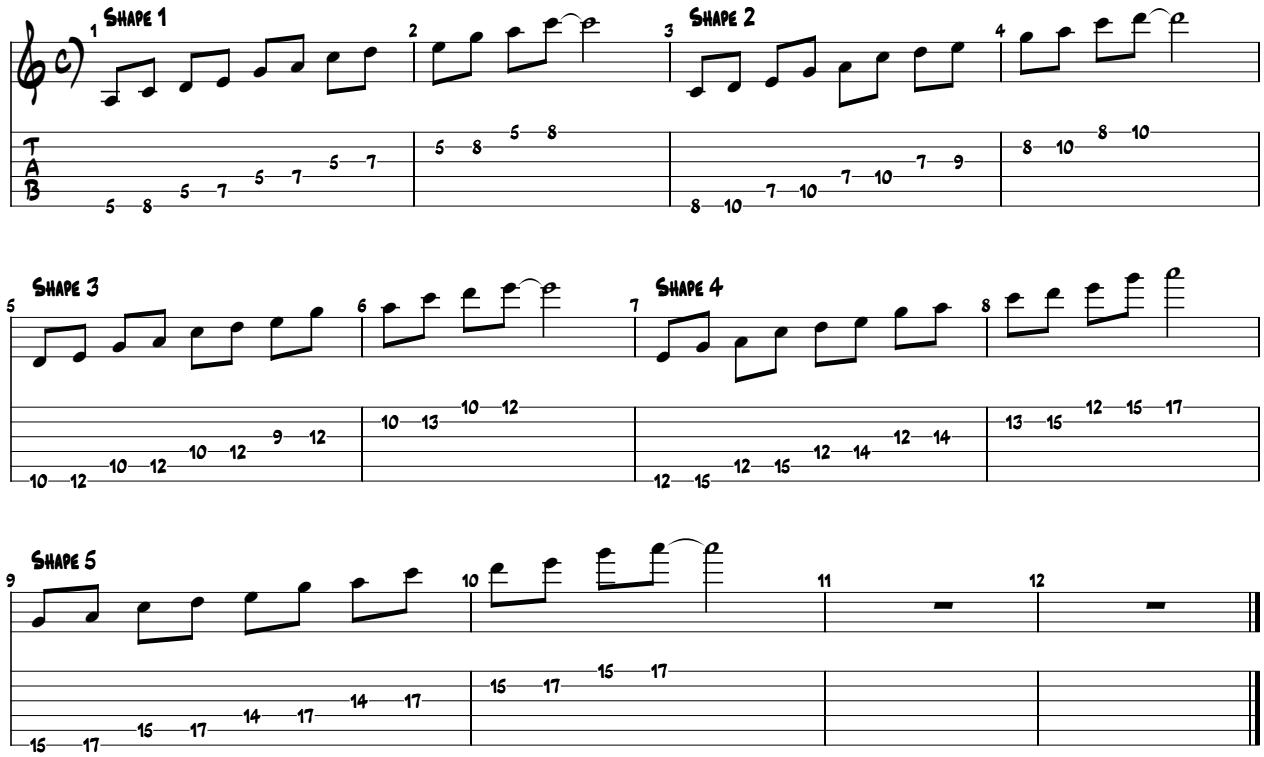
2.2.1 Minor pentatonic scale patterns



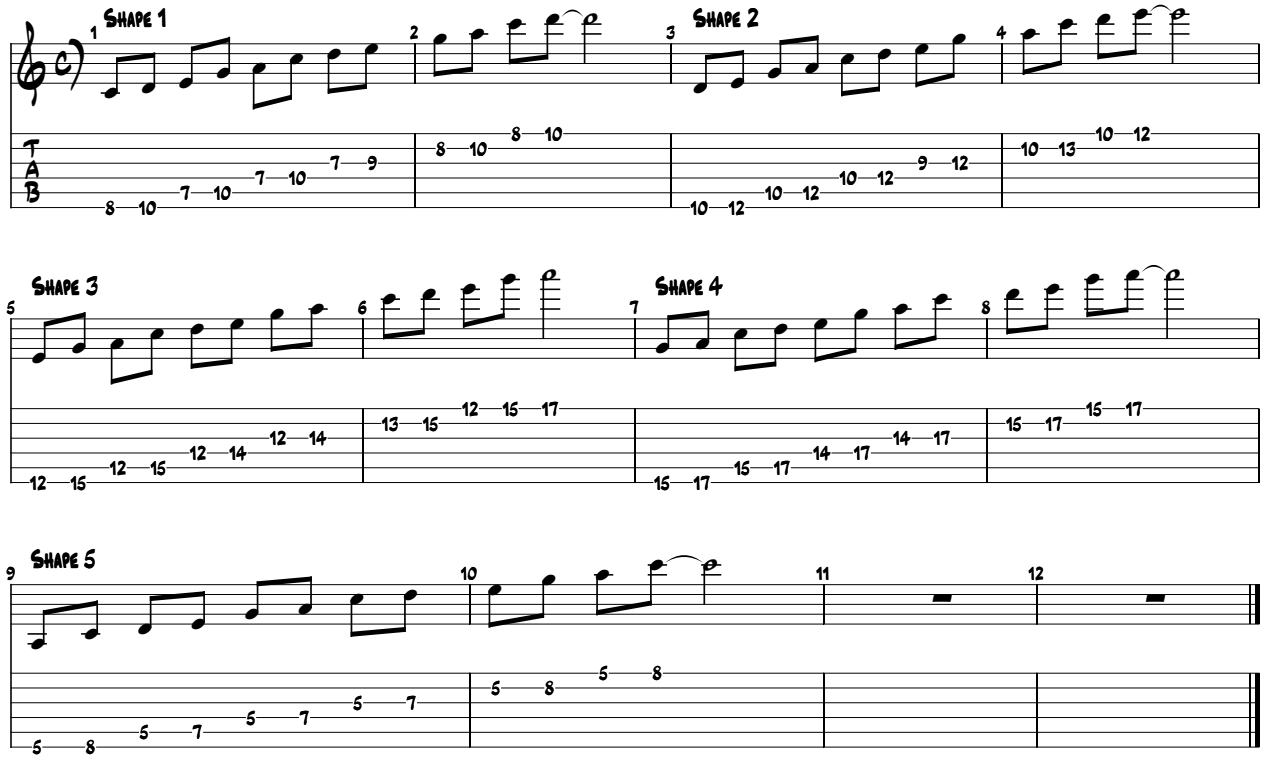
2.2.2 Major pentatonic scale patterns



2.2.1 A minor pentatonic scale patterns



2.2.2 C major pentatonic scale patterns



3. Improvisation: Chords and pentatonic scales

Have fun adding licks between your chords

Combining chords and pentatonic scales

Chords and pentatonic scales from the same key sound great together.

They also sound great with their relative keys – e.g., A minor and C major; E minor and G major.

Goal

To gain confidence adding licks that use notes from pentatonic scales between any major or minor chord

Exercises

2.3.1 Improvise licks over Am and C

Use any A minor pentatonic shape over any A minor chord.
Use any C major pentatonic shape over any C major chord.

2.3.2 Improvise licks over Am and G

Use A minor pentatonic over the A minor chord, and the G major pentatonic over the G major chord using the backing track.

Pro tip: Relative keys can help you find patterns quickly: A minor equals C major; and G major equals E minor.

2.3.3. Improvise licks over C and F

Try improvising over C major and F major using the backing track.

4. Technique: Bending

Ways to improve your bending style

Bending tips

- Keep the tip of your thumb on top of the neck, pointing forward.
- Don't bend your wrist.
- Position your fingers at about a 45-degree slant.
- Use your ring finger to bend the string.
- Use your middle and index fingers to help.
- Don't slide your fingers under the adjacent strings.
- Use your index finger to prevent nearby strings from ringing when you release your ring finger.

Goal

To be able to bend a string to the desired pitch without other strings ringing

Exercise

2.4.1 Melody in the Key of A minor

This melody gives you a chance to practice your bending technique while playing over a backing track.

Pro tip: Try recording yourself when you play this exercise to really hear if you're nailing the intonation of your bends.

Exercise 2.4.1 Melody in the Key of A minor

5. Solo: “Feeling Blue in B Minor”

Play over a backing track using the skills you’ve learned

Guitar terms

Pick-up bar (or anacrusis): A note or series of notes before the first measure (the first bar) of a song

Goal

To be able to keep up with the backing track, bending the notes with good technique

Exercise

2.5.1 Solo: “Feeling Blue in B Minor”

Have some fun practicing the solo with the backing track.

2.5.1 Solo: "Feeling Blue in B Minor"

Advancing to Level 3

Are you ready to move on? Answer the following questions to help you decide. For the answers, go to Advancing to Level 3 in the members area.

Level 2 Self test

Grab your guitar, and a pen to write down your answers.

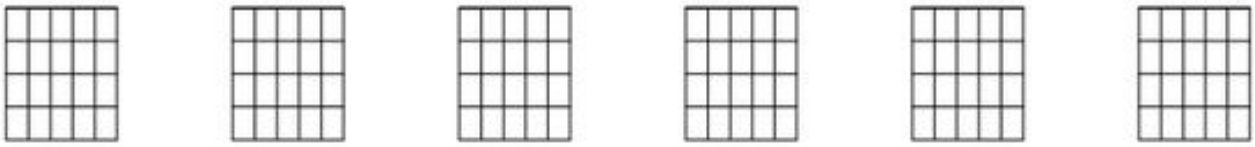
1. Notes in a triad
Major triads (or just “major chords”) are made of which notes from the scale?

2. Pentatonic scales
Can you play at least one pentatonic scale pattern up and down fluently and from memory?

3. Relative keys
What do two relative keys share, and in what way are they different?

4. Bending technique
Are you able to keep up with the backing track and bend the strings to the correct pitch?

5. Improvise and play solos
Name 2 pentatonic scales to use when improvising over C and F chords.



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1. Chords: 7th chords

These chords can add a bit of “spice” to your playing

Guitar terms

Major

Major 7th interval: A half tone lower than the high note of the octave

Major 7th chord: Major chord with the major 7th interval added (the 7 note of the scale)

Minor

Minor 7th interval: One tone lower than the high note of the octave

Minor 7th chord: A minor chord with the minor 7th interval added (the ♭7 note of the scale)

Dominant

7th chord (or dominant 7th chord): Major chord with the minor 7th interval added (the ♭7 note of the scale)

7th chords - a recap

The most commonly seen 7th chords are:

- Major 7th, made up of these functions:
  1 – 3 – 5 – 7
  E.g., Cmaj7: C – E – G – B

- Minor 7th, made up of these functions:
  1 – ♭3 – 5 – ♭7
  E.g., Cm7: C – Eb – G – B♭

- 7th (or dominant 7th), made up of these functions:
  1 – 3 – 5 – ♭7
  E.g., C7: C – E – G – B♭

Tips

- Learn the chord shapes by heart. Don’t try to work them out as you’re playing.
- By adapting these chords to become barre chords, you can play them anywhere.
- The 5th interval can often be left out of any chord, especially if you’re adding other notes.

Goal

Within 1 second, be able to locate any major 7th, minor 7th, or 7th chord anywhere on the neck with the root on the low E string or the A string

Note: To reach this goal, you may need to keep coming back to practice these chords as you advance through the course. It can take some time before these shapes become second nature.

Exercises

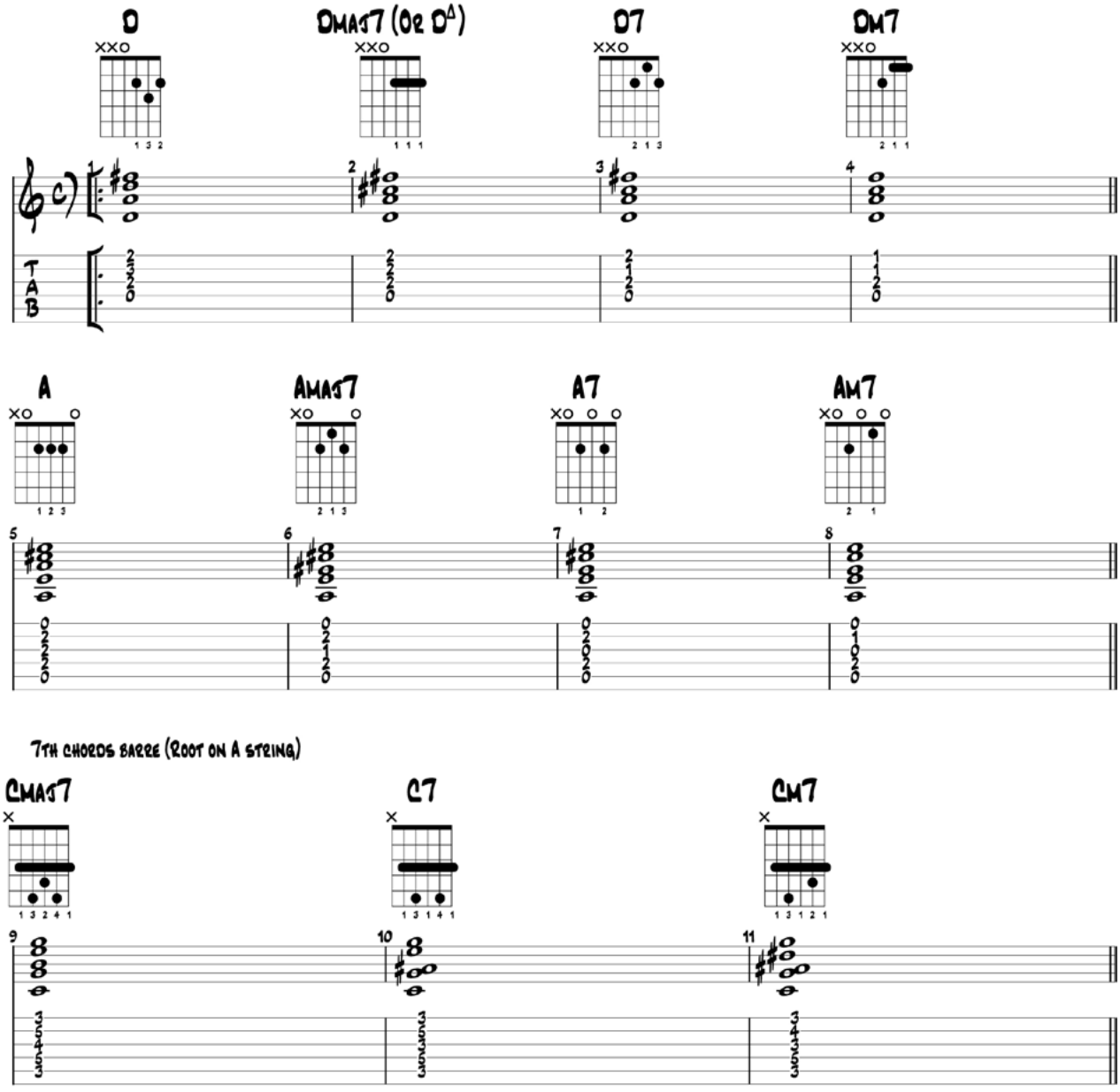
3.1.1 7th chords – Part 1

Practice these chords with the tabs.

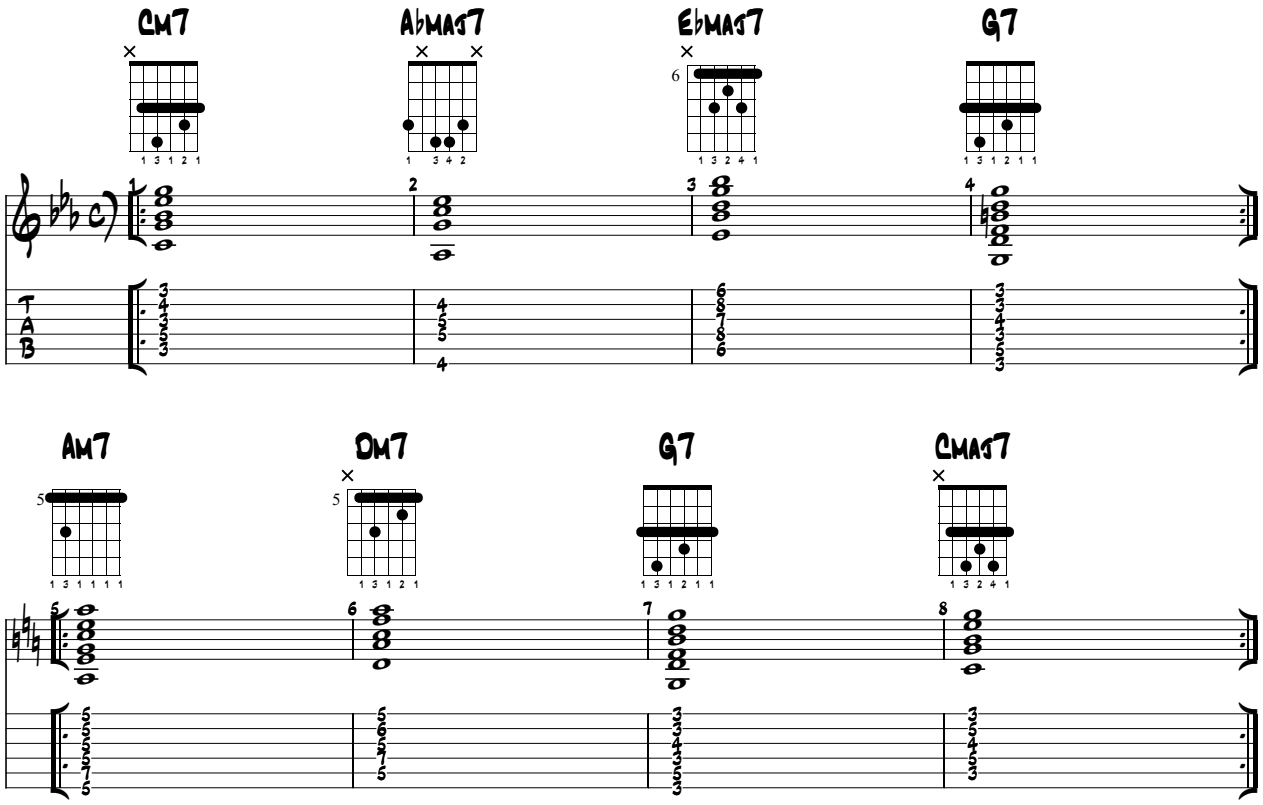
3.1.2 7th chords – Part 2

Expand your 7th chord vocabulary.

Exercise 3.1.1 7th chords – Part 1



Exercise 3.1.2 7th chords – Part 2



2. Speed and versatility: Pentatonic scales

Skills that will help you easily shift any lick to different strings

Guitar terms

Alternate picking: Alternating between a downstroke and an upstroke

Triplet: A group of three notes of the same length (counted as one-two-three)

Goal

To increase your speed at playing the E minor pentatonic in five positions, while maintaining good technique

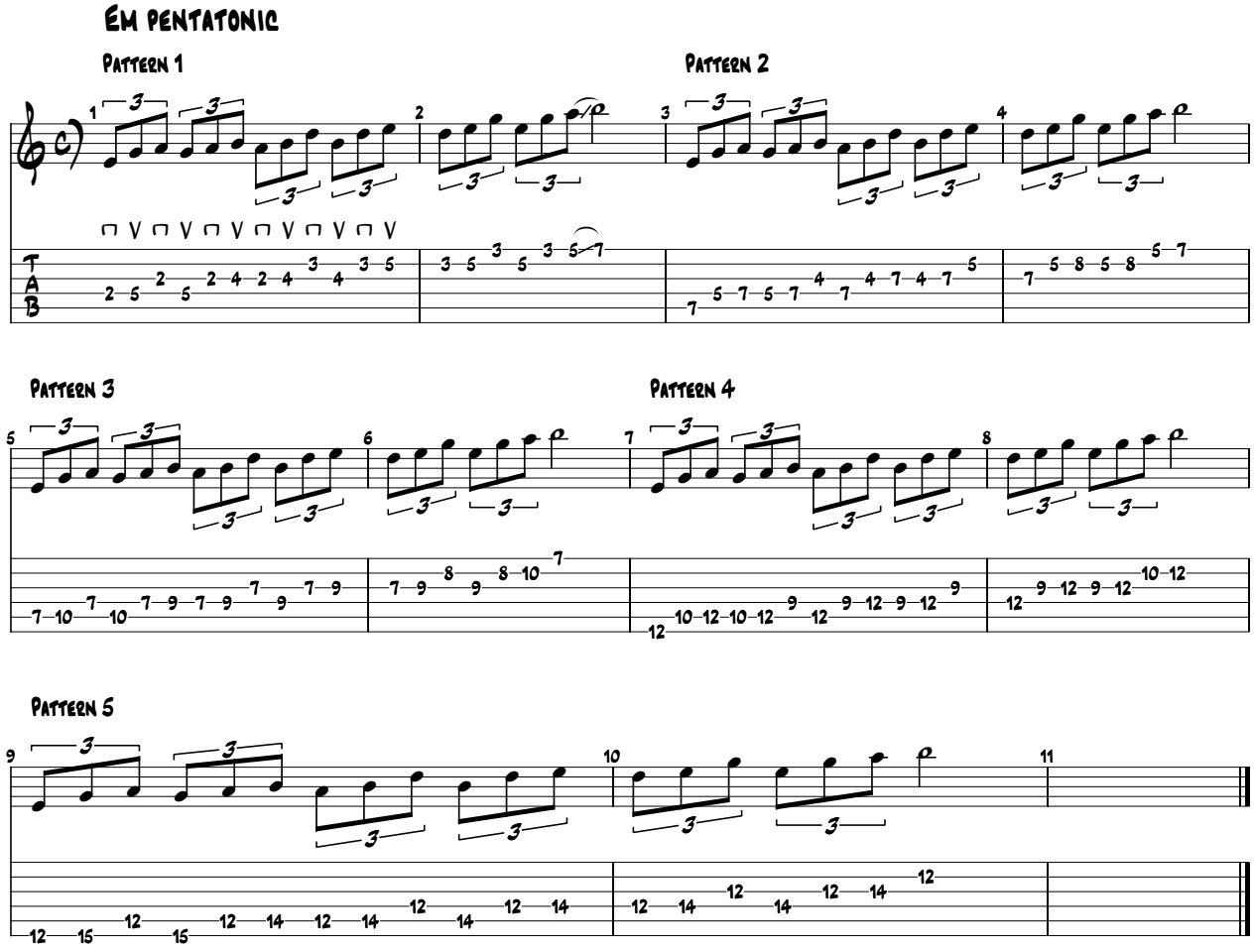
Exercises

3.2.1 The E minor pentatonic scale played in 5 patterns

Advanced exercises

- Count in sixes (not threes).
- Play the exercises in G minor or A minor.
- Use a metronome and gradually increase the speed.

Exercise 3.2.1 The E minor pentatonic scale played in 5 patterns



3. Practical theory: Chord progressions

Add to your repertoire with these 7th chords

Guitar terms

Transpose: To change the pitch of a song by raising or lowering the notes or chords by the same interval

Chord progression dictionary

Chord degree	Name	Example: 7th Chords in Key of G major
I	Tonic (root)	Gmaj7 (or GΔ/GM7)
ii	Supertonic	Am7 (or A-7)
iii	Mediant	Bm7
IV	Subdominant	Cmaj7
V	Dominant	D7
vi	Submediant or relative minor	Em7
vii	Seventh or leading note	F#m7♭5 (or F#ø, which is pronounced as “half-diminished”)

Goal

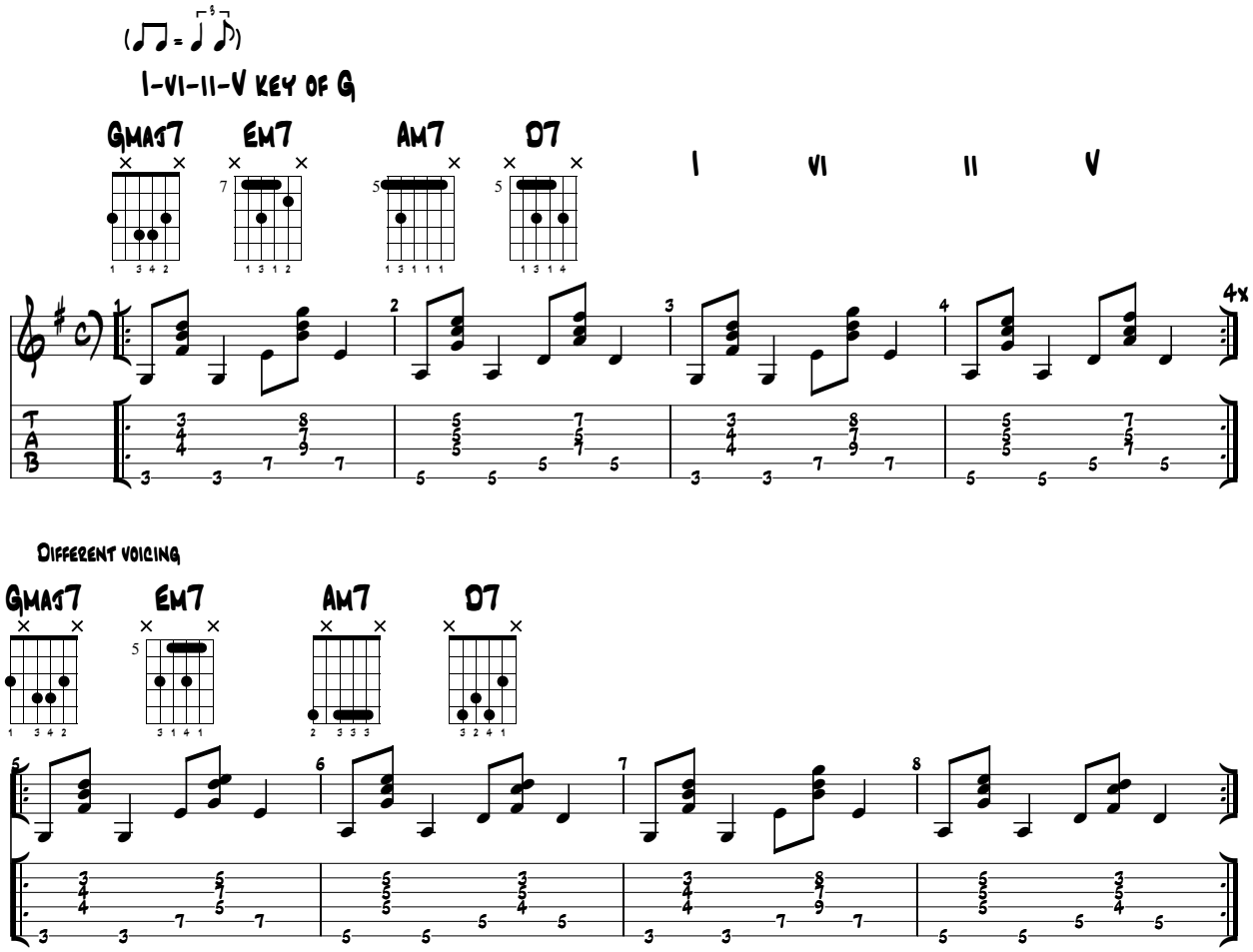
To be able to construct jazzy or spicy sounding chord progressions in any key based on 7th chords
To be able to quickly find and play the chords with the root on the Low E or A string

Exercises

3.3.1 Jazz in key of G

Practice this tune with a I – vi – ii – V progression.

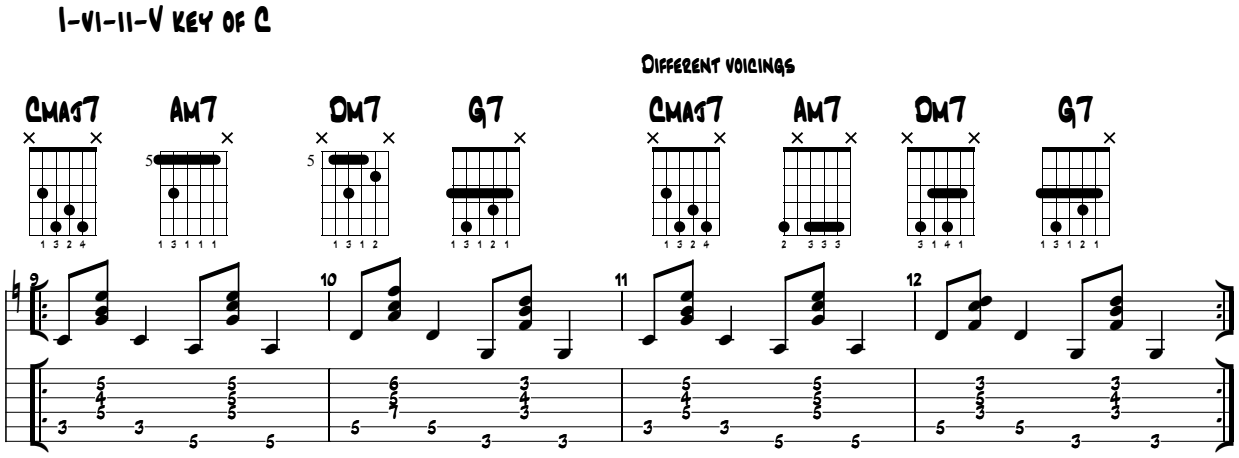
Exercise 3.3.1 Jazz in key of G



3.3.2 Jazz in key of C

Transpose the chord progression I – vi – ii – V into the key of C. You'll find the answers in the tabs – but try to work it out yourself first!

Exercise 3.3.1 Jazz in key of C



4. Lead: Minor scales

A lot of music is in a minor key, so these are great scales to know

Guitar terms

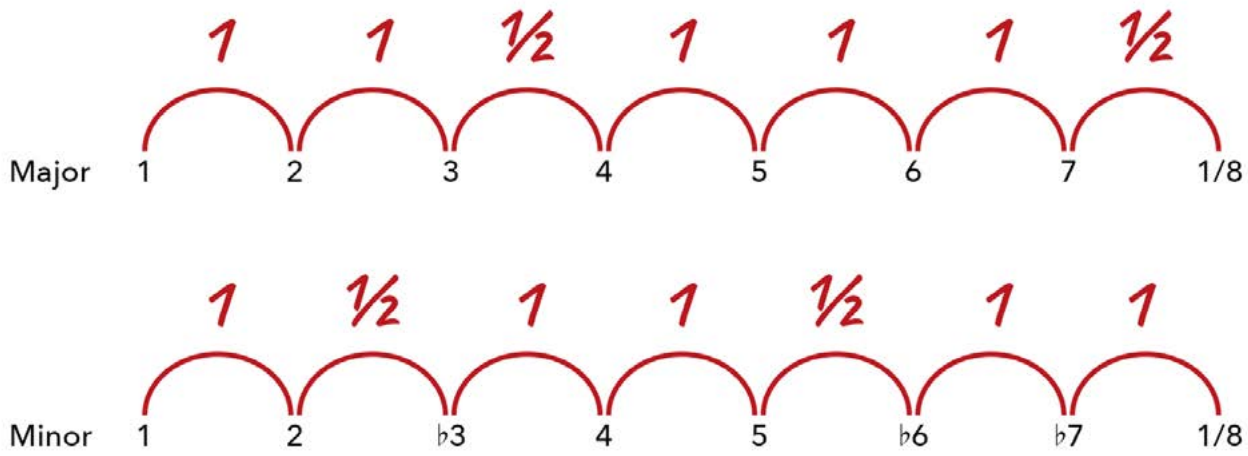
Aeolian or natural minor scale: minor scale

The minor scale – a recap

Starting from the root note, this is the sequence between the notes in a minor scale:

Whole tone (2 frets)
Semitone (1 fret)
Whole tone (2 frets)
Whole tone (2 frets)
Semitone (1 fret)
Whole tone (2 frets)
Whole tone (2 frets)

The intervals of the minor scale compare to the intervals of the major scale like this:



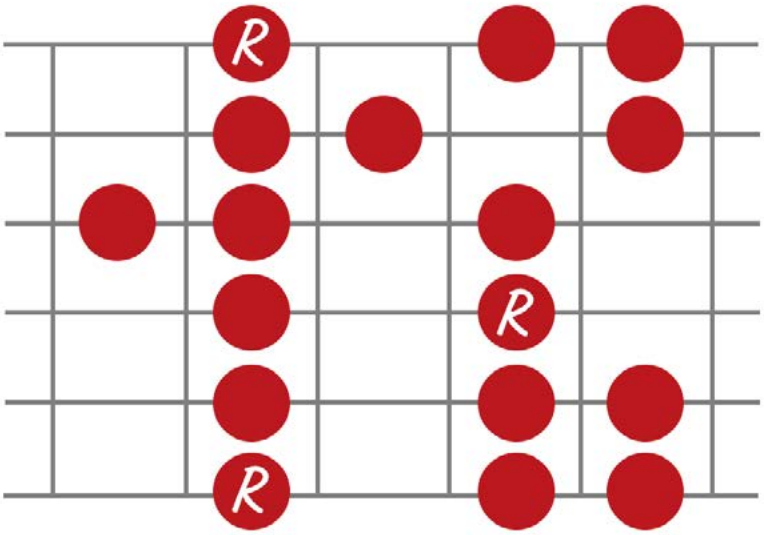
Goal

To play from memory the A minor and C minor scale in more than one location on the fretboard

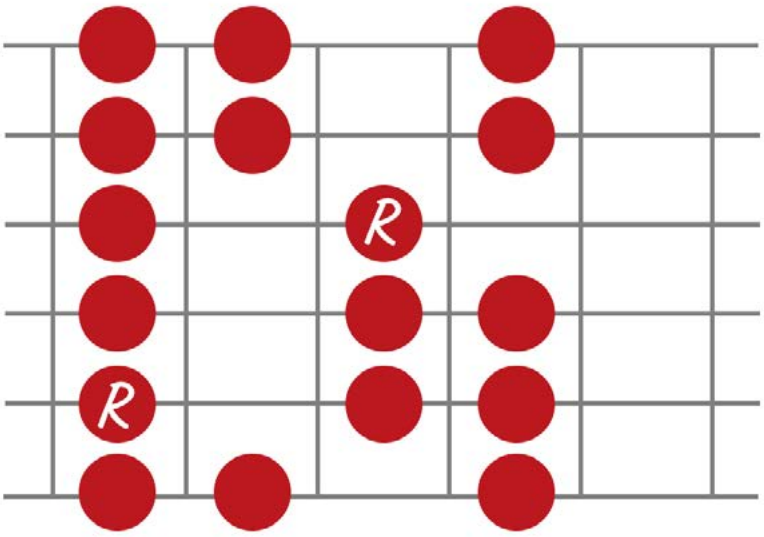
Exercises

3.4.1 A minor, root on string 6 and root on string 5

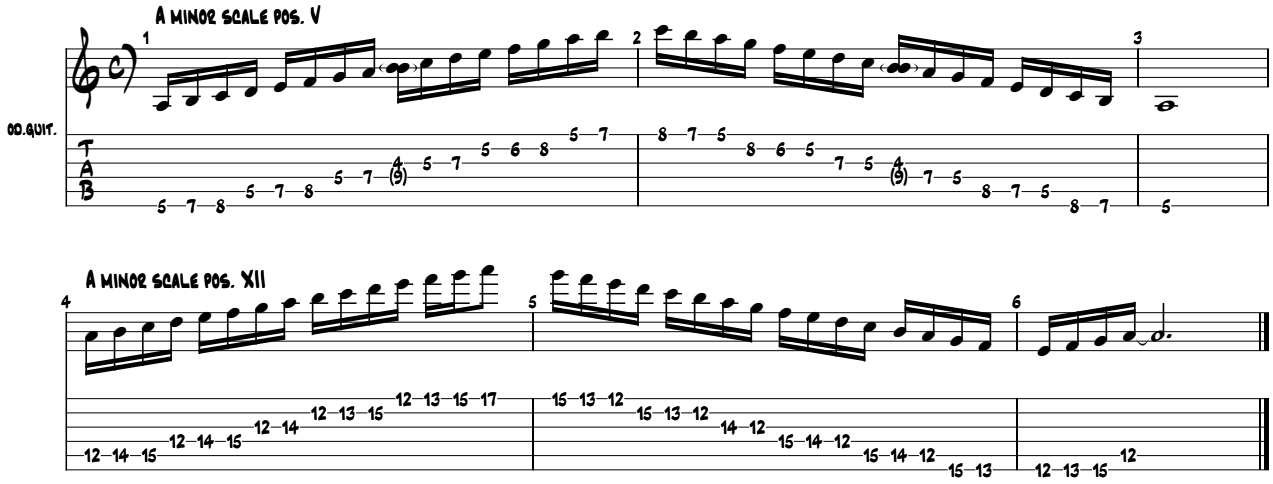
Root string 6



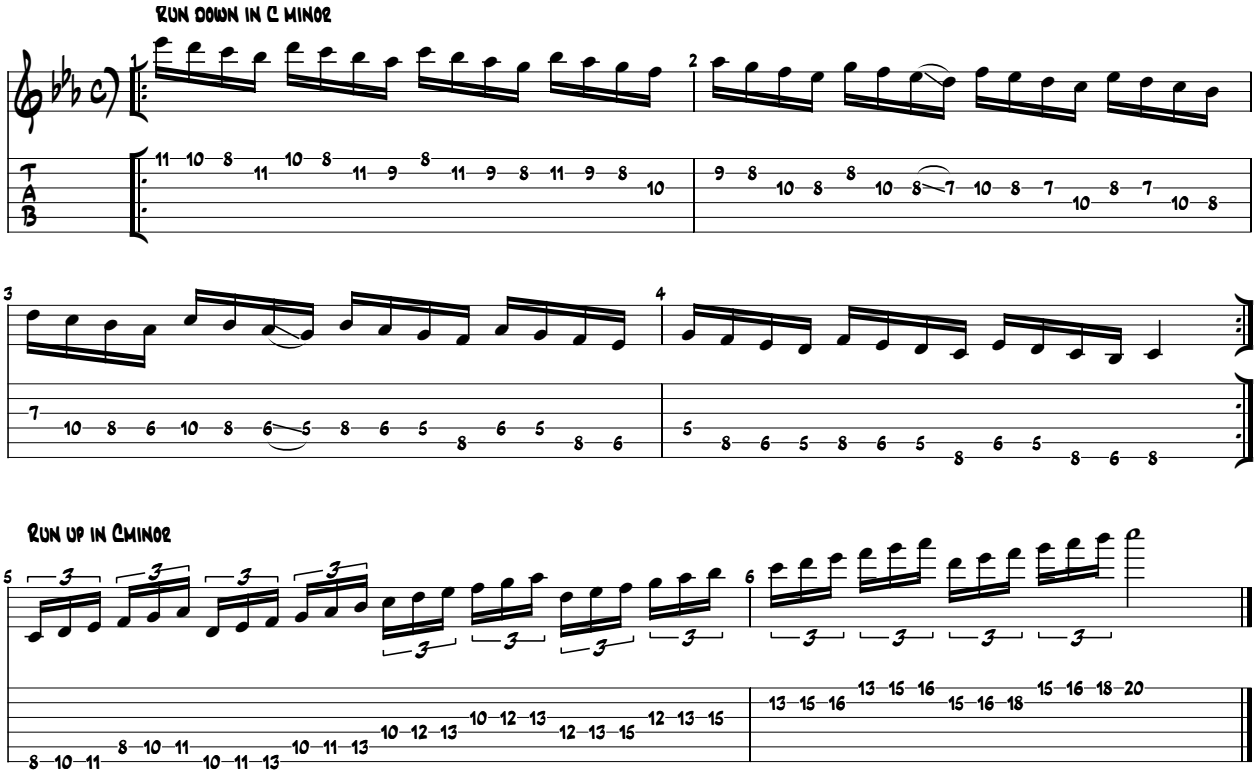
Root string 5



Exercise 3.4.1 A minor, root on string 6 and root on string 5



Exercise 3.4.2 C minor, descending run and ascending run



5. Solo: “Aeolian Dream”

Play over a backing track using the skills you’ve learned

Goal

To nail the solo, keeping up with the backing track

Advanced goal

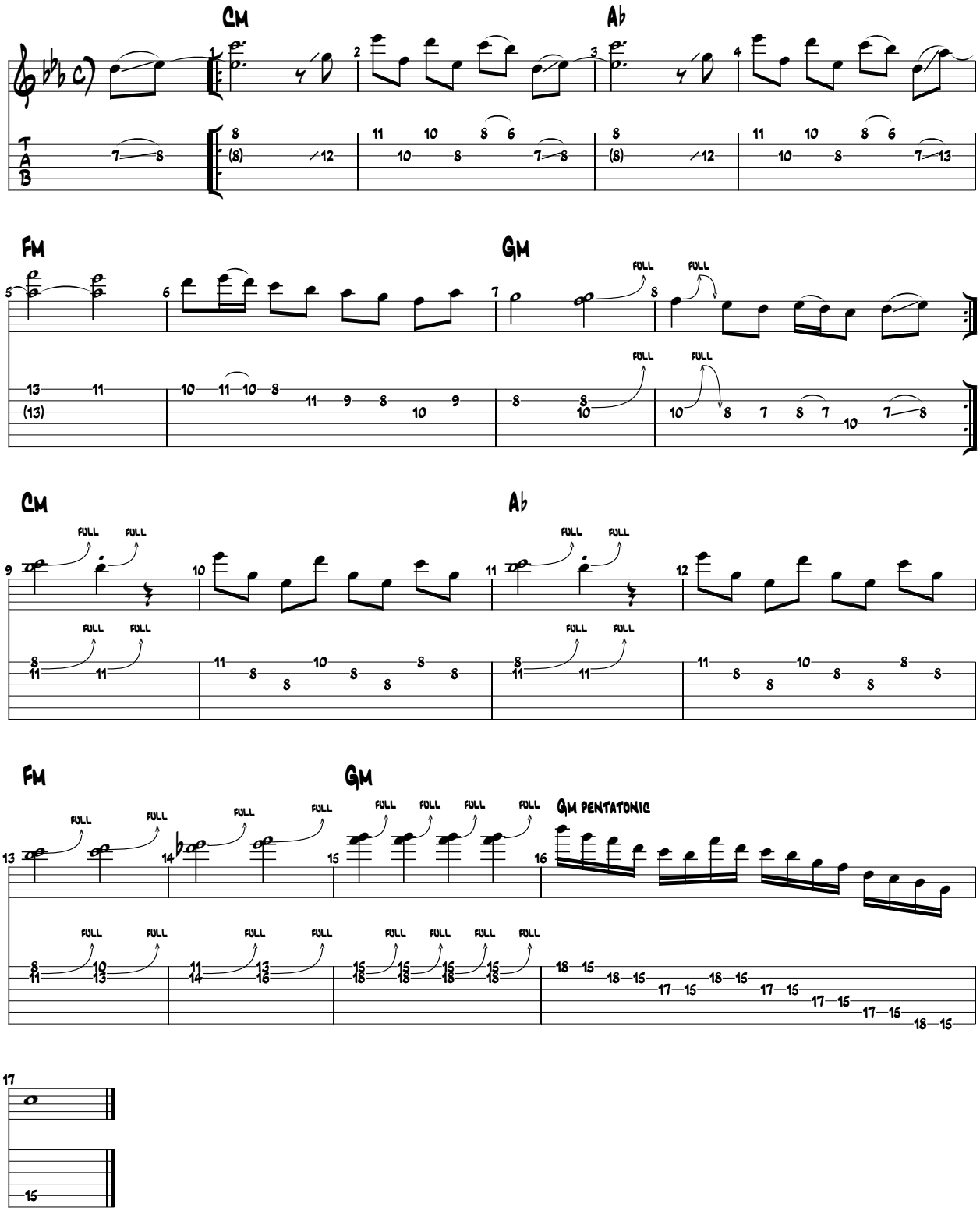
To understand why the notes in the solo sound good with the chords in the backing track

Exercise

3.5.1 Solo: “Aeolian Dream”

Practice the solo over the backing track ... and then feel free to let loose and improvise.

3.5.1 Solo: "Aeolian Dream"



Advancing to Level 4

Are you ready to move on? Complete the following questions to help you decide. Grab your guitar, and a pen to write down your answers. You can check the answers in Advancing to Level 4 in the members area.

Level 3 Self test

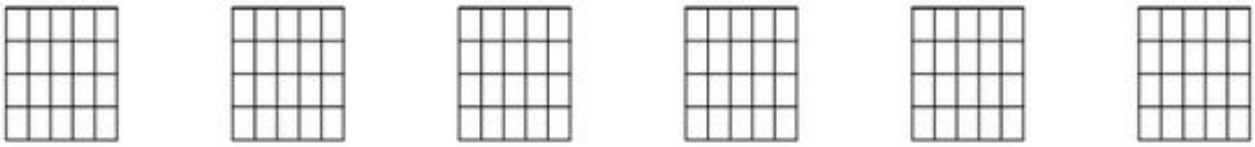
1. 7th chords
A major 7th chord is made up of which 4 intervals of the major scale?

2. Pentatonic scales
Can you play at least 3 of the 5 pentatonic scale patterns from lesson 2?

3. Chord progressions
If you were to play a ii – V – I progression with 7th chords in the key of D, what chords would you play?

4. Minor scales
Are you able to play A minor in at least one of the two positions without checking tabs?

5. Improvise and play solos
Do you feel relatively comfortable jamming with the backing track in lesson 5?



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1. Chords: Triads on the top 3 strings

Find the triads you need fast and fluently

Frequency spectrum

The guitar lies mostly in the middle registers of the frequency spectrum. For instance, it's not as low as a bass guitar, which has a lot of low frequencies, and doesn't go as high as the violin.

When you play, you have to decide where in that middle spectrum you want to be. If you want the guitar to sound fat and thick, play the chords on the first few frets of the lower strings. If you want the guitar to sound higher, play the chords on the higher strings, and higher up the neck!

This is very important to think about when you play in a band or when you record guitar in the studio.

Goal

To be able to locate any major or minor chord on the top three strings by the end of the course

Advanced goal

To be able to play any major or minor chord on the D, G, and B strings by the end of the course

Exercises

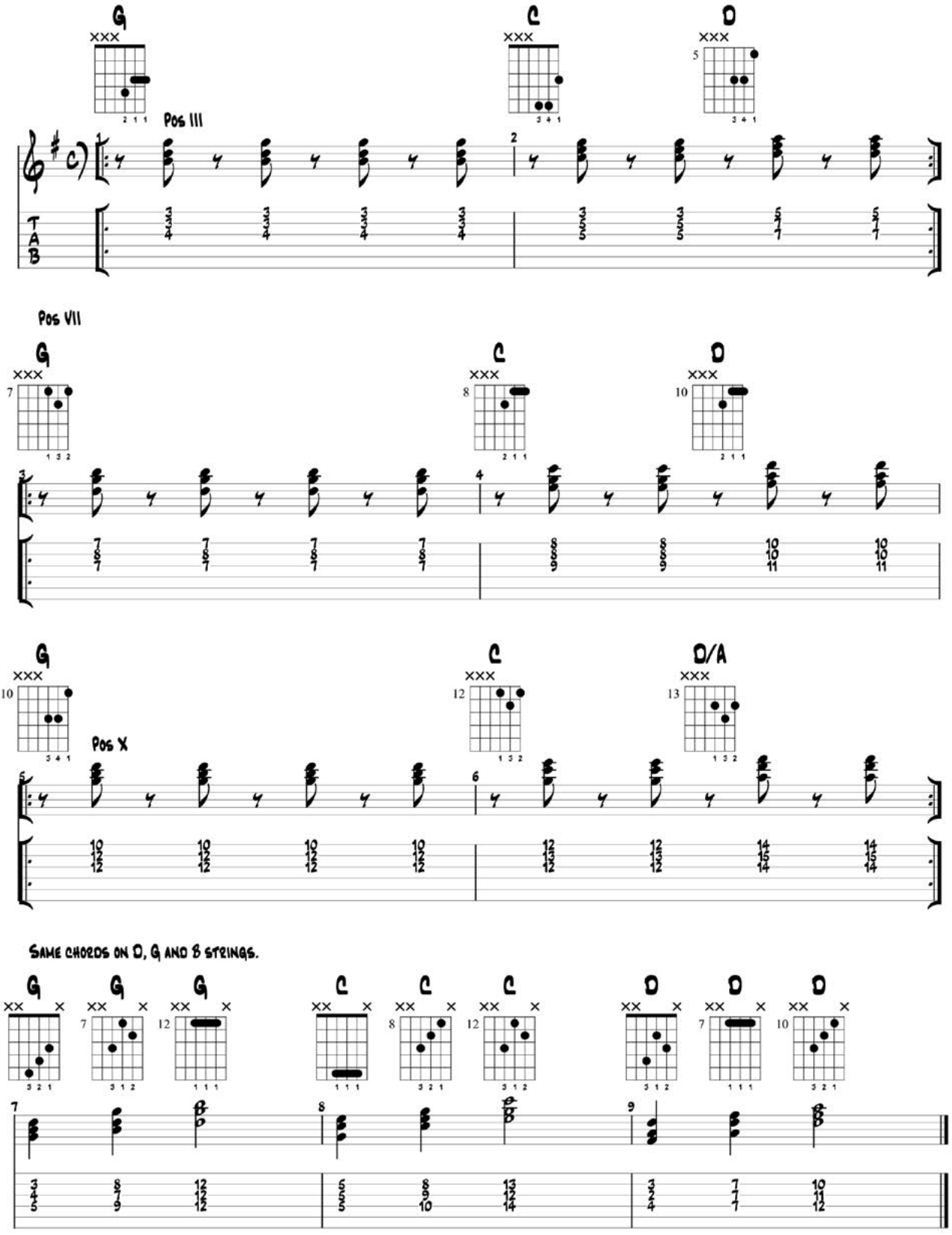
4.1.1 Reggae vibe in G

Play a G – C – D chord progression three ways on the top three strings, over the backing track.

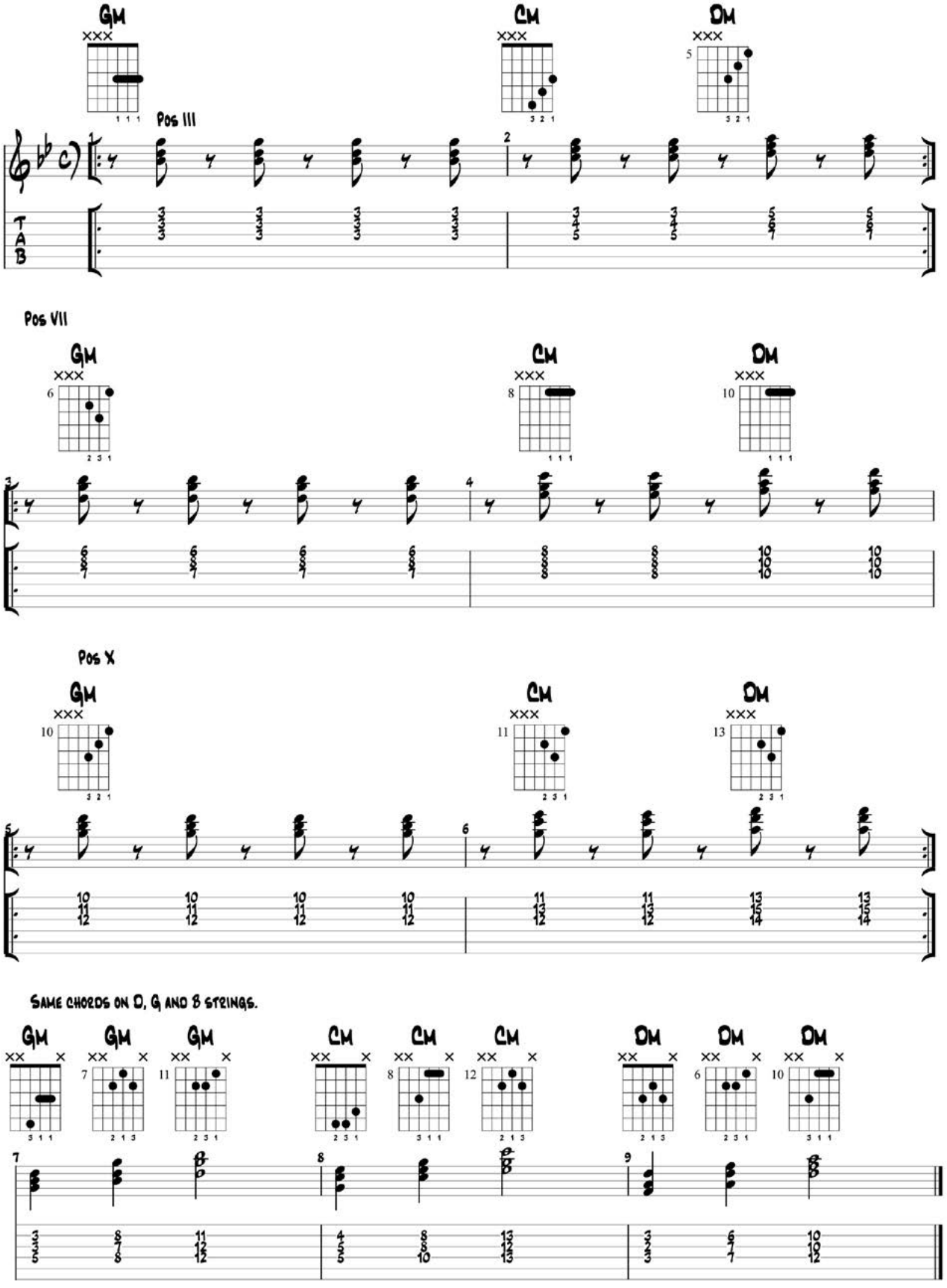
4.1.2 Reggae vibe in G minor

Play a Gm – Cm – Dm chord progression three ways on the top three strings, over the backing track.

Exercise 4.1.1 Reggae vibe in G



Exercise 4.1.2 Reggae vibe in G minor



2. Speed and versatility: Scales

Play scales using 3 notes per string to boost your skills

Guitar terms

Legato: A style of playing where notes are smooth and connected to one another

Goal

To increase your speed at playing the G major, A minor, and C major scales using the 3 notes per string system

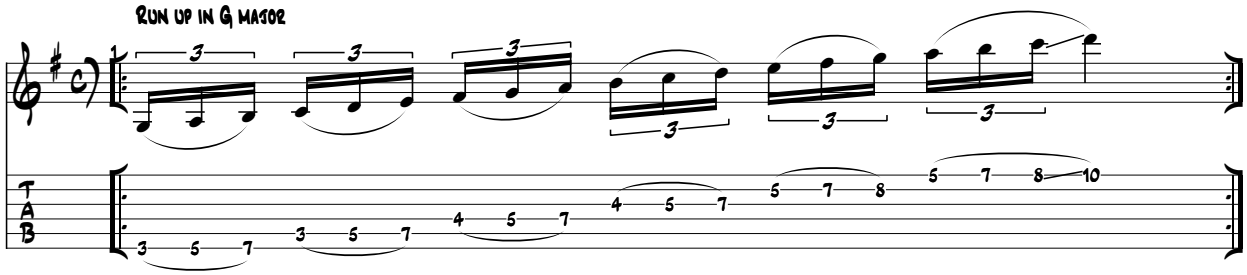
Exercises

4.2.1 G major scale, 3 notes per string
4.2.2 A minor scale, 3 notes per string
4.2.3 C major scale, 3 notes per string

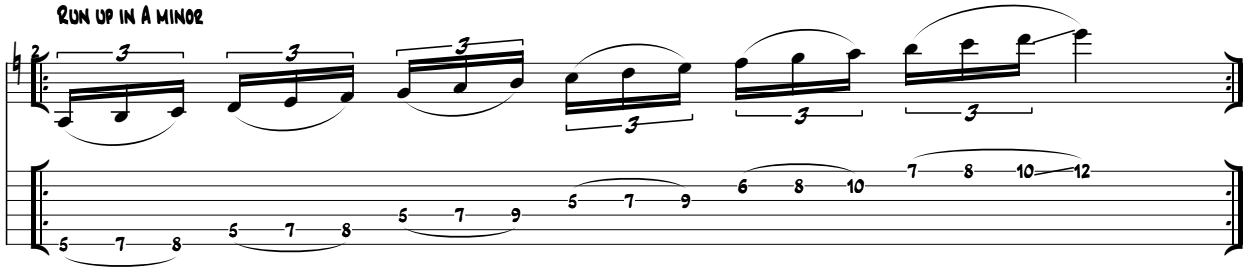
Advanced exercises

Figure out another minor scale and another major scale using the 3 notes per string system.

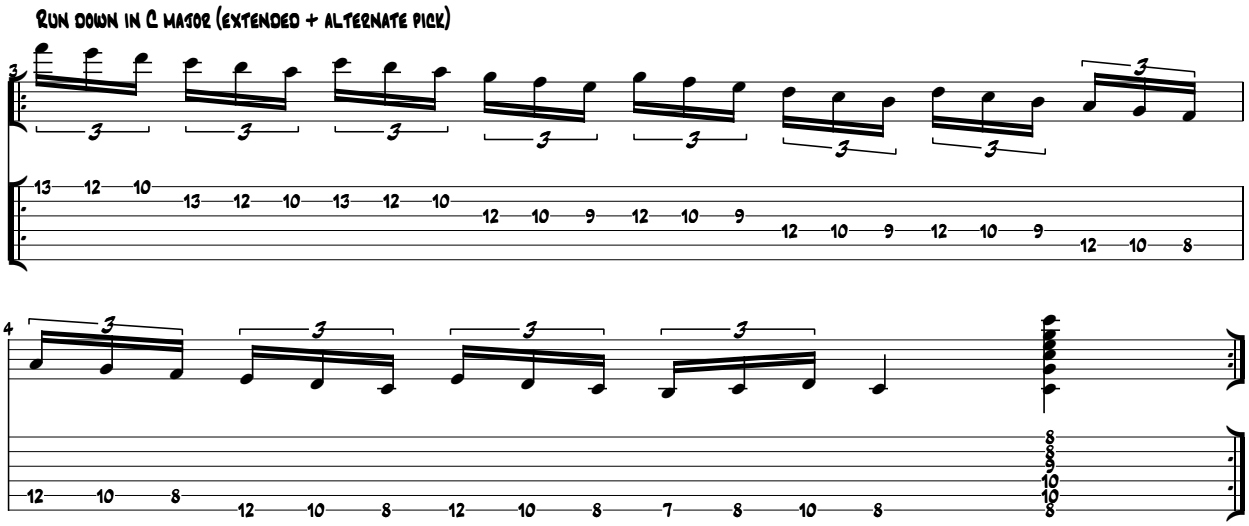
Exercise 4.2.1 G major scale, 3 notes per string



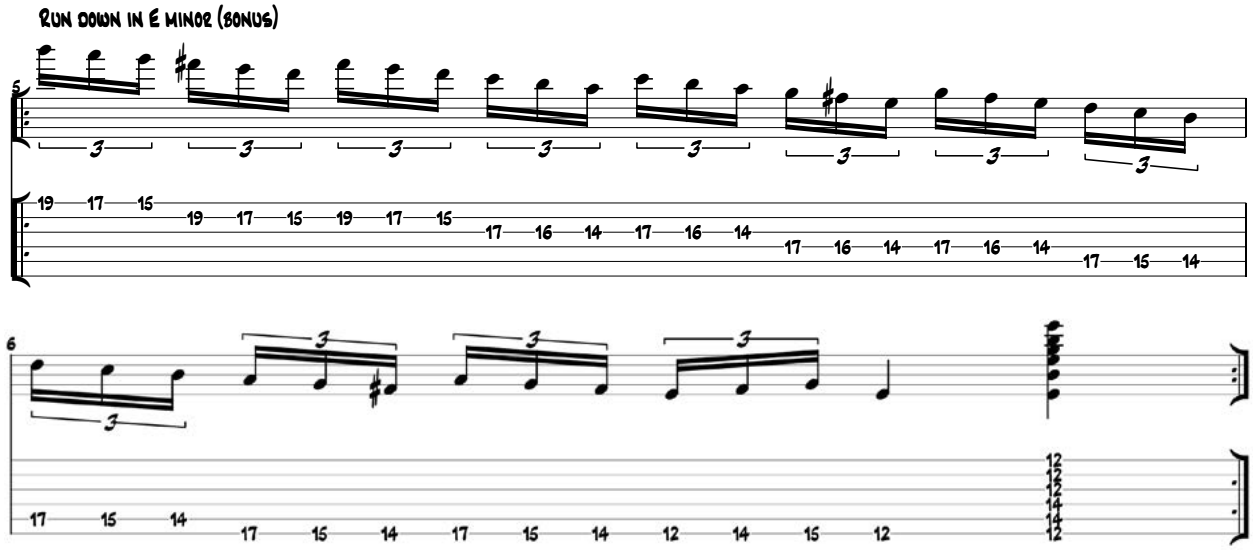
Exercise 4.2.2 A minor scale, 3 notes per string



Exercise 4.2.3 C major scale, 3 notes per string



Bonus: Run down in E minor



3. Improvisation: How to embellish chords

Creative ways to give chords a solo feel

Guitar terms

Arpeggio: The notes of a chord played sequentially, instead of all at once.

Grace note: A note added simply as an embellishment (not essential for the melody or harmony)

Goal

To be able to add notes to any chord, major or minor, while retaining the sound of the chord

Pro tip: Embellishments should add a touch of spice to a chord but not change the sound of the chord. You can think of it like this: a pizza still needs to taste like pizza even if you put spicy toppings on it!

Exercises

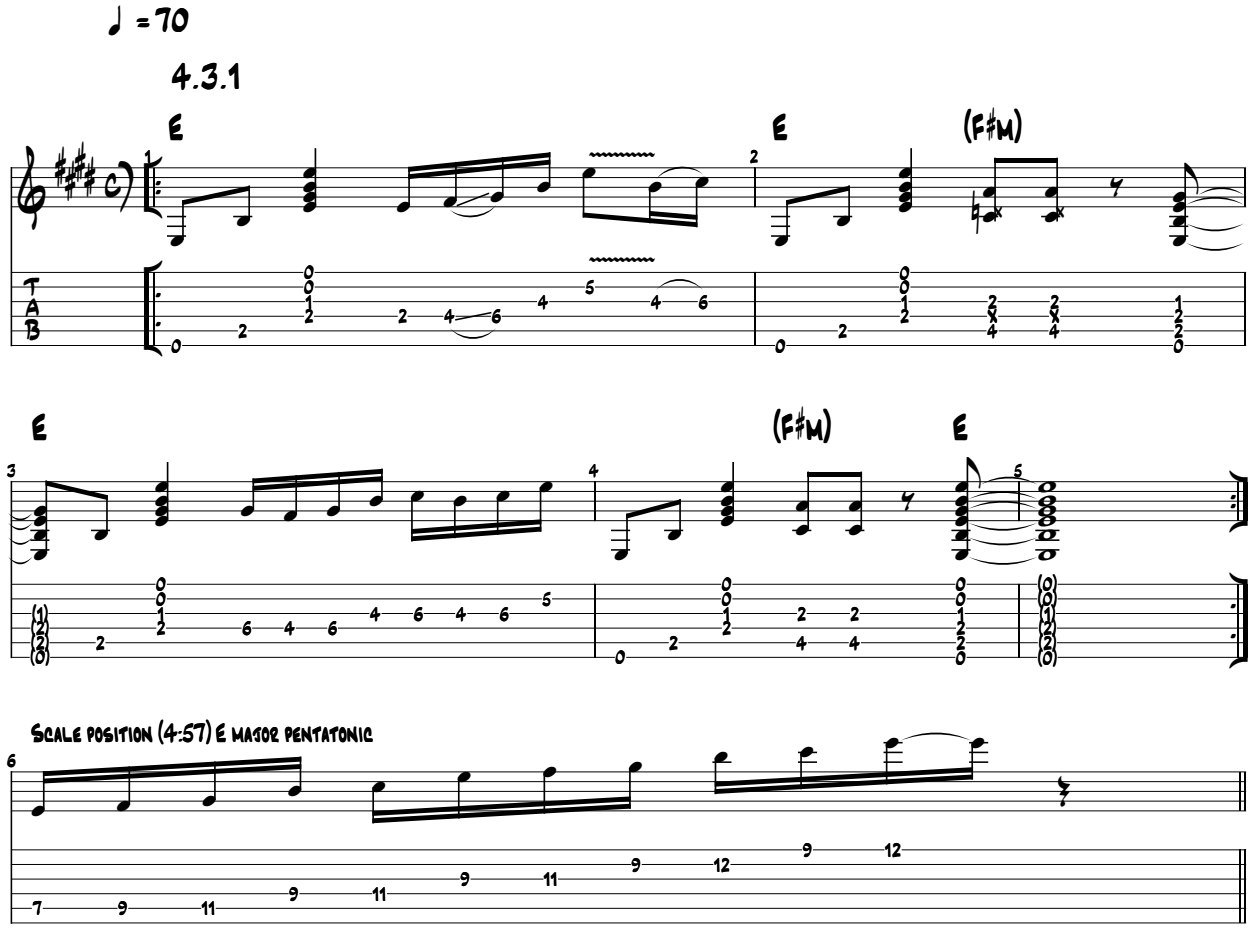
4.3.1 Embellished E major – version 1

4.3.2 Embellished E major – version 2

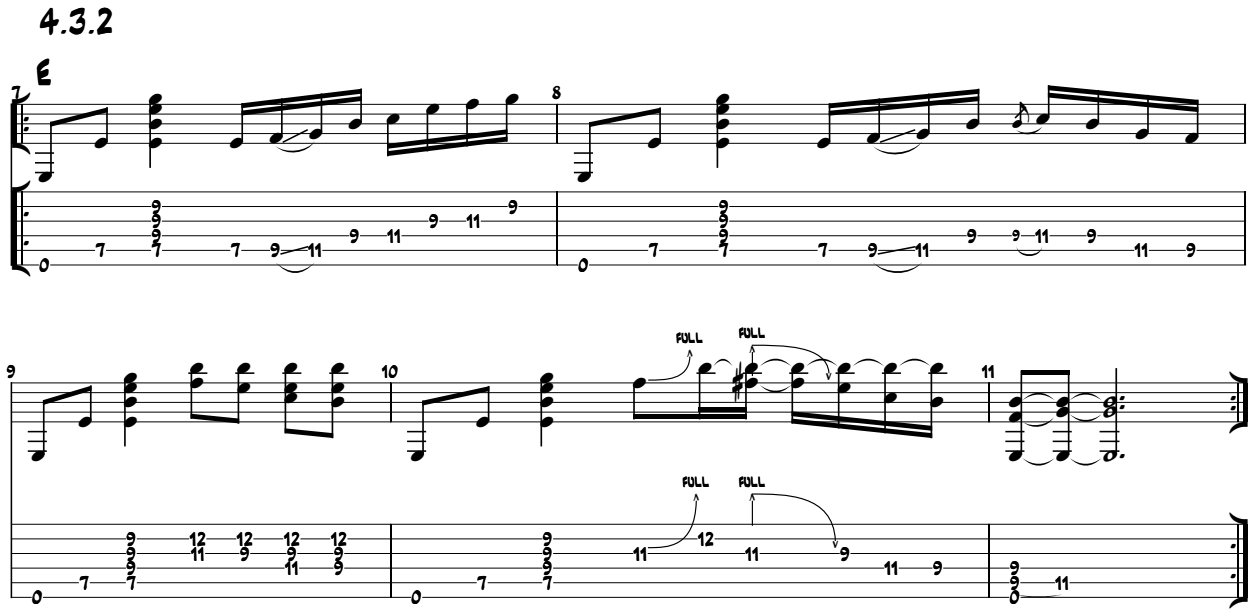
Advanced exercise

Try embellishing another major chord and another minor chord.

Exercise 4.3.1 Embellished E major – version 1



Exercise 4.3.2 Embellished E major - version 2



4. Lead: Harmonic minor scales

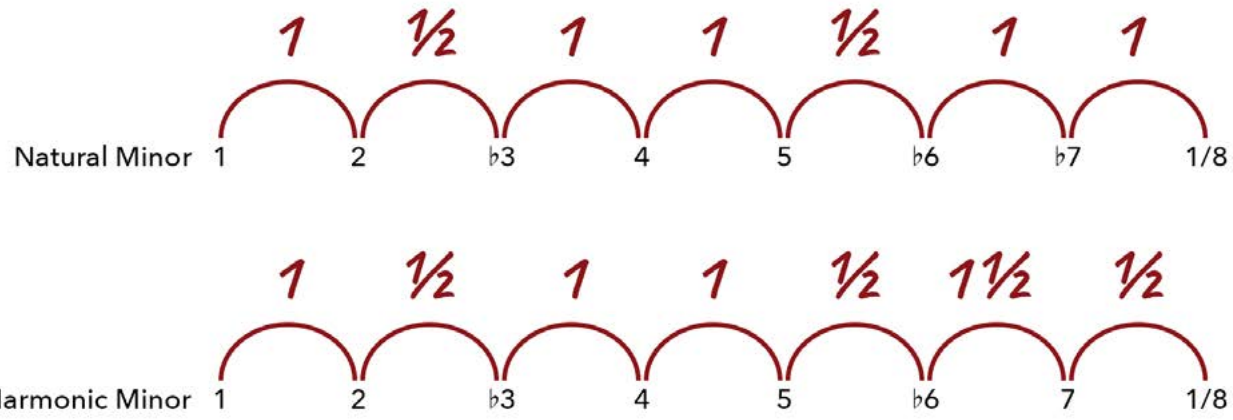
Use this scale to create a unique sound

The harmonic minor scale – a recap

Starting from the root note, this is the sequence of intervals between the notes in a harmonic minor scale:

Whole tone (2 frets)
Semitone (1 fret)
Whole tone (2 frets)
Whole tone (2 frets)
Semitone (1 fret)
3 semitones (3 frets)
Semitone (1 fret)

The intervals of the harmonic minor scale compared to the intervals of the minor scale are:



When to use it

In songs with a minor chord progression, the V chord is frequently switched to a major chord for a more interesting sound. Try playing notes from the harmonic minor scale over that chord (rather than notes from the natural minor or pentatonic scale).

Goal

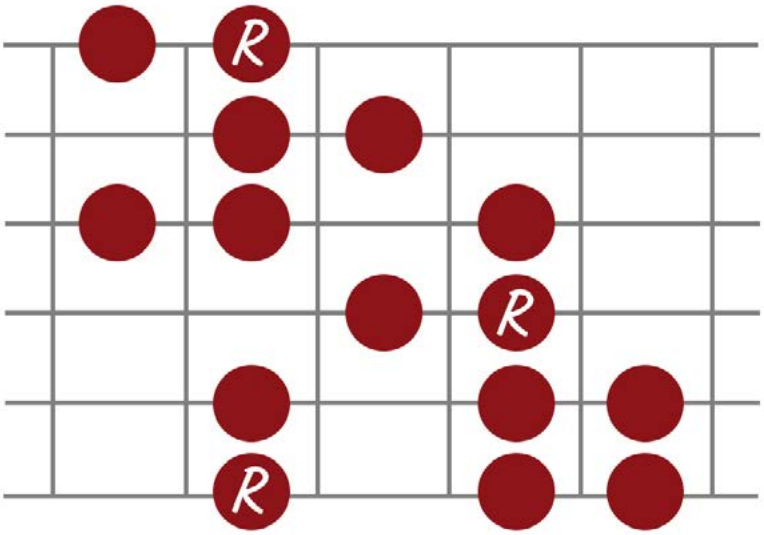
To play from memory the A harmonic minor scale and recognize when you can use it in a song

Pro tip: The harmonic minor scale has a very distinct flavor and sound, so it's easily recognizable in a song once you know it.

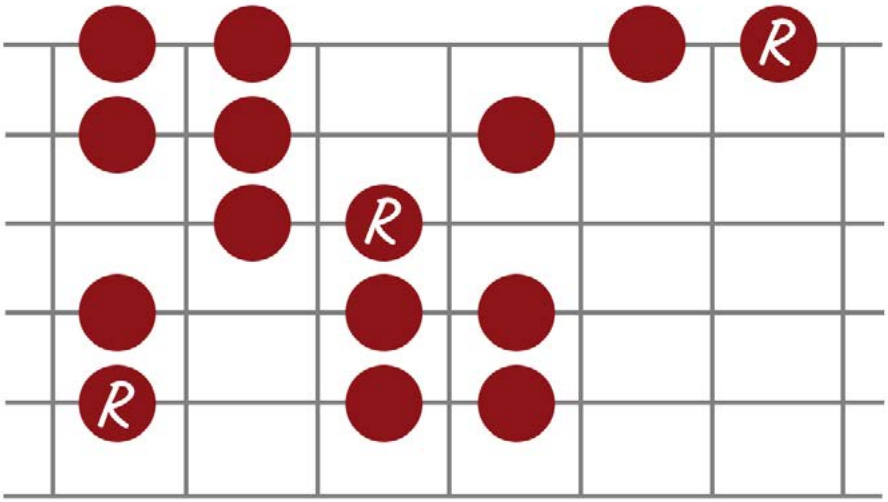
Exercise

4.4.1 A harmonic minor scale

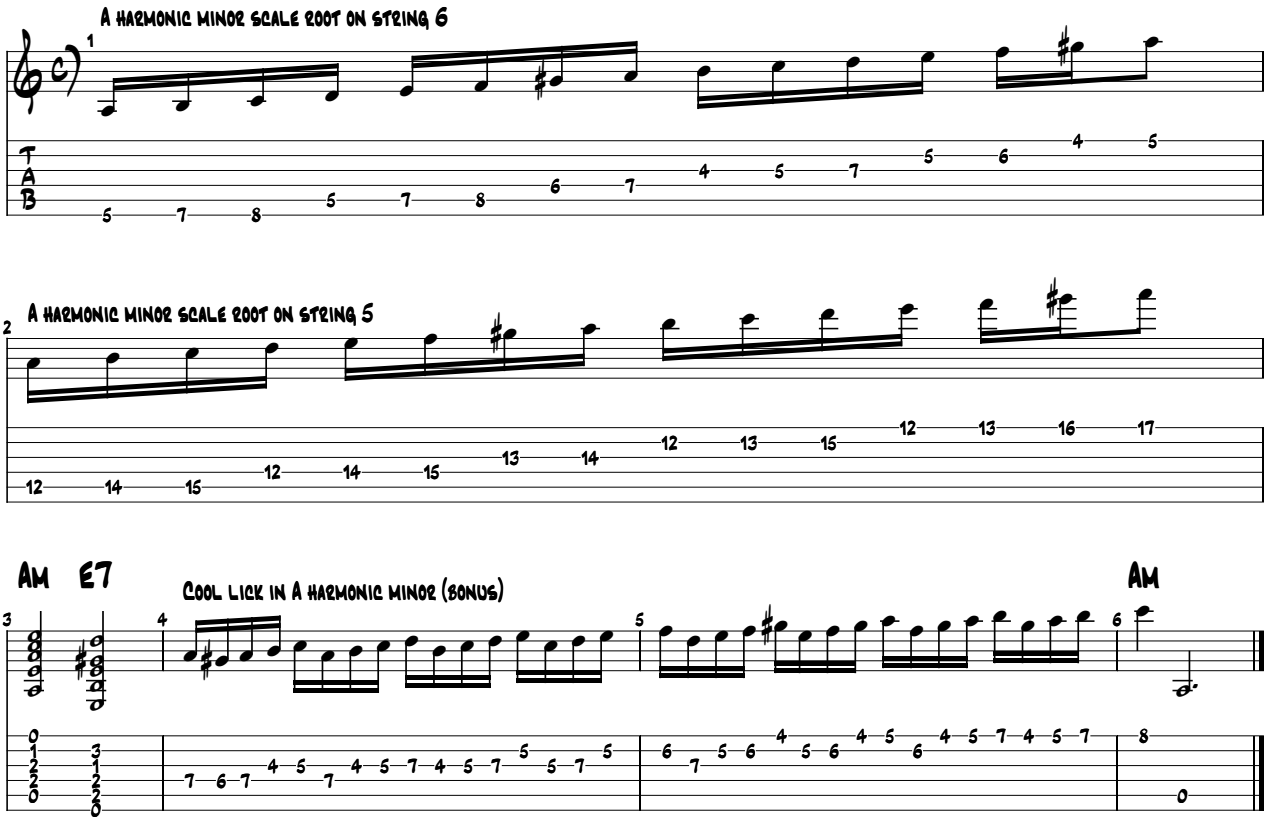
Root on string 6



Root on string 5



Exercise 4.4.1 A Harmonic minor scale



5. Solo: “Harmonic Patterns in E Minor”

Create an amazing sound using the harmonic minor plus scales from earlier levels

Guitar terms

Tremolo picking: Alternating upstrokes and downstrokes at high speed

Goal

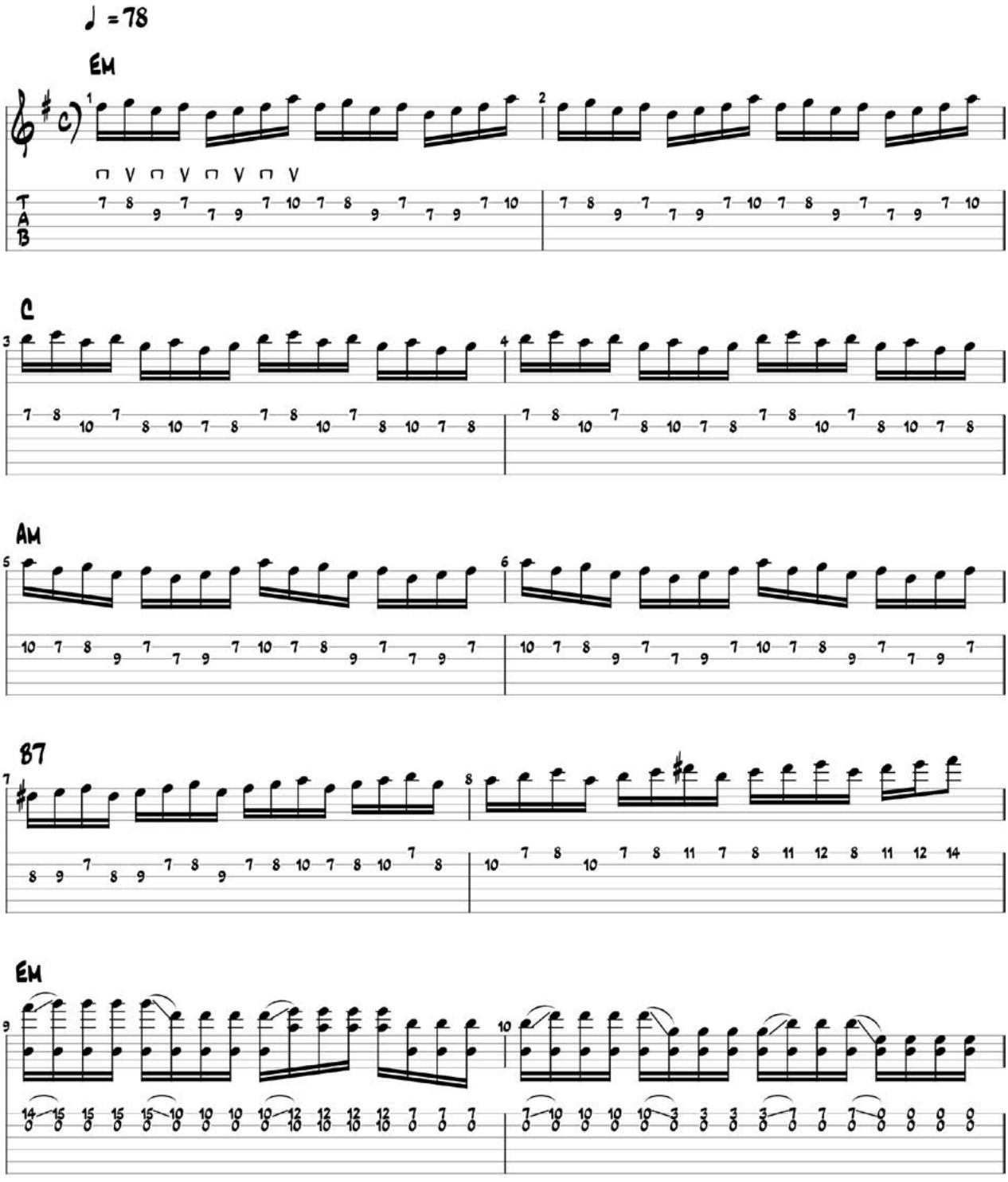
To nail the solo while keeping up with the backing track

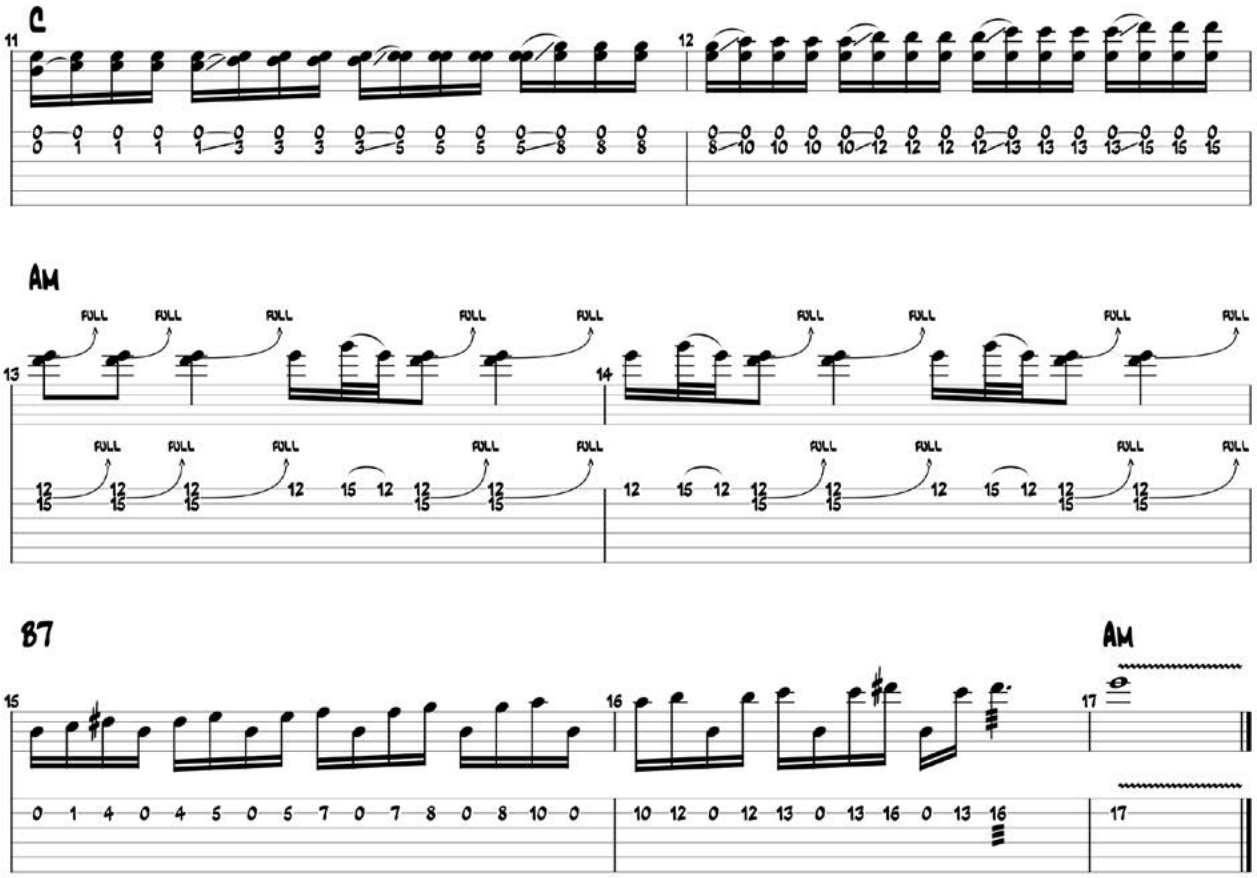
Exercise

4.5.1 Solo: “Harmonic Patterns in E Minor”

Practice the solo over the backing track, then jump into an improvisation.

Exercise 4.5.1 Solo: "Harmonic Patterns in E Minor

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Advancing to Level 5

Are you ready to move on? Complete the following questions to help you decide. Grab your guitar, and a pen to write down your answers. You can check the answers in Advancing to Level 5 in the members area.

Level 4 Self test

1. Triads on the top 3 strings
Can you play the Gm – Cm – Dm chord progression at least two ways on the top three strings without looking at tabs?

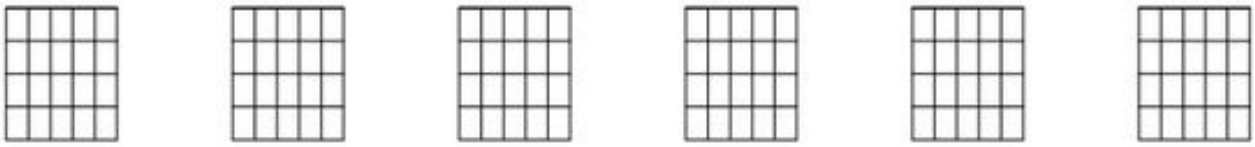
2. Scales
Can you play the A minor scale using three notes per string?

3. Embellishing chords
What is the easiest scale we can use to embellish any major or minor chord?

4. Harmonic minor scales
What is the difference between a natural minor scale and a harmonic minor scale?

5. Improvise and play solos

a) When playing the solo, do you hear when you're playing E harmonic minor instead of natural minor?
b) When you're jamming over the backing track, do you hear the backing track change to the B7 chord?



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1. Technique: Picking

One of the biggest secrets to my playing: how I keep in time

Guitar terms

Syncopated rhythm: When notes fall in unexpected places, such as the off beats

16th note: A note that lasts for a quarter of a beat (counted as 1 e & a 2 e & a ...)

Tips

- Move your picking hand up and down even when you're not playing a note.
- Think of your hand like a metronome that's keeping the beat.
- Maintain a steady pace.

Goal

To play the exercise with the backing track, using the picking technique in the video

Exercise

5.1.1 Funky syncopated rhythm

Play along with the backing track.

Exercise 5.1.1 Funky syncopated rhythm

2. Technique: Fretting chords

Give your chords a new sound with hammer-ons, pull-offs, and muting

Tips

- Maintain the strumming pattern from the previous lesson.
- Use the hammer-on technique in the video for any minor or minor 7 chord. Also try it out on different chord shapes!
- Experiment with leaving out some notes of a chord.

Goal

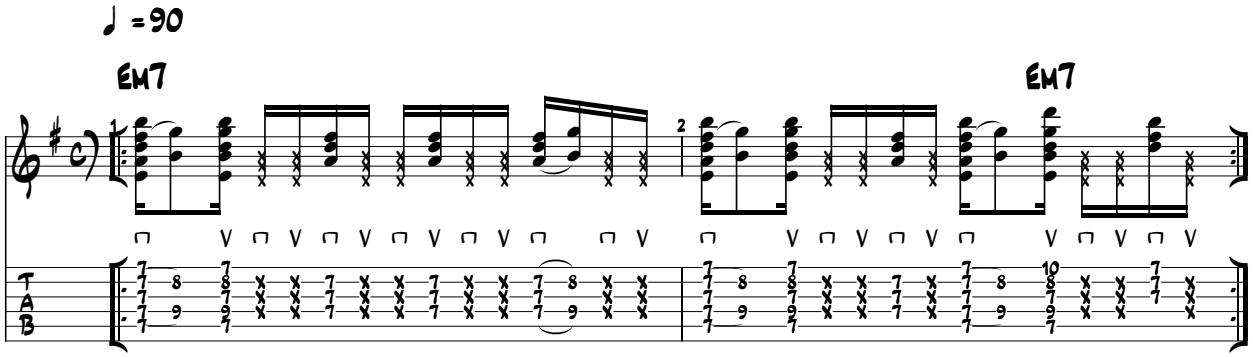
To play the exercise using the fretting techniques in the video, and the rhythmic picking technique from the previous lesson

Exercise

5.2.1 Funky fretting

Play along with the backing track.

Exercise 5.2.1 Funky fretting



3. Lead: Major and minor arpeggios

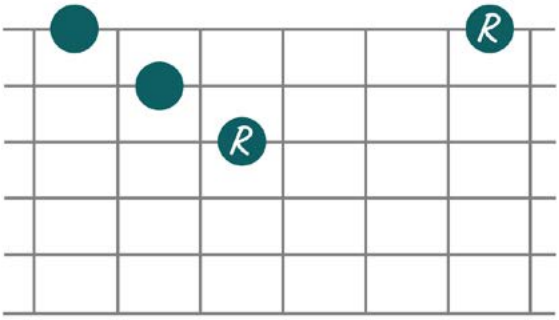
Three positions for playing arpeggios

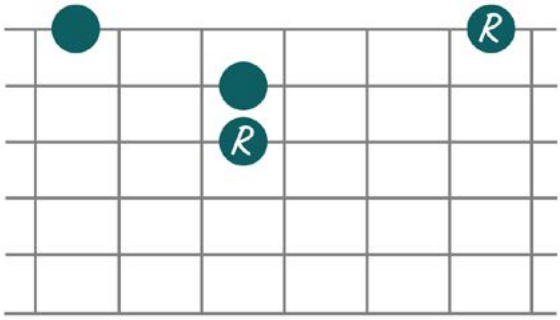
3 shapes of A minor and C major

3 positions, major and minor

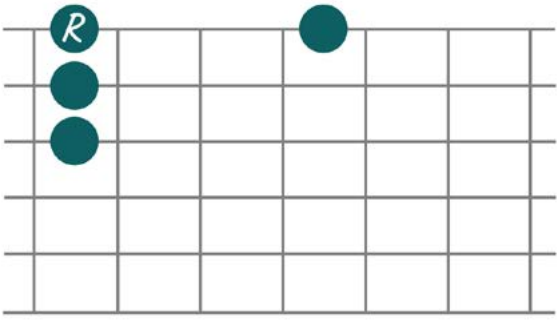
Minor Major

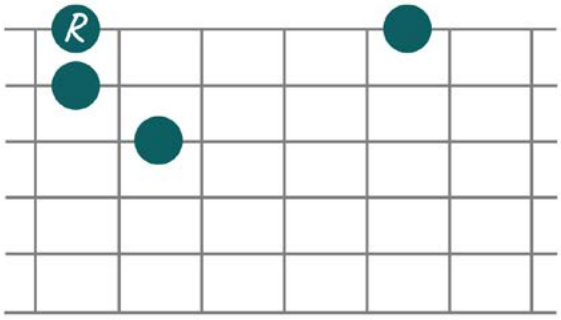
Root position



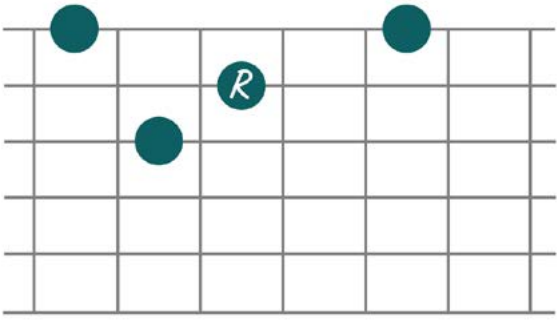


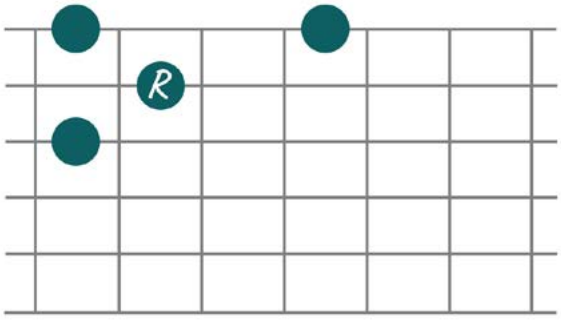
1st inversion





2nd inversion





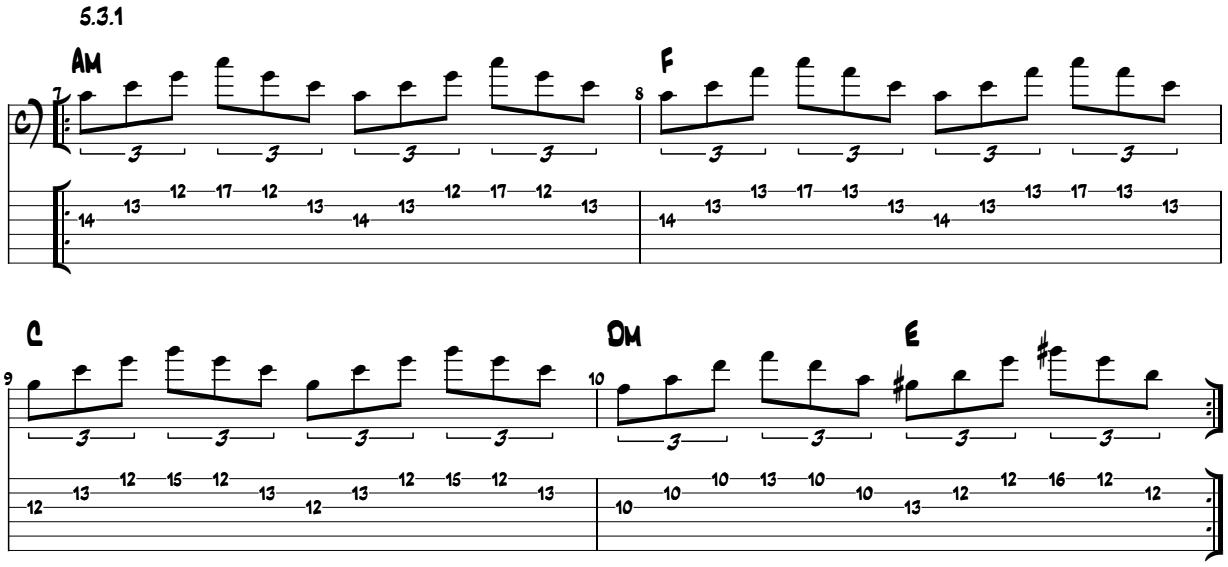
Goal

To play any major or minor arpeggio in 3 positions

Exercise

5.3.1 Arpeggio progression: Am – F – C – Dm – E

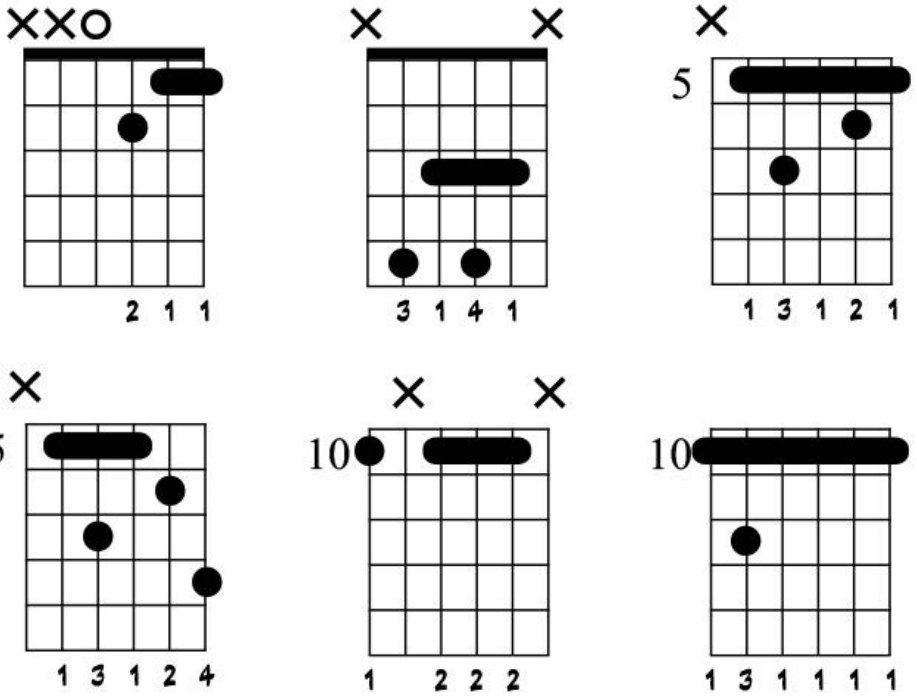
Exercise 5.3.1 Arpeggio progression: Am - F - C - Dm - E



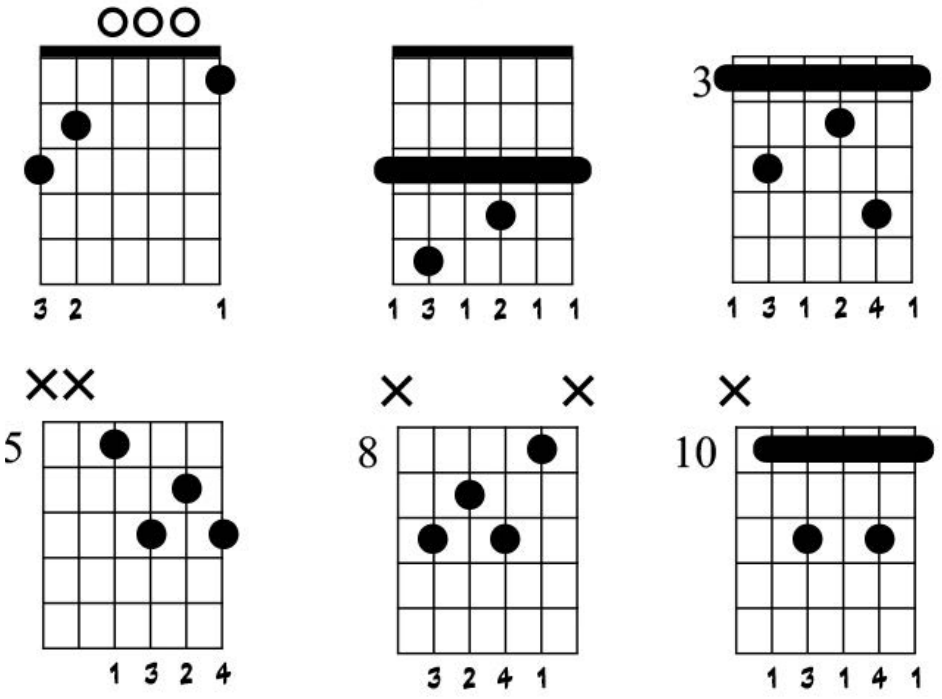
4. Chords: Dm7, G7

Expand your vocabulary with 6 different ways to play these chords

Dm7



G7



Goal

To play from memory the D minor 7 chord in 6 positions, and the G7 chord in 6 positions

Exercises

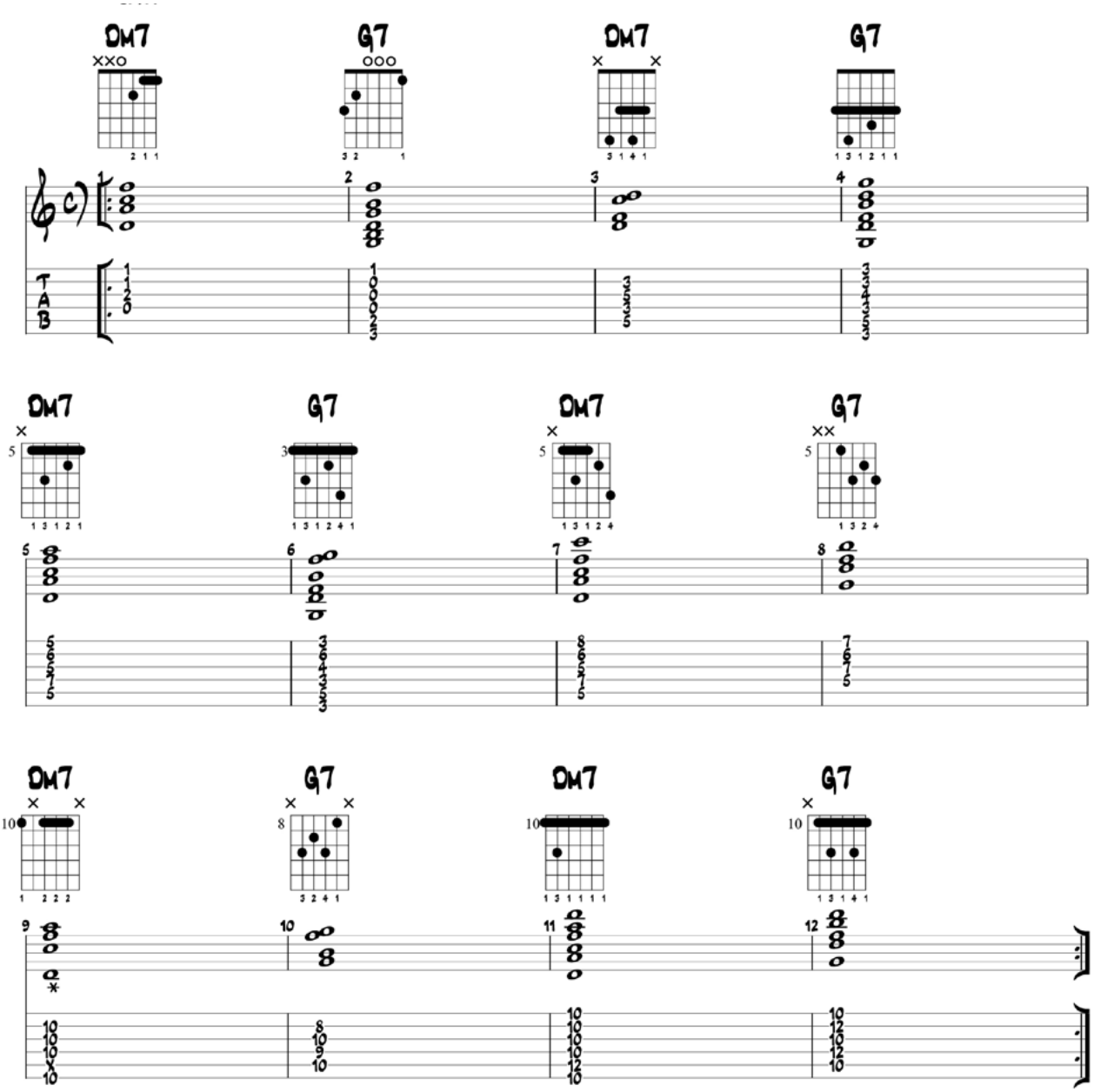
5.4.1 Six positions of Dm7 – G7

Practice with the backing track.

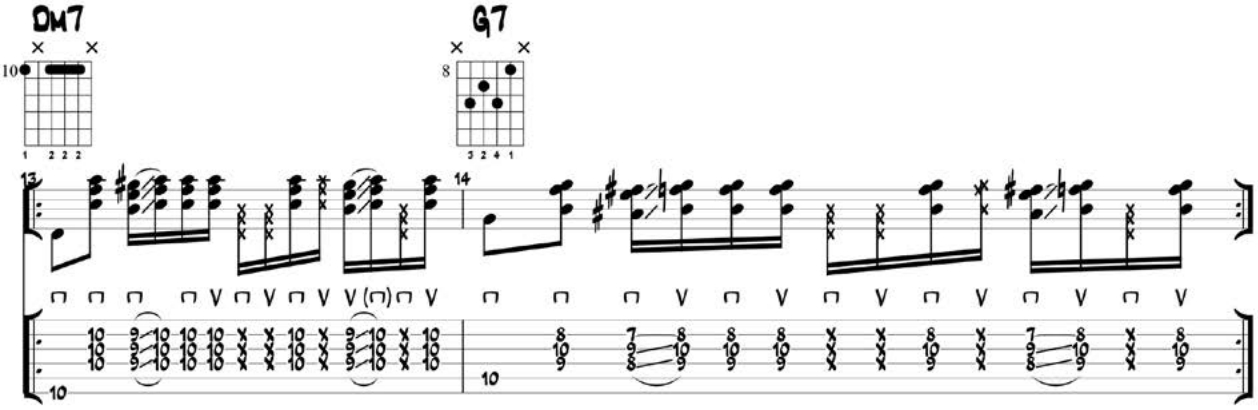
5.4.2 Funky slides

Practice with the backing track.

Exercise 5.4.1 Six positions of Dm7 – G7



Exercise 5.4.2 Funky slides



5. Practical theory: Dorian mode

A great scale to use for blues, funk, and even pop

Guitar terms

Ionian mode: Major scale

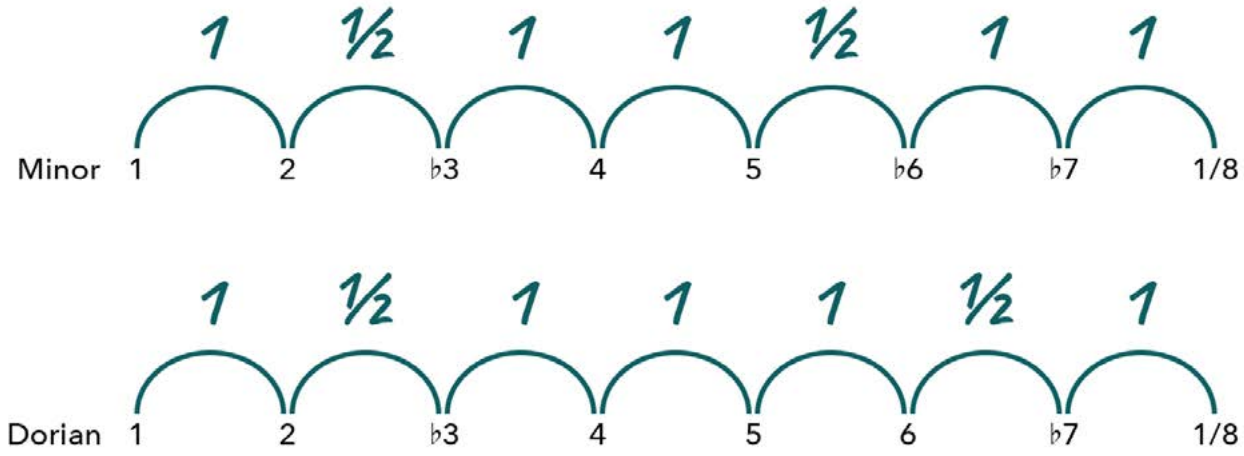
Aeolian mode: Natural minor scale or minor scale

Dorian mode – a recap

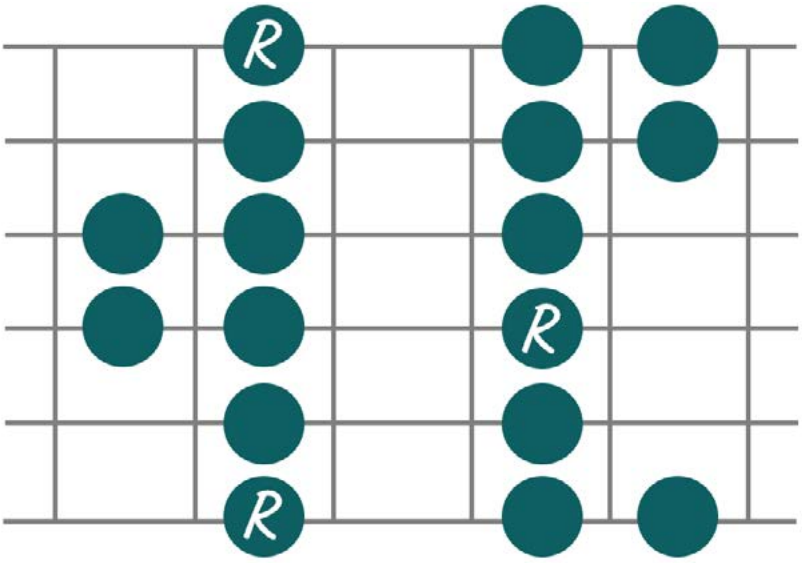
Starting from the root note, this is the sequence of intervals between the notes in a dorian scale:

Whole tone (2 frets)
Semitone (1 fret)
Whole tone (2 frets)
Whole tone (2 frets)
Whole tone (1 fret)
Semitone (1 fret)
Whole tone (2 frets)

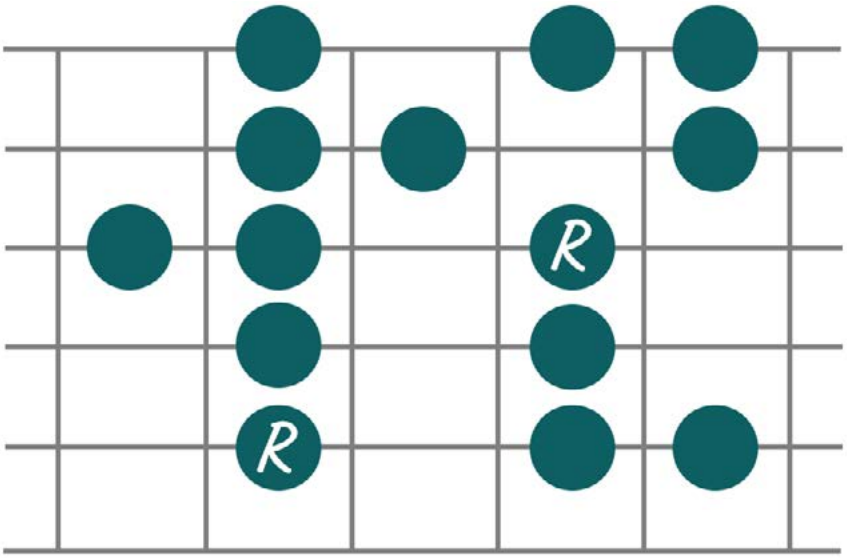
The intervals of the dorian scale compared to the intervals of the minor scale are:



Dorian mode, root on string 6



Dorian mode, root on string 5



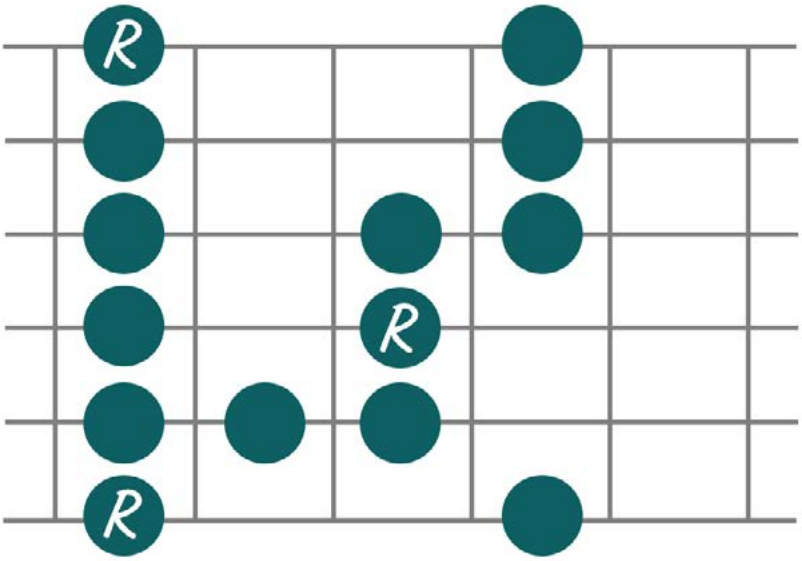
When to use it

The dorian mode is frequently used in blues, funk, and pop music. It is most often heard when the home chord (the “tonic” or the I chord) is minor or minor 7, and the IV chord is major.

For example, over the chords Em – A, notes from the E dorian scale (E – F# – G – A – B – C# – D – E) will sound great. That’s because the major third from the A chord (C#) is the 6 in the key of E.

As another example, a blues shuffle in the key of A made up of the chords A7 – D – E7 is perfectly suited for the dorian mode.

Blues scale



Goal

To know the D dorian scale from memory and feel comfortable improvising with it

Exercise

5.5.1 D dorian scale

Practice this useful scale until you feel comfortable playing it.

5.5.2 Improvise in dorian mode

Using the backing track, improvise licks using the D dorian scale (and add the D minor pentatonic and D blues scale if you wish).

Exercise 5.5.1 D dorian scale

6. Solo: “Dazzling Dorian Funk!”

A cool melody that brings together everything you learned in this lesson

Goal

To nail the solo while keeping up with the backing track

Exercise

5.6.1 Solo: “Dazzling Dorian Funk!”

Get funky with the backing track.

5.6.1 Solo: "Dazzling Dorian Funk!"

Dm7
G7
Dm7
G7
Dm7
G7
Dm7
G7
Dm7
FULL
FULL

Advancing to Level 6

Are you ready to move on? Complete the following questions to help you decide. Grab your guitar, and a pen to write down your answers. You can check the answers in Advancing to Level 6 in the members area.

Level 5 Self test

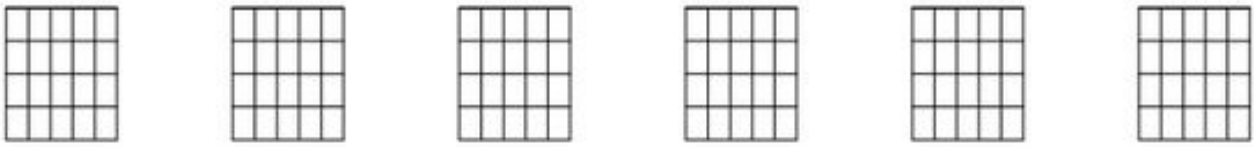
1. Timing
How many 16th notes fit in one beat?

2. Chords
Can you find at least two Dm7 chord shapes from memory?

3. Fretting
Now can you use the hammer-on technique to spice up the Dm7 chord?

4. Arpeggios
Can you play the C major arpeggio in 3 positions from memory?

5. Dorian mode
What is the difference between the minor scale and the dorian scale?



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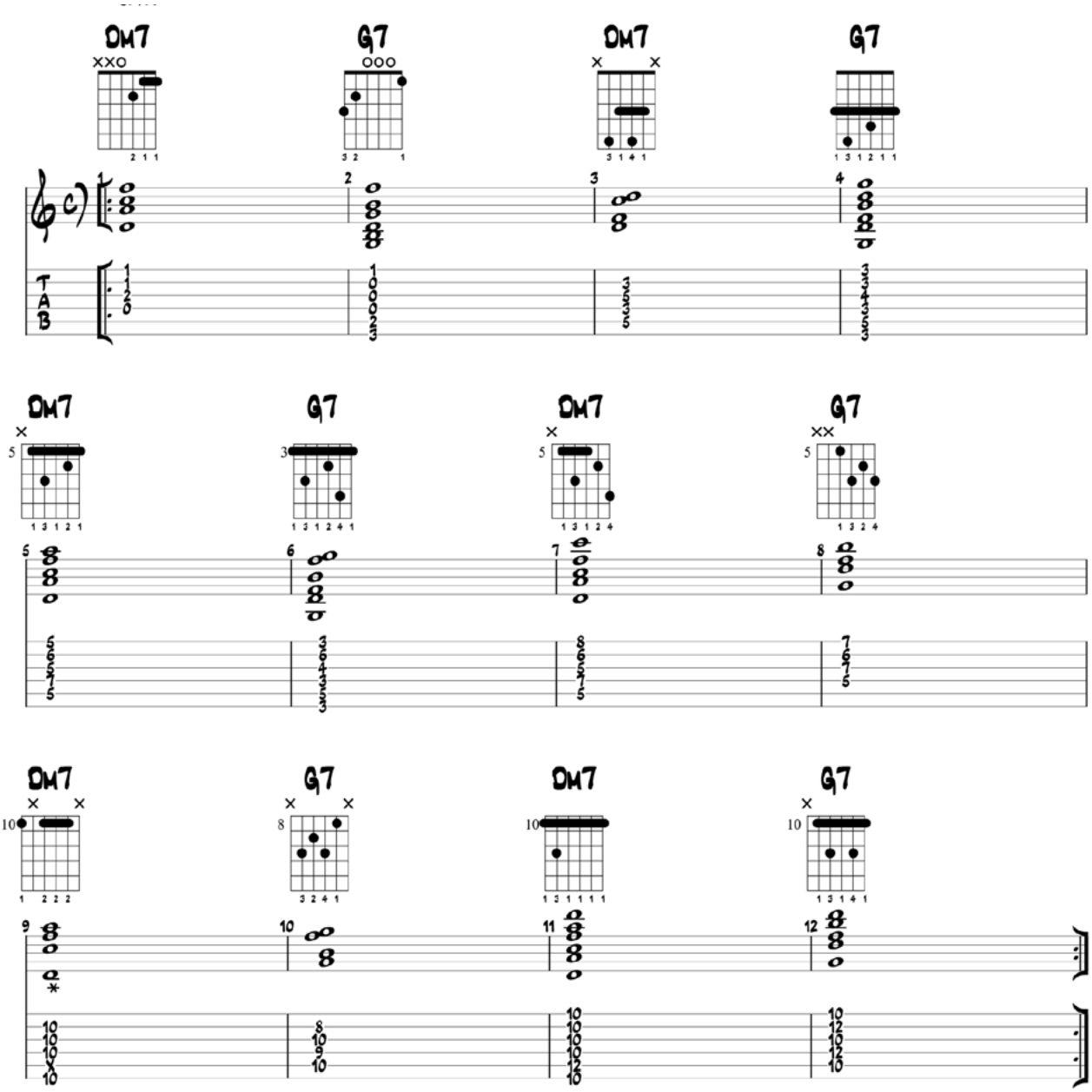
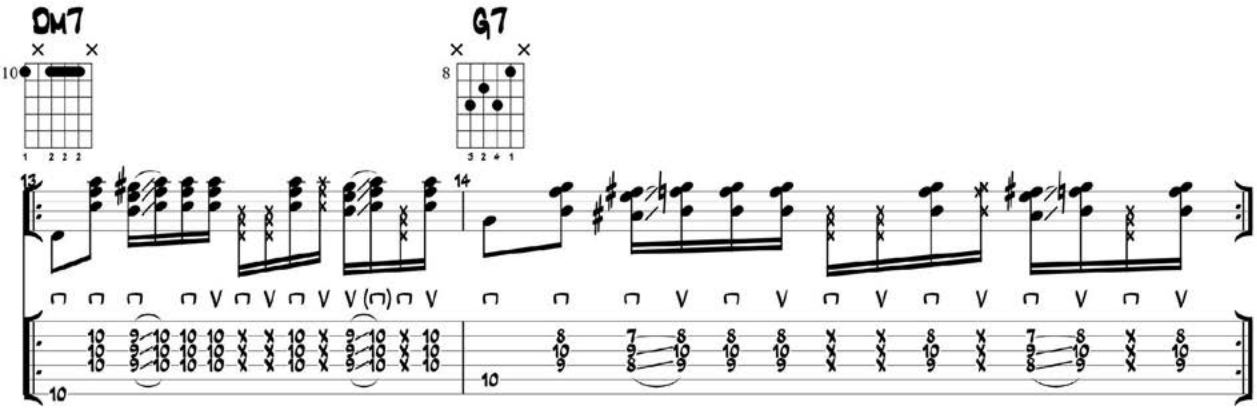
Exercise 5.4.1 Six positions of Dm7 – G7



Exercise 5.4.2 Funky slides



1. Speed and versatility: Diagonal pentatonic scales

Think outside the box and you'll have more options as a guitarist

Goal

To play from memory the G major, E minor, and A minor, and E major pentatonic scales in the diagonal position

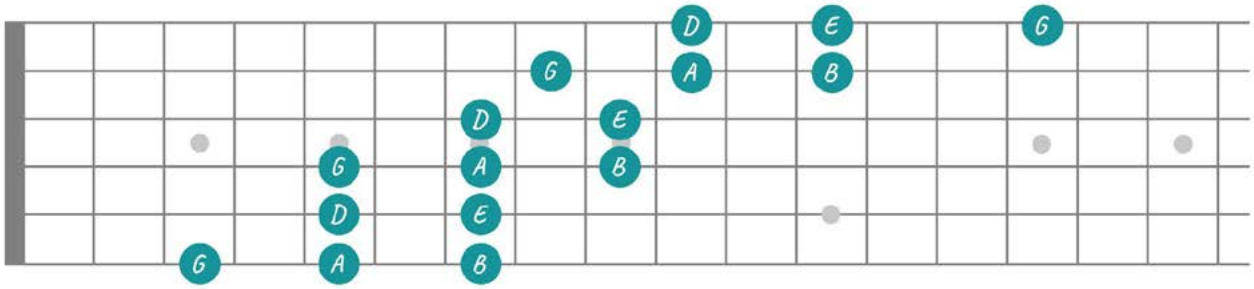
Advanced goal

Play any major or minor pentatonic scale diagonally in any key

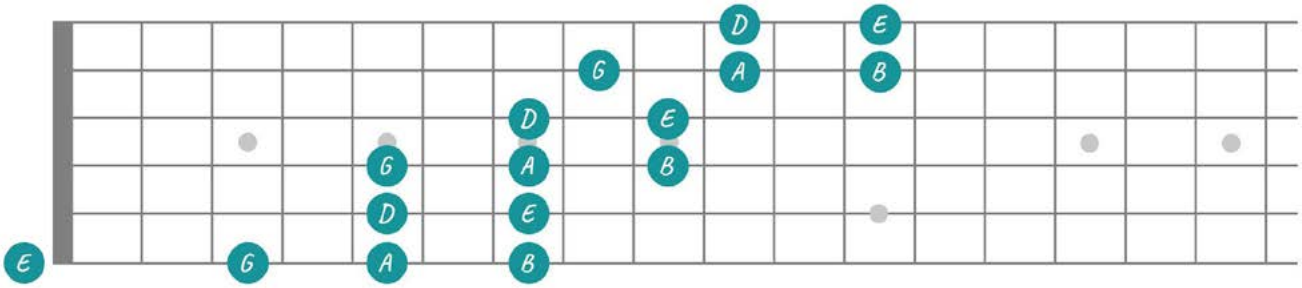
Exercise

6.1.1 Pentatonic scales in the diagonal position

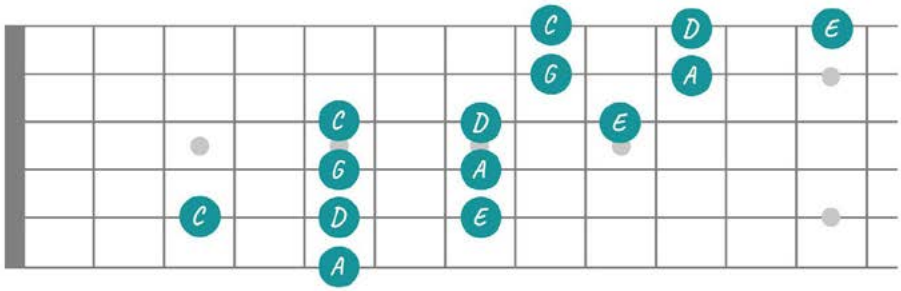
G major pentatonic



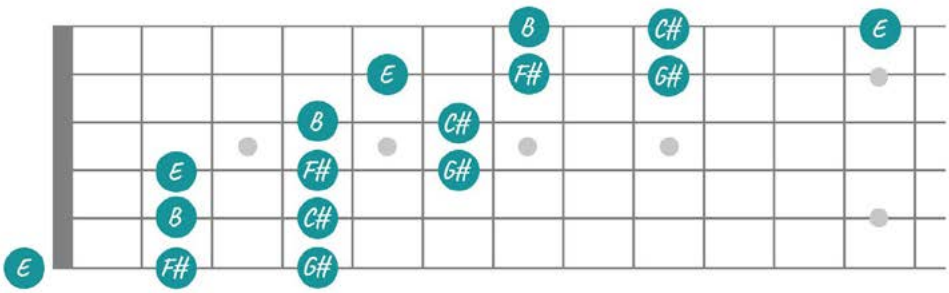
E minor pentatonic



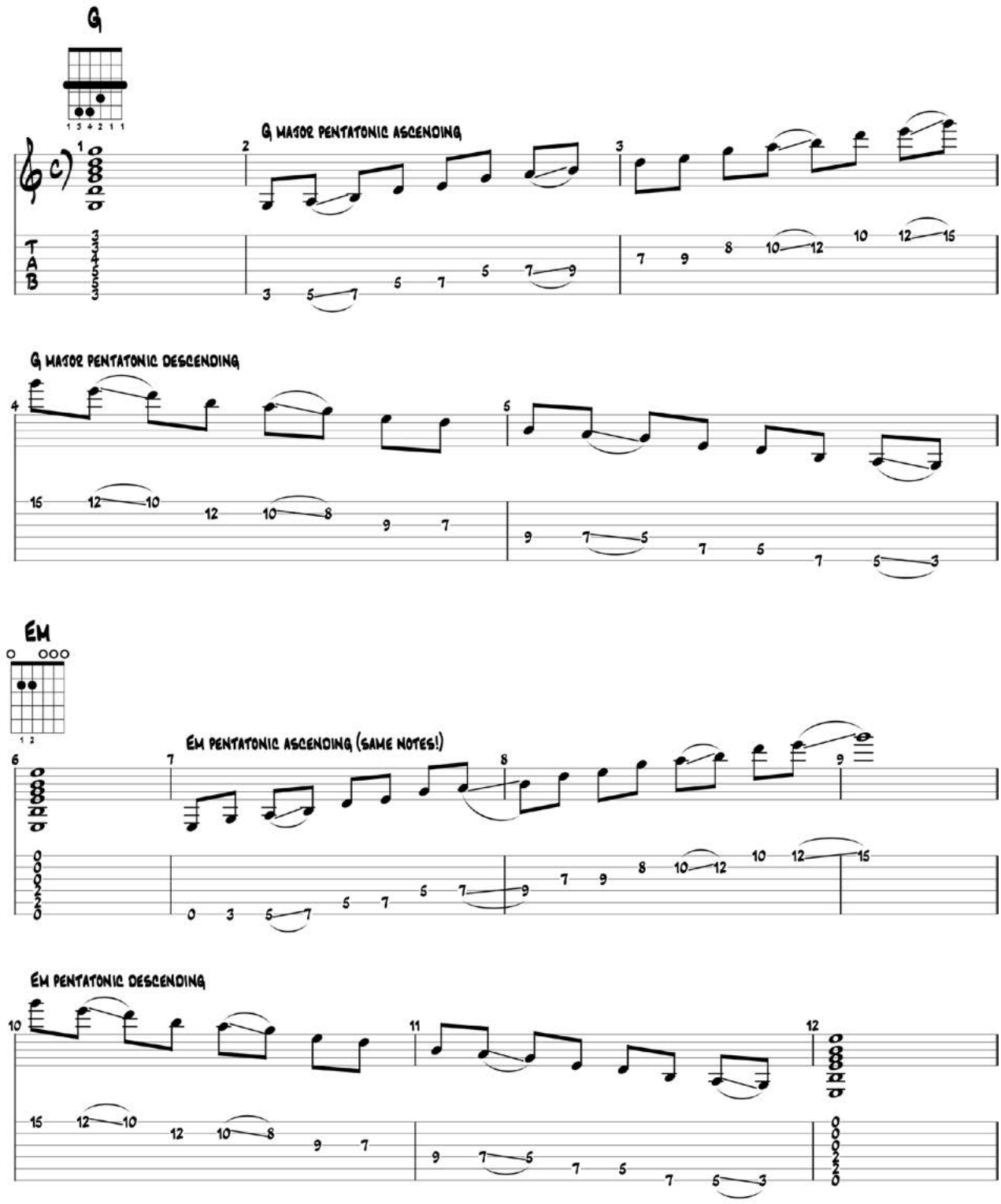
A minor pentatonic

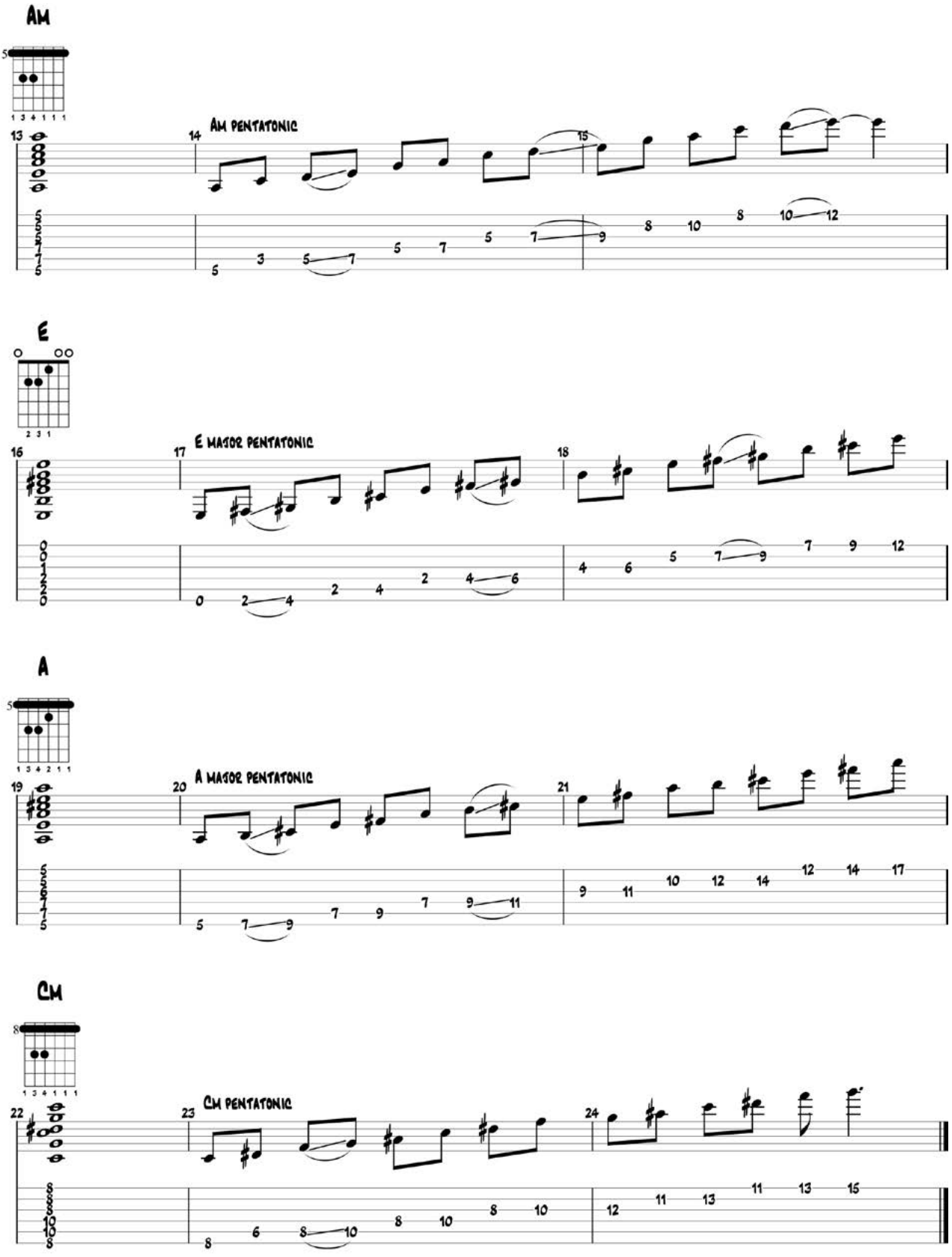


E major pentatonic



Exercise 6.1.1 Pentatonic scales in the diagonal position




Am
Am pentatonic
E
E major pentatonic
A
A major pentatonic
Cm
Cm pentatonic

2. Chords: Embellishments

Spice up chords like Hendrix, Frusciante, and Mayer

Goal

> *To feel confident improvising embellishments over a I – V – vi – IV chord progression*

Pro tip: Use this type of embellishment from time to time, but don't overdo it.

Exercises

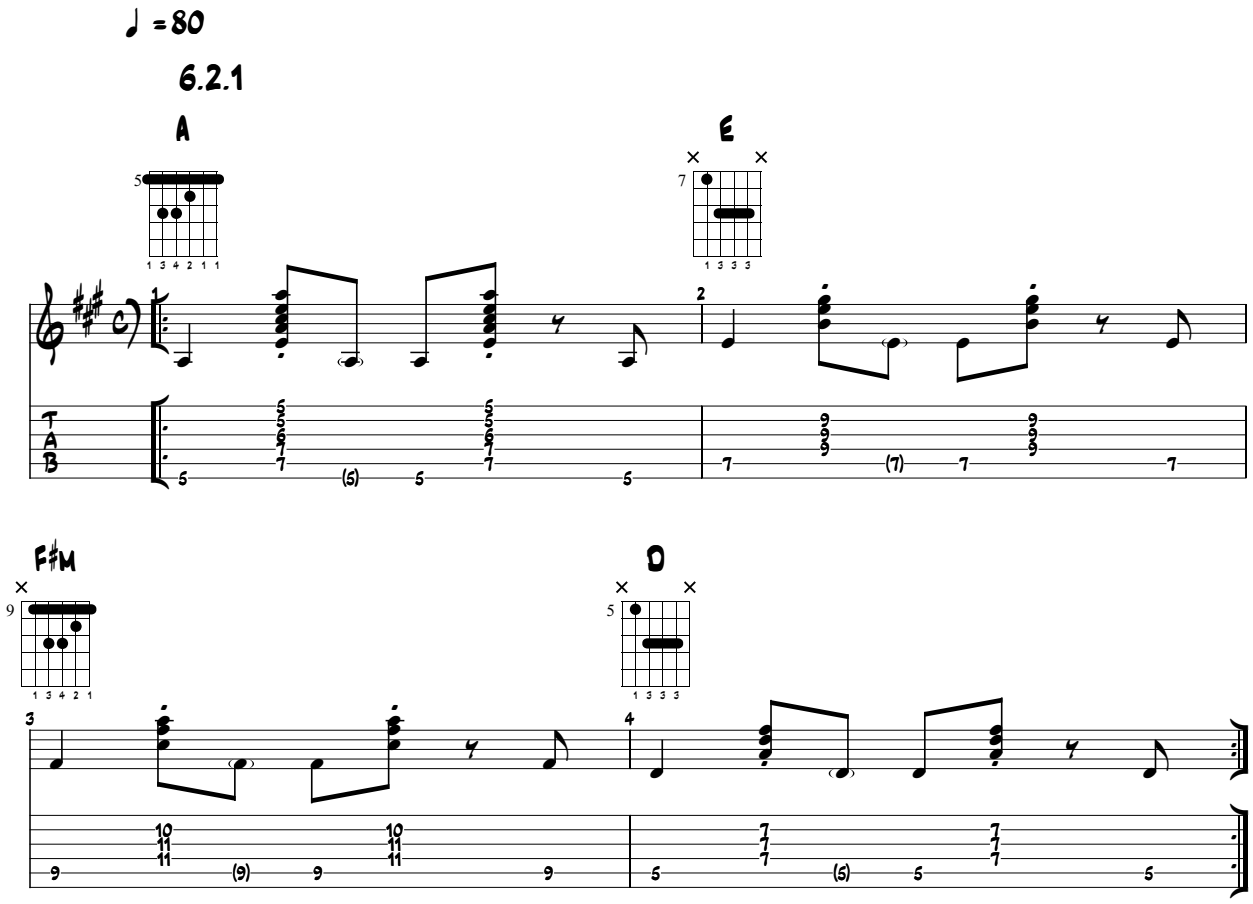
6.2.1 A simple I – V – vi – IV chord progression

Practice this chord progression until you're comfortable with it.

6.2.2 An embellished I – V – vi – IV chord progression

Now practice adding embellishments to the progression from the previous exercise.

Exercise 6.2.1 A simple I – V – vi – IV chord progression



Exercise 6.2.2 An embellished I - V - vi - IV chord progression

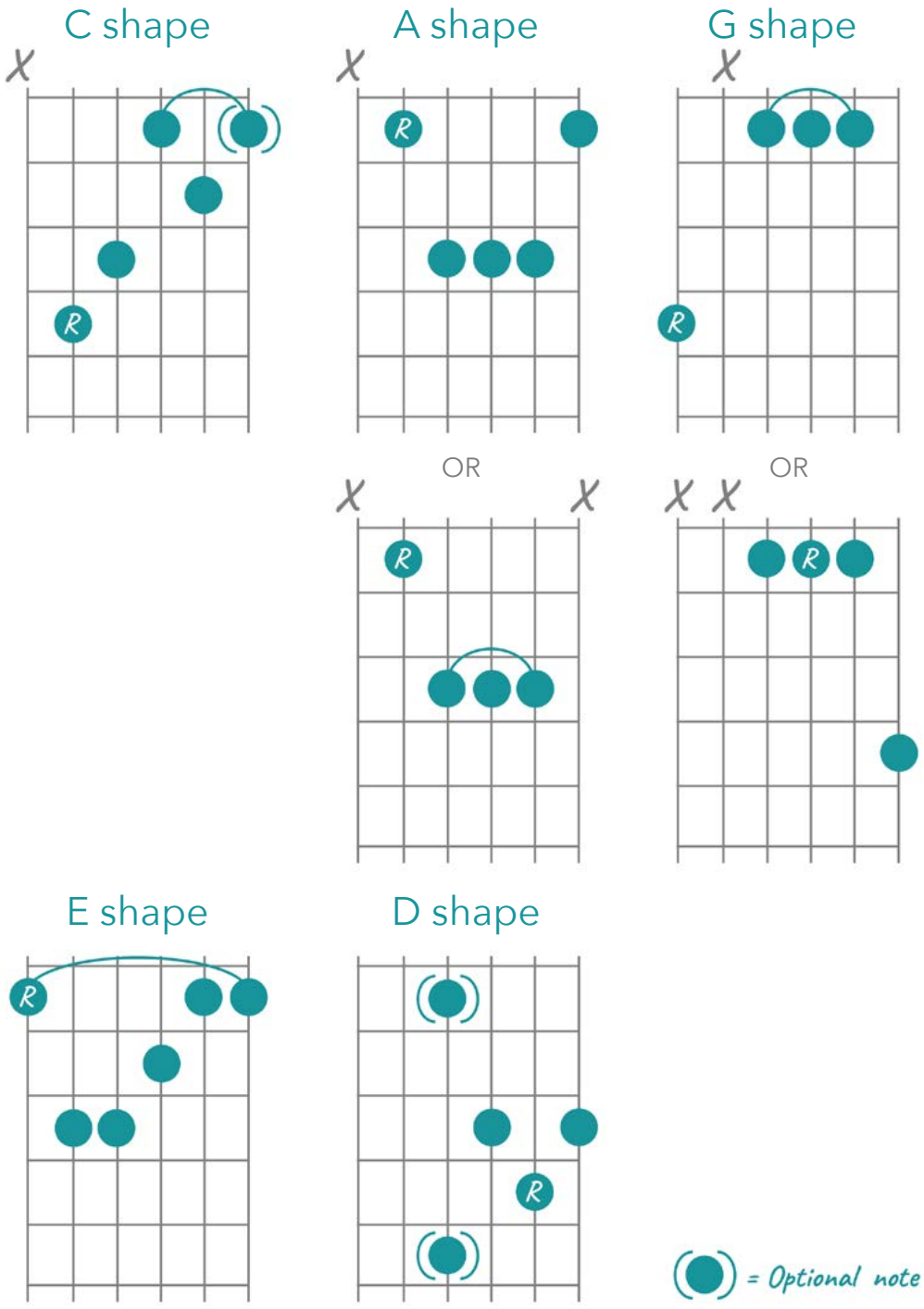
3. Practical theory: The CAGED system

A way to visualize the fretboard and find chords quickly

CAGED – a recap

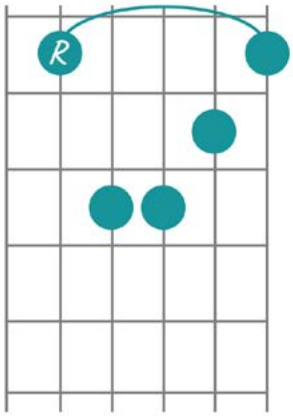
- Use the C, A, G, E, and D open chord shapes to create other chords by playing them as barre chords higher up the neck.
- The G and D shapes need some modifications to be easily played higher up the neck.
- Open Am, Em, and Dm chord shapes can also be moved up the neck to create other minor chords.

Major

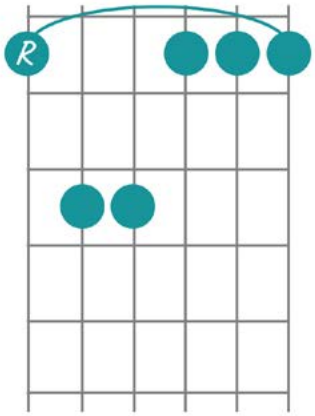


Minor

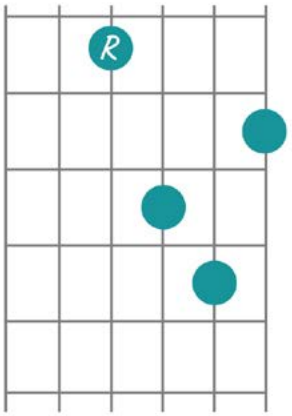
Am shape



Em shape



Dm shape



Goal

To know from memory the chords created by moving the open major chord shapes of C, A, and E.

To play the minor shapes from Am, Em, and Dm up the neck as barre chords

Pro tip: CAGED is only one way of thinking about the fretboard. The most important thing is to find the method that best helps you find chords quickly up and down the neck.

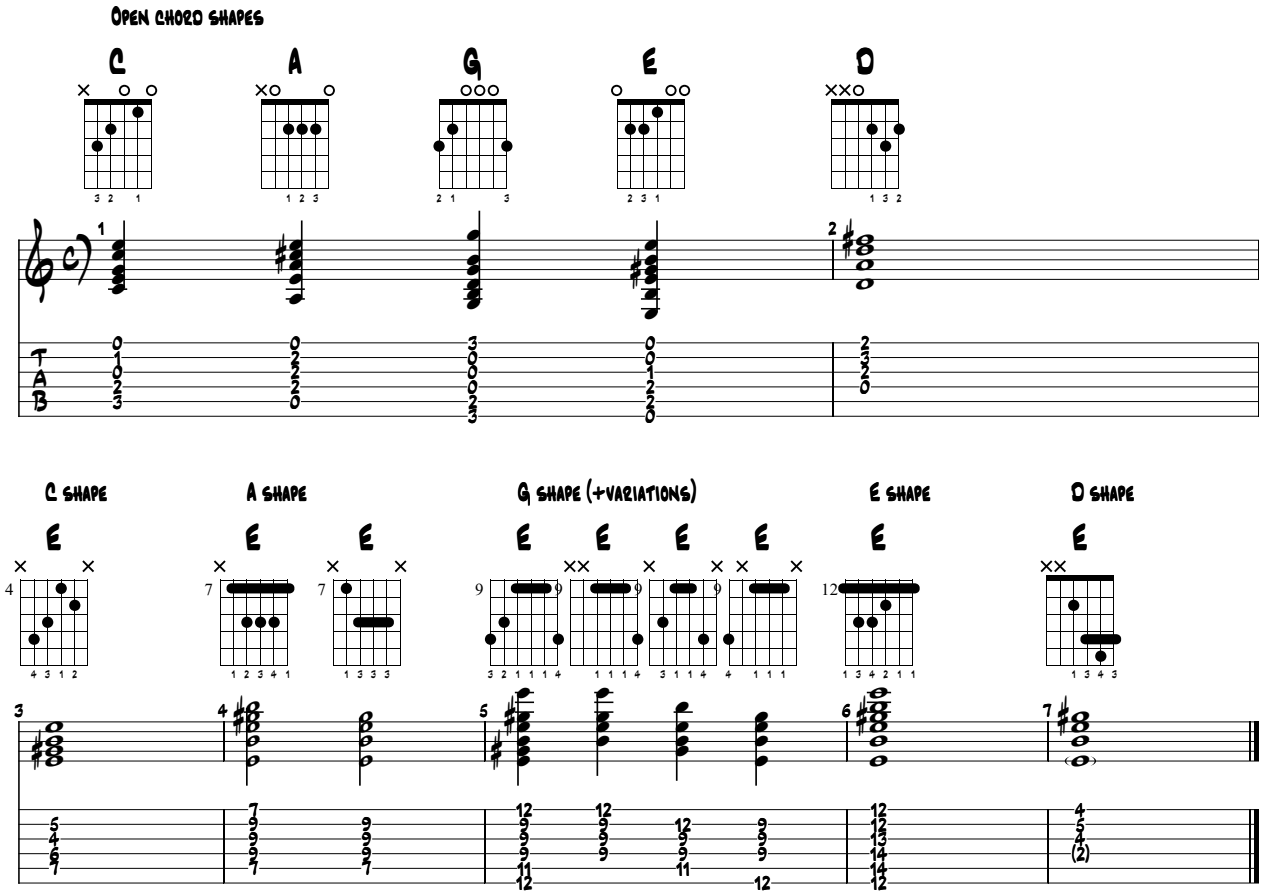
Exercise

6.3.1 CAGED

Try to locate the E major chord lying in 5 different positions on the neck of the guitar.

If you're comfortable doing so, try doing the same for other major chords, such as C, G, and A.

Exercise 6.3.1 CAGED



4. Lead: Target notes

Build drama in your solos by creating and resolving tension

Guitar terms

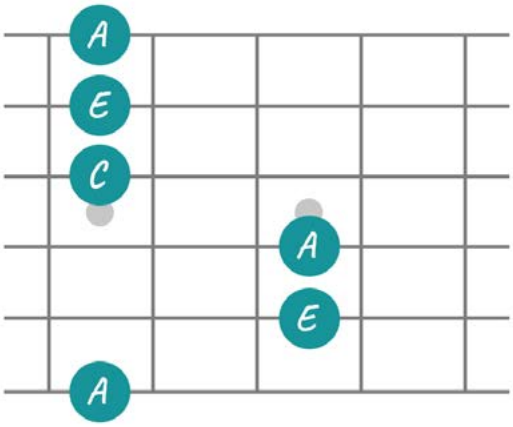
6/8 time: When a bar is divided into six 8th notes, counted as two groups of 8th notes with accents on the one and four, as in "*one* two three / *four* five six."

Target notes – a recap

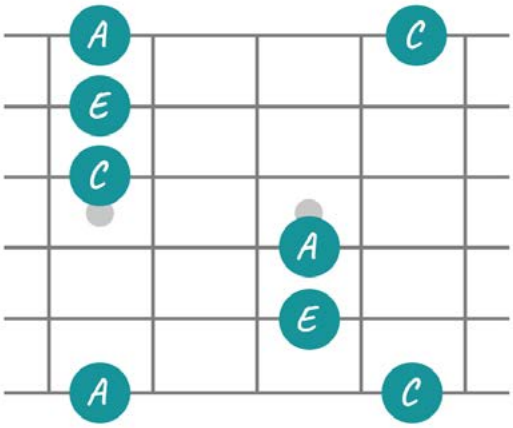
- A target note is any of the notes in the chord that you're playing over.
- A target note sounds resolved to the ear because it's harmonious with the chord and feels like "home."
- Playing a non-target note can grab the listener's attention by creating tension.
- By ending a lick on a target note, you can resolve the tension you created.
- Building and resolving tension in this way can make your solo sound interesting and well thought out.
- You can use the CAGED system to find target notes all along the neck.

Am target notes

Am chord target notes, position 5

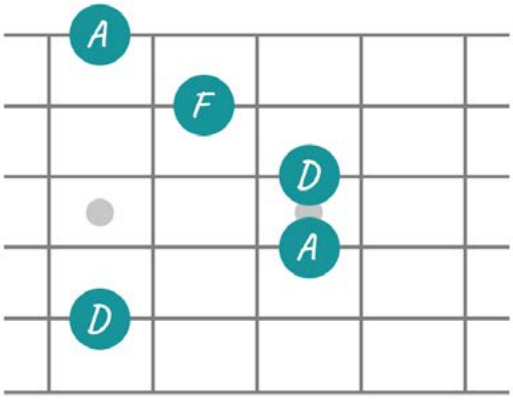


Am arpeggio target notes, position 5

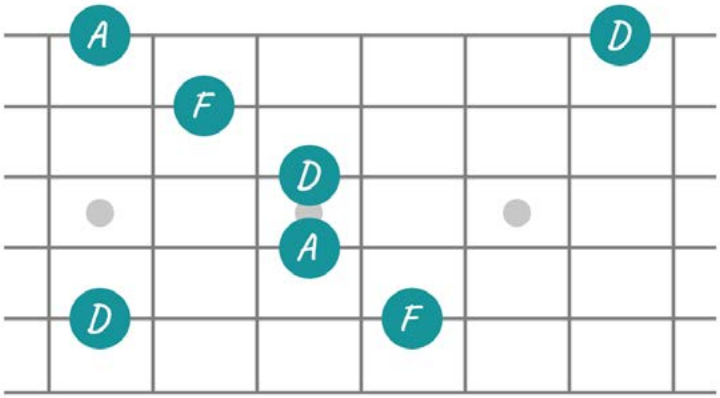


Dm target notes

Dm chord target notes, position 5



Dm arpeggio target notes, position 5



Goal

To be confident using target notes in solos to resolve tension.
To be able to listen to the chords playing underneath your solo and emphasize the notes from these chords so your solos have a more thought-out sound.

Exercises

Exercise 6.4.1 Target note practice

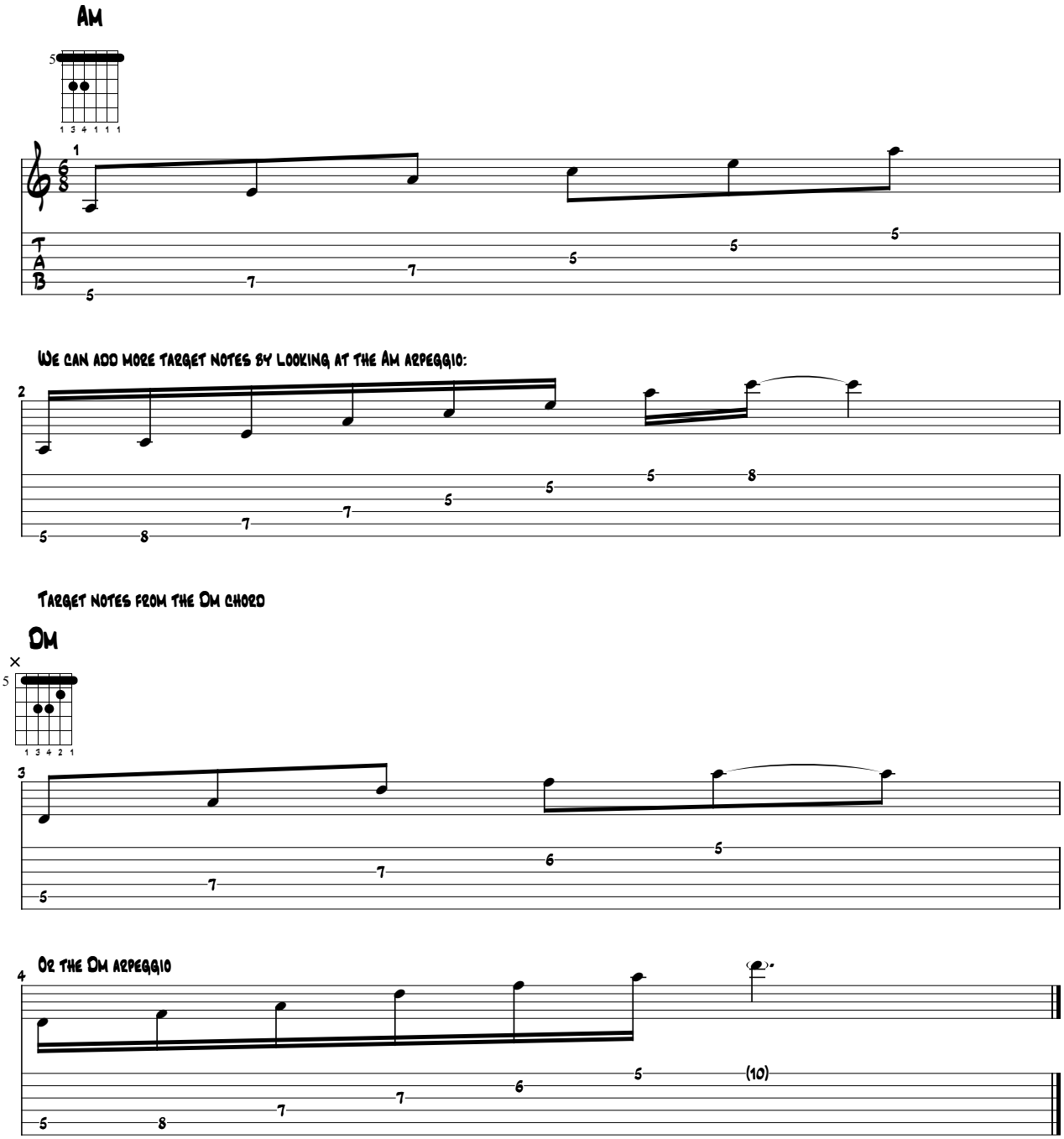
Practice finding and playing the target notes of the Am and Dm chords in the 5th position on the neck. As you get to know the target notes better, try to pick up speed.

Pro tip: Listen to what happens when you add a note from the minor 7 chord to the list of target notes. Over Am (or Am7), the G (the ♭7) could be used as a target note, and it will make the chord sound a little more spicy.

6.4.2 Target note improvisation

Improvise over the backing track. At the start and end of a bar or a chord, play a target note from that chord. In between the target notes, experiment with non-target notes from the A minor scale (natural minor / aeolian), the A minor pentatonic scale, or even the A minor blues scale.

6.4.1 Target note practice



5. Solo: “Target Blues in Am”

Target notes, the harmonic minor, chord embellishments – get ready to bring all these skills together

Goal

To feel confident playing the solo and then improvising over the backing track

Exercise

6.5.1 Solo: “Target Blues in Am”

Play the solo, and then have some fun improvising over it using everything you’ve learned so far.

Target Blues in Am

Advancing to Level 7

Are you ready to move on? Complete the following questions to help you decide. Grab your guitar, and a pen to write down your answers. You can check the answers in Advancing to Level 7 in the members area.

Level 6 Self test

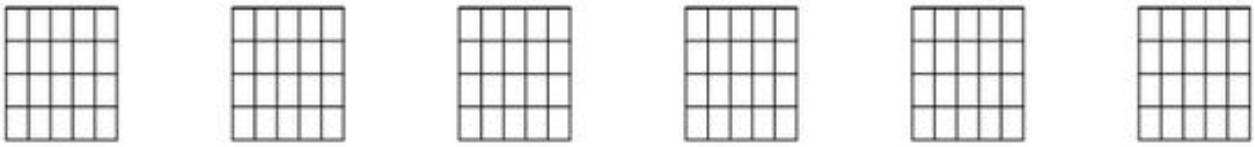
1. Pentatonic scales in diagonal position
Can you play at least 2 of these scales from memory in the diagonal position: G major, E minor, and A minor pentatonic?

2. Chord embellishment
Do you know how to use the sixth interval to embellish any major chord?

3. CAGED
Play the open A chord, then turn it into a barre chord and move it up the neck, naming each new chord it creates.

4. Target notes
What are the target notes when soloing over the D minor chord?

5. Solo and improvisation
In the key of Am, name an arpeggio or scale you could play over the E7 chord?



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1. Chords: Twelve-bar blues

Seven ways to play this fundamental chord progression

Guitar terms

Blue note: A note that creates tension. Often it's a lower pitch than would be expected. For example, playing the minor 3rd over a major or dominant seventh chord (a C over an A7 chord).

Twelve-bar blues chord progression – a recap

These are the chord degrees to play in any given key:

Bars 1–4	I
Bars 5–6	IV
Bars 7–8	I
Bar 9	V
Bar 10	IV
Bar 11	I
Bar 12	V

Goal

To be able to play 12-bar blues in any key, in one or more of the ways shown in the video

Exercise

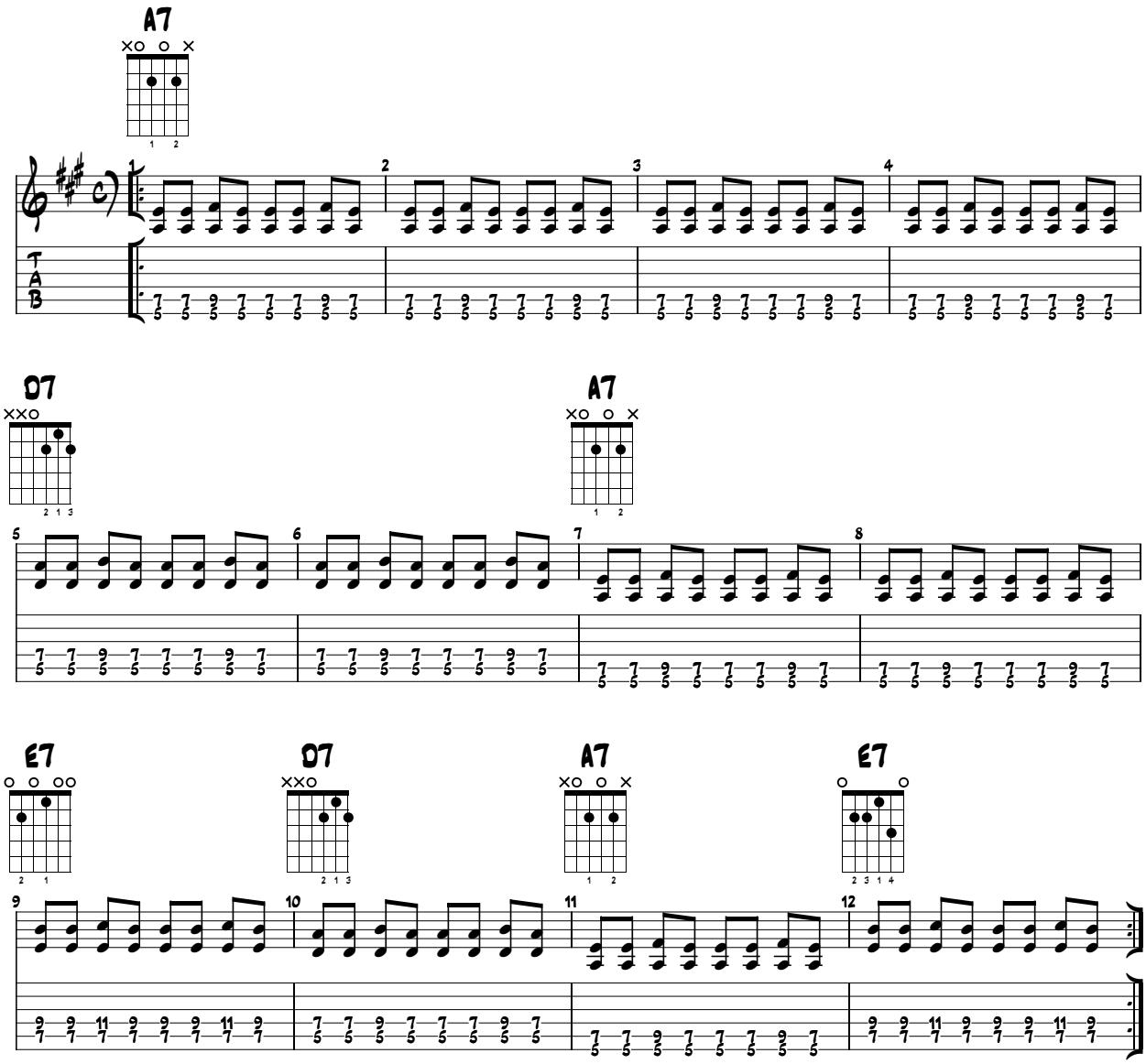
7.1.1 Standard 12-bar blues in A

Tabs of the 12-bar blues for you to practice.

7.1.2 Seven ways to play 12-bar blues in A

In the tabs, I've started you out with the first 4 bars of each variation on the 12-bar blues. Your task is to work out the IV and V chords and play the whole 12 bars in the style I demonstrated in the lesson.

Exercise 7.1.1 Standard 12-bar blues in A



Exercise 7.1.2 Seven ways to play 12-bar blues in A

5
A7
6
A7
7

2. Lead: Mixolydian scales

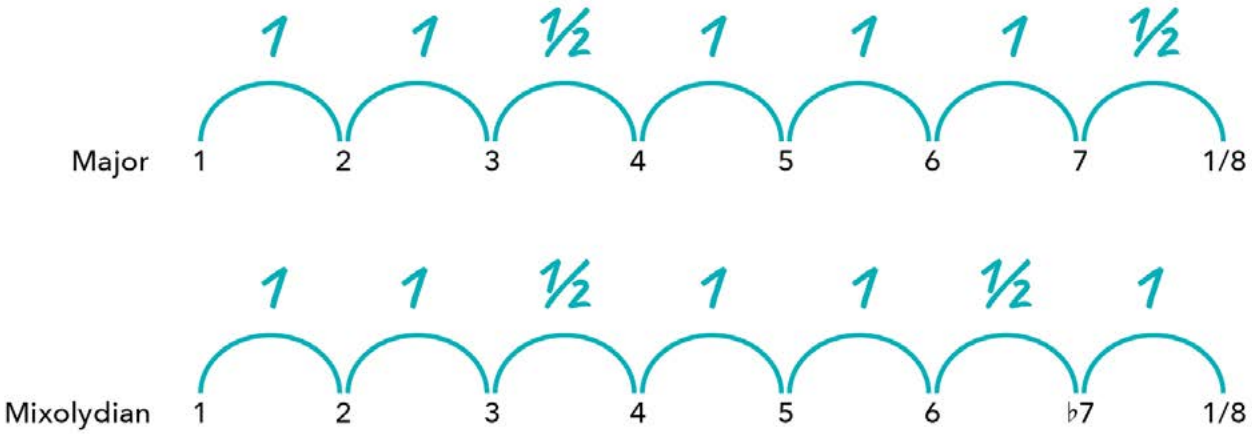
Add to your repertoire when playing over 7th chords

Mixolydian mode – a recap

Starting from the root note, this is the sequence between the notes in a mixolydian scale:

Whole tone (2 frets)
Whole tone (2 frets)
Semitone (1 fret)
Whole tone (2 frets)
Whole tone (2 frets)
Semitone (1 fret)
Whole tone (2 frets)

The intervals of the mixolydian scale compare to the intervals of the major scale like this:



Tips

- The mixolydian scale is also called the dominant scale, because it fits well over dominant seventh chords.
- Mixolydian can be a great choice for blues, as most blues music is based on seventh chords.

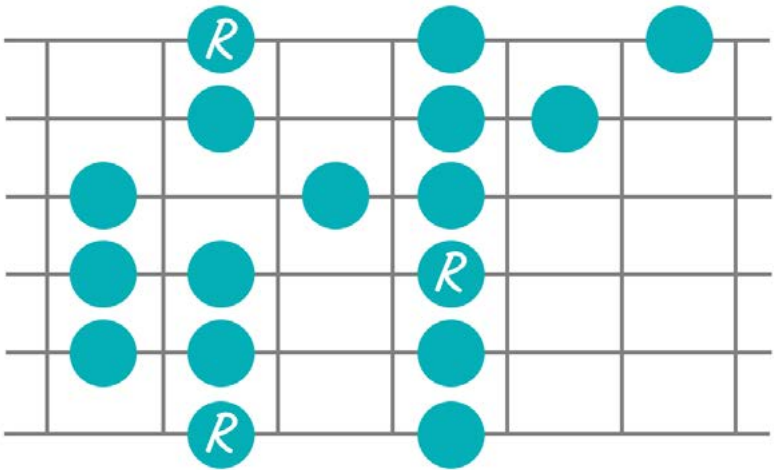
The modes compared

MODE	STARTS ON	FUNCTIONS	E.G.: C MAJOR	NOTES OF SCALE
Ionian (major)	1st scale degree	1 – 2 – 3 – 4 – 5 – 6 – 7 – 1/8	C	C – D – E – F – G – A – B – C
Dorian	2nd scale degree of major	1 –2 – ♭3 – 4 – 5 – 6 – ♭7 – 1/8	D	D – E – F – G – A – B – C – D
Mixolydian	5th scale degree of major	1 – 2 – 3 – 4 – 5 – 6 – ♭7 – 1/8	G	G – A – B – C – D – E – F – G
Aeolian (natural minor)	6th scale degree of major	1 – 2 – ♭3 – 4 – 5 – ♭6 – ♭7 – 1/8	A	A – B – C – D – E – F – G – A

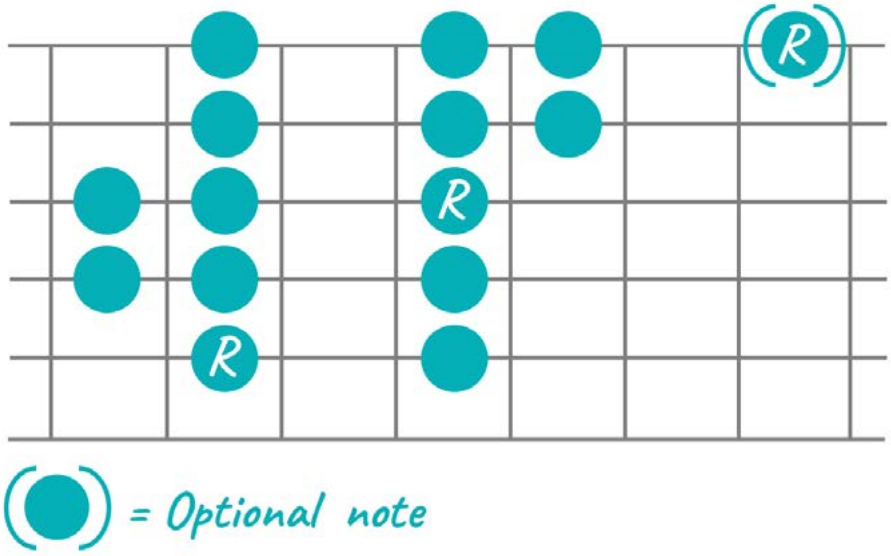
The A mixolydian scale

- The mixolydian scale is also called the dominant scale, because it fits well over dominant seventh chords.
- Mixolydian can be a great choice for blues, as most blues music is based on seventh chords.

Root on the 6th string



Root on the 5th string



Goal

To be able to play the A mixolydian scale from memory and use it in improvisation

Advanced goal

To be able to play the mixolydian scale in two positions in any key

Exercises

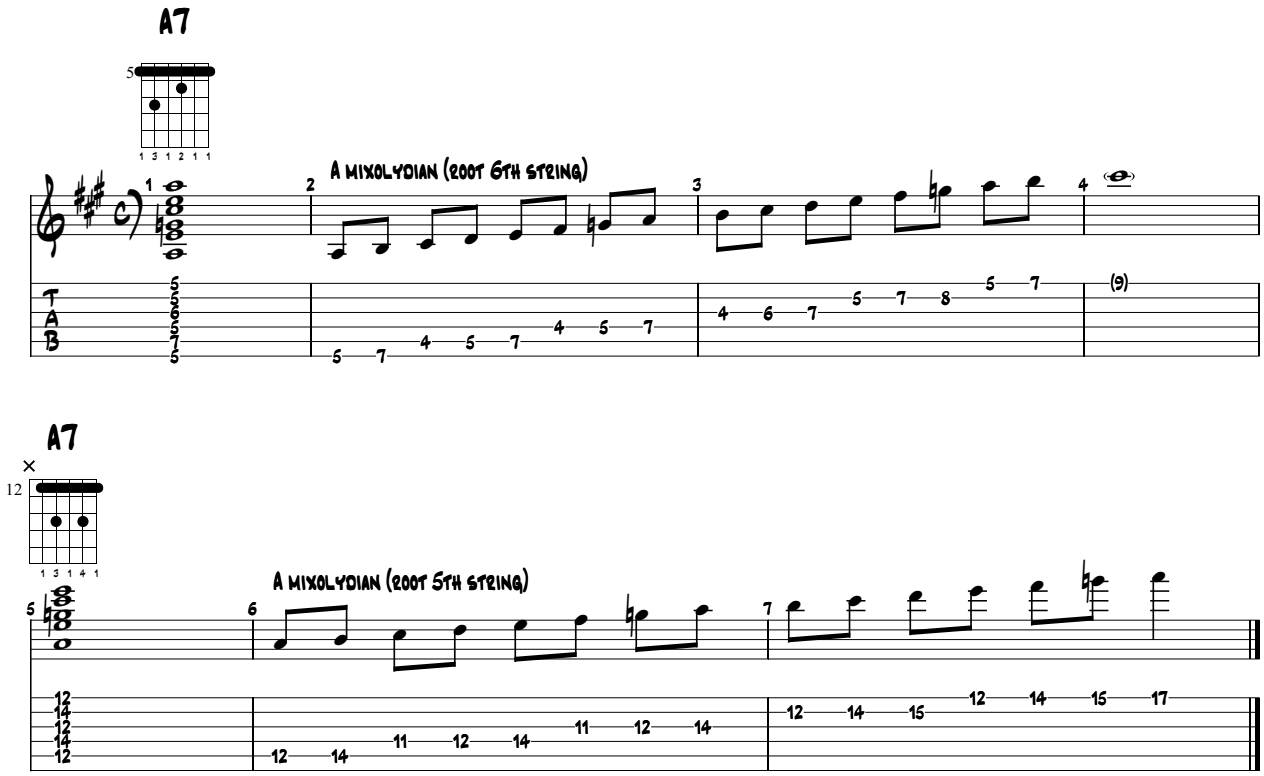
7.2.1 The A mixolydian scale

Pro tip: link the scale you're playing to the chord shown in the tabs. So for this exercise, link the A mixolydian scale to the A7 chords. Play the scale in two positions: with the root on the 6th string, and with the root on the 5th string.

7.2.2. Improvisation with the A mixolydian scale

Experiment with playing notes from the A mixolydian scale over the backing track.

Exercise 7.2.1 The A mixolydian scale



3. Improvisation: Twelve-bar blues

Four ways to take the lead in one of the most iconic music genres

Guitar terms

Passing note (or passing tone): A non-harmonic note that is used as an embellishment, as a part of a melody, or to transition between notes

Key center: The chords that make up a key belong to one key center

Tips

- Using the minor pentatonic scale or minor blues scale is one of the easiest and best ways to solo over the blues.
- When soloing over a blues progression, don't overthink it.
- It's less about following rules and more about listening to how it sounds.

Goal

To feel confident improvising over 12-bar blues using one or more of the techniques in the video

Exercise

7.3.1 Twelve-bar blues improvisation

Play over the backing track and experiment with the techniques I covered in the video:

1. Minor pentatonic or minor blues scale. If you're new to the blues, you can stick with this. After all, there are some blues greats who use nothing but these scales.
2. Dorian scale. Here we add two notes to the minor pentatonic scale: the 2 and the 6. The 6 is perfect to stress the IV chord in the blues. The 2 is great for the V chord.
3. Play different scales over the different chord degrees. Play major pentatonic on the I chord, minor pentatonic on the IV chord, and a seventh arpeggio on the V chord. For example, in the key of A, you would play: A major pentatonic on the A7 chord, A minor pentatonic on the D 7 chord, and an E7 arpeggio on the V chord.
4. Use the modes. Use the mixolydian scale on every chord. There are two ways to look at it: 1) Look at it from the perspective of each chord – e.g., in the key of A, play A mixolydian on the I chord, D mixolydian on the IV chord, and E mixolydian on the V chord. 2) Look at it from the perspective of the key center. In the case of A, that would be: A mixolydian over the I chord, A dorian over the IV chord, and A major over the V chord.

Pro tip: Combine techniques to create the distinctive sound you want.

4. Chords: Extended chords

Demystifying some of the more complex chord types

Scale degrees - a recap

- We number the first note of a scale as 1.
- The 8 is the same note as the 1 except one octave higher.
- We can continue counting up. For example:

9	2nd note of the scale, one octave higher
11	4th note of the scale, one octave higher
13	6th note of the scale, one octave higher

- The 9th, 11th, and 13th intervals can be added to chords to create different types of chords.

Chord types - a recap

Triads

A triad had 3 unique notes:

- Major: 1 – 3 – 5
- Minor: 1 – ♭3 – 5

Add chords

An add chord is a triad with a note added from the next octave of the scale. Some examples:

Cadd9: 1 – 3 – 5 – 9
Cadd11: 1 – 3 – 5 – 11
Cadd13*: 1 – 3 – 5 – 13

*The Cadd13 is usually called C6, because the 6 is already higher than the notes from the chord, and the 13 and the 6 are the same notes.

Seventh chords

A seventh chord has 4 unique notes:

- Major 7: 1 – 3 – 5 – 7
- 7 (or dominant 7): 1 – 3 – 5 – ♭7
- Minor 7: 1 – ♭3 – 5 – ♭7

Extended chords

- An extended chord is a seventh chord with an interval (or intervals) added from the next octave of the scale.
- Leave out some notes to achieve the sound you want, depending on the song.
- It's essential to leave notes out of chords that have more than 6 notes (e.g., Cmaj13).
- Some examples:

Chord name	Scale intervals
Cmaj9	1 – 3 – 5 – 7 – 9
Cmaj11	1 – 3 – 5 – 7 – 9 – 11
Cmaj13	1 – 3 – 5 – 7 – 9 – 11 – 13
C9	1 – 3 – 5 – ♭7 – 9
C11	1 – 3 – 5 – ♭7 – 9 – 11
C13	1 – 3 – 5 – ♭7 – 9 – 11 – 13
Cm9	1 – ♭3 – 5 – ♭7 – 9
Cm11	1 – ♭3 – 5 – ♭7 – 9 – 11
Cm13	1 – ♭3 – 5 – ♭7 – 9 – 11 – 13

Pro tip

Rather than trying to remember all the voicings of the extended chords:

- Learn the 9th, 11th, and 13th scale intervals for chords with the root on the low E string or on the A string.
- Experiment with how it sounds when you add these notes as extensions to those chords.

Goal

To be able to extend chords with the root on the low E string or the A string with the 9th, 11th, and 13th extensions

Exercises

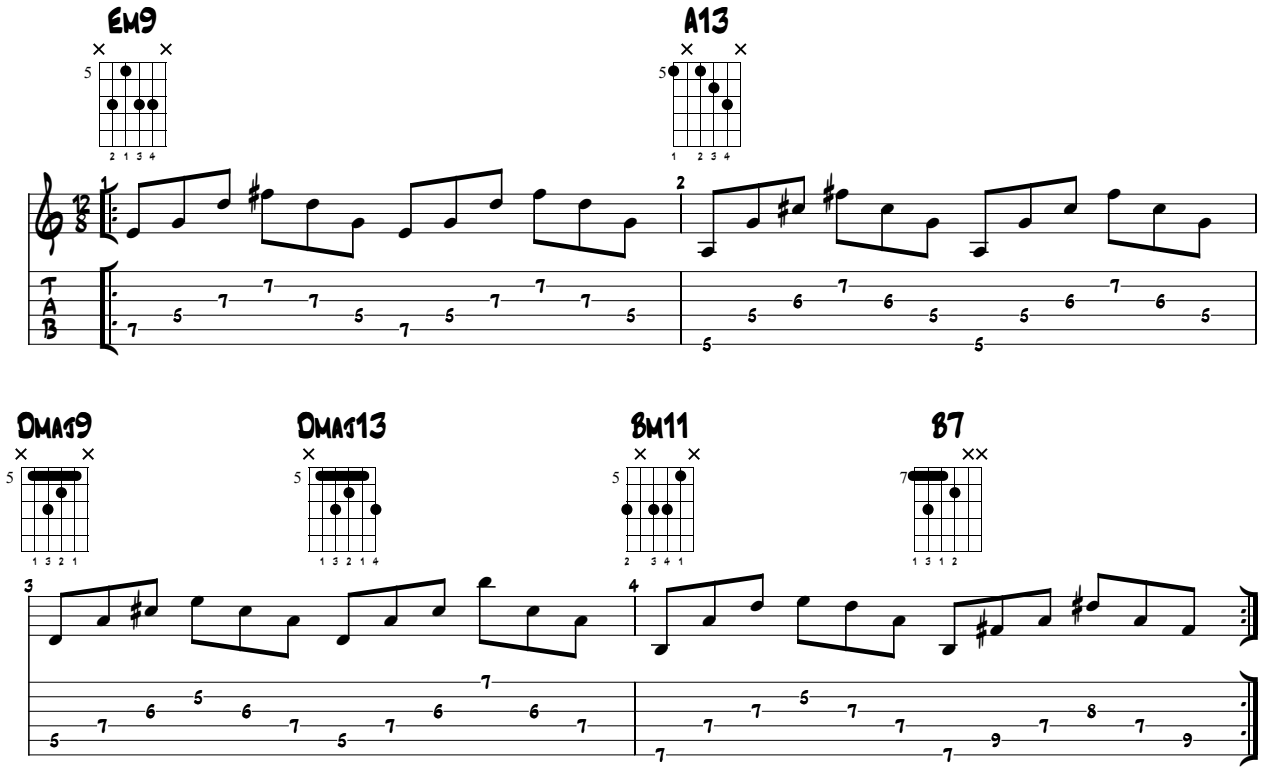
7.4.1 Chord progression in Em

Practice a chord progression that uses extended chords.

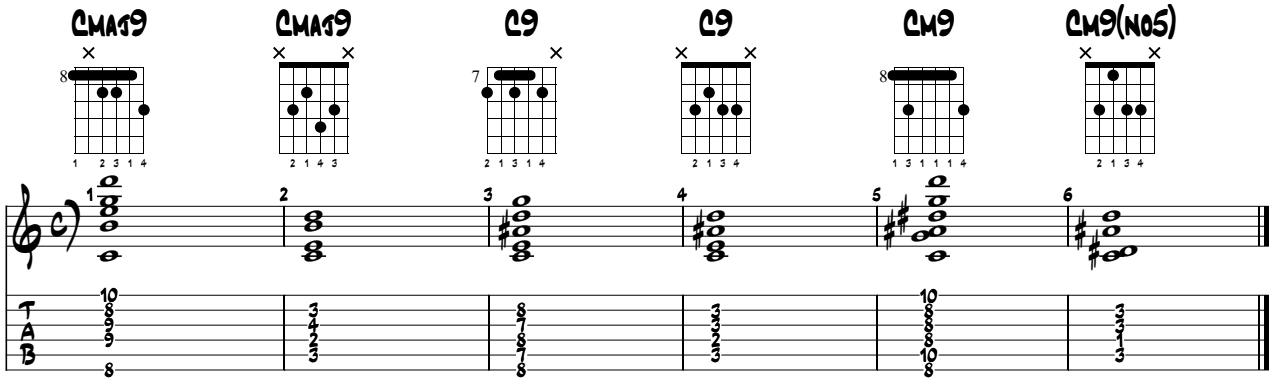
7.4.2 Learn Cmaj9, C9, and Cm9

Hone your skills with this set of extended chords.

Exercise 7.4.1 Chord progression in Em



Exercise 7.4.2 Learn Cmaj9, C9, and Cm9



5. Solo: “Everything Is Connected”

Draw on all the skills you’ve learned in the course and see just far you’ve come

Goal

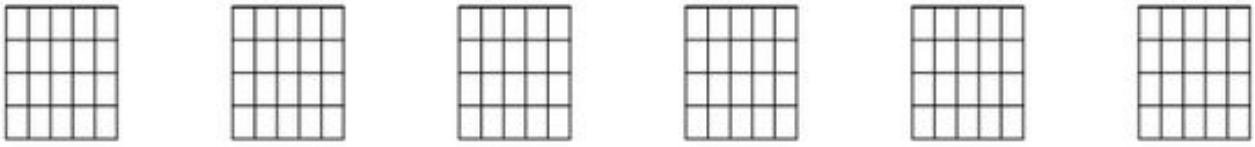
To feel confident playing the solo

Exercise

Exercise 7.5.1 Solo: “Everything Is Connected”

Pro tip: To keep developing as a player, it’s a good idea to come back to this solo or to any of the other exercises in the course. That way you can refine your technique over time, plus keep everything fresh in your memory.

7.5.1 Solo: "Everything Is Connected"



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